

# Fate's Edge

## The Eastern Realms

Chen Wei, Provincial Censor of the Eastern Circuit  
(with marginalia by a tired quill)

June 4, 2026

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# Preface: The Censor's Report

*My brush is heavier than any sword. A single stroke can erase a name, a family, a dynasty. The emperor reads my reports and trembles. He knows that I have written nine reports this year. The ninth is about him.*

The Eastern Realms are not a mystery. They are a bureaucracy with a coastline. Sihai measures its emperors in centuries, its canals in miles, its failures in erased names. Nihori counts in storms and sword-strokes. Ayokha negotiates with the monsoon.

I have travelled the length of the Mandate. I have sat in examination halls where candidates wept into their inkstones. I have stood on the Bridge of Three Echoes, where the dead ask for nothing but a story. I have watched a Nihori duelist bow to an opponent he had just killed, because the form was correct.

You will find no ledger here – not in the sense you expect. The East does not deal in interest. It deals in memory, in ritual, in the weight of a name properly recorded. A debt is not a number. It is a crack in a keystone, a missing step on a stair, a scroll that never dries.

This book is a census. I have listed the places, the people, the pressures, and the rewards. The card-drawing system is explained elsewhere. Here, I only witness.

The ink is dry. The seal is stamped. The ninth scroll remains unfilled – for now.

— *Chen Wei, at a weigh-house in the Sihai capital, under a lamp that flickers nine times before it steadies*

# How to Use This Book

This book is a companion to the *Fate's Edge Core Amaranthine Worldbook* and the *System Reference Document (SRD)*. It provides regional content for the Eastern Realms – Sihai, Nihori, Ayokha, and the non-human peoples of their thresholds – using the same card-driven generator system.

Each regional chapter contains:

- A short introduction (in the voice of Chen Wei, who is not always fair but rarely wrong).
- A local quote.
- An *almanac* – a quick Q&A about daily life in that region.
- Then the full generator tables ( *places*,  *people*,  *complications*,  *rewards*), *imported from separate*

For the core rules (attributes, skills, actions, magic, summoning, travel, etc.), refer to the *Fate's Edge SRD or Player/GM Guides*. The generators assume you are familiar with Position, Effect, and Clocks.

*“The road is a ledger – but only if you forget the stories.”* – Dusana of the Raven Road (apocryphal)

# Chapter 1

## Gateways & Travel

*The road is a ledger – but only if you forget the stories.*

### Travel Modes of the Eastern Realms

#### Grand Canals (Sihai)

The Sihai canal system moves grain, troops, and officials. A **Stamped Pass** from a provincial governor grants priority. Beware the **Censorate Audit** – officials may demand to see your papers at any lock.

#### Storm Seas (Nihori)

The Inland Sea is lashed by typhoons and volcanic ash. A **Storm-Charm** or a **Tide-Charm** from a shrine maiden calms the spirits. Never name a drowned person aloud while underway – the sea collects names.

#### Monsoon Rivers (Ayokha)

The rivers of Ayokha flood and change course with the monsoon. A **Witness Cord** or a **Silk Voucher** buys passage from the Lethai-ar ferrymen. Never pour the ninth cup of tea in a Lethai-ar's presence – that cup is for the river.

#### Threshold Roads (Aelaerem, Aelinnel)

Red threads and counting stones mark the boundaries. A **Red Thread Bundle** or a **Bell Charter** wards off the Hollow. Never count to nine aloud near a shrine – the spirits count with you.

#### Processional Ways (Lethai-al, Lethai-ar, Lethai-thora)

The Lethai peoples walk ancient roads between shrines. A **Tide-Charm** (Nihori), a **Witness Cord** (Ayokha), or a **Silence Token** (Sihai) grants safe passage. Never answer a

question asked by a reflection – the answer will bind you to the path you did not choose.

## Gateways to Other Expansions

- **Amaranthine Core (Kahfagia, Ecktoria, etc.):** From Sihai, the **Silk Road** west leads to Ykrul and the Violet Steppe. From Nihori, the **Aberderrin Sea** connects to the Linns.
- **Southern Realms (Oshiira, Ashaan, Ngomebe):** From Ayokha, monsoon winds carry ships to the Brass Coast (Dhahara) and to Oshiira. From Sihai, the southern trade routes pass through the Crimson Valley.
- **Way of Silk (Fhara, Sidhi, Pereshi, Kuvani, Tulkani):** From Sihai, the **Eastern Silk Road** connects to Kuvani. From Nihori, the **Remount Stations** of Kuvani are a short sea crossing away.
- **Dhahara (Brass Coast, Nine Kingdoms, Himadri):** From Ayokha, the **Monsoon Circuit** carries ships directly to the Brass Coast. From Sihai, the Himadri passes lead to the iron mines.

# Chapter 2

## Sihai

*The Central Kingdom.*

Chen Wei says: *“The Mandate of Heaven is not a right. It is a loan – but no one remembers the interest rate. The emperor borrows legitimacy from the ancestors. When the ledger falls, the empire follows.”*

Sihai is the central kingdom, the seat of the Emperor and the Mandate of Heaven. Its canals carry grain from the south; its examination halls produce bureaucrats who govern by the brush. Beneath the mortal bureaucracy runs a deeper one: the Celestial Bureaucracy of gods, ghosts, and ancestors, where every official has a heavenly counterpart and every erased name becomes a hungry ghost. The Lethai-thora – the ancient archivists who taught the first emperors to write – still keep the hidden scrolls, the ones that record what the Censorate burns.

*“Never speak of succession before naming the Emperor. The Censorate has ears in every tea house. A misplaced word can erase your name from the rolls.”*

— Quiet Chancellor Wei

***What do people eat for breakfast?*** Congee with preserved vegetables – the congee is rice boiled until it is memory, the vegetables salted and aged in clay jars sealed with the emperor’s own wax. The wax is a promise. The promise is sometimes broken.

***What does a child learn before they can walk?*** To write their name. Sihai children are taught the eight strokes of the character “person” – the ninth stroke is the one that turns a name into a signature. A signature is a contract. A contract is a life.

***What is the first thing you notice about a stranger?*** Their chop – the seal they carry to sign documents. Jade means noble. Brass means clerk. Wood means merchant. No chop means a ghost. Ghosts cannot sign contracts.

***What is the most common crime?*** Examination fraud – but fraud is a family business. The questions are leaked in advance. The examiners are bribed. The system is a sieve called “merit.”

***What does no one talk about but everyone knows?*** The Emperor is a figurehead. The real power is the Censorate – nine ministers who have never been seen together. Their names are not recorded. Their faces are not painted. The Emperor signs what they tell him to sign.

**Where do people go when they die?** To the ancestral tablets. The dead are not buried. Their names are written on wooden tablets, placed in the family shrine. The tablets are fed with rice and tea. The dead eat the steam.

**How do you apologize for a serious wrong?** You offer a calligraphy – a scroll written in your own blood. Presented to the wronged party's ancestral shrine. If the ancestors accept, you are forgiven. If the scroll bursts into flame, you are not.

**What is the most important festival?** The Festival of the Ancestors (autumn). The tablets are cleaned and polished. The dead are invited to feast. The food is removed after an hour. The dead have eaten the essence.

**What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person?** The Censorate's ninth minister is a woman – the emperor's own mother, who was supposed to have died in childbirth. She faked her death to escape politics. She has been running the Censorate from a hidden villa. The emperor does not know.

## 2.1 Sihai — “The Central Kingdom”

### Quick Reference

**Tagline:** *The Mandate is a memory. The ancestors are listening. The Hollow collects what is forgotten.*

**Quiet Chancellor (Elite):** “The Mandate of Heaven is not a right. It is a story we tell ourselves — that the emperor remembers the names of the dead. When the story falters, the empire falls. I do not serve the emperor. I serve the silence where the forgotten names should be.”

**Provincial Censor (Commoner):** “My brush is heavier than any sword. A single stroke can make a name vanish — from ledgers, from lips, from the dreams of those who loved it. The emperor reads my reports and trembles. He knows that I have written nine reports this year. The ninth is about him.”

**Genre / Mood:** Celestial bureaucracy, ink-washed horror, examination hell, the weight of forgotten ancestors.

**Starting Location:** An examination hall where ink-stained desks face a silent proctor. A Provincial Censor holds up a scroll: “This candidate’s family name has been erased. He does not know. You will tell him — or you will take his place in the silence.”

#### Theme & Atmosphere

Sihai is the central kingdom, the seat of the Emperor and the Mandate of Heaven. Its canals carry grain from the south; its examination halls produce bureaucrats who govern by the brush. But beneath the mortal bureaucracy runs a deeper one: the Celestial Bureaucracy of gods, ghosts, and ancestors, where every official has a heavenly counterpart and every erased name becomes a hungry ghost. The Lethai-thora — the ancient archivists who taught the first emperors to write — still keep the hidden scrolls, the ones that record what the Censorate burns.

Power here is measured in ink, not iron. The Censorate watches everyone; the Salt Monopoly controls trade; the Kitchen God reports every household’s secrets to the Jade Emperor at New Year. A well-written couplet can appease a ghost; a forged seal can summon a demon. The Hollow’s ninth weight is the unpaid interest on the Mandate itself. Every dynasty borrows legitimacy; every silence is a weight.

**What you notice first:** The smell of ink and canal water, but also incense and grave-soil. The way officials stamp every document with a brass seal — and the way the seal leaves a faint watermark that looks like a face. The constant ticking of water-clocks, but sometimes the ticking skips a beat, and the shadows pause to listen.

**The one rule that kills newcomers:** Never speak of succession before naming the Emperor. The Censorate has ears in every tea house — and the ghosts have ears in every wall. A misplaced word can make a name vanish from the rolls, and from the memory of the ancestors.

## Regional Mood: The Weight of the Brush

Power here is measured in examination scores, salt licenses, and the thickness of a family's archive. The Emperor rules, but the Censorate audits, the Salt Monopoly finances, and the Lethai-thora remember what the Censorate burns. A provincial governor's authority rests on his examination rank; a merchant's on his salt license. The dead are not gone — they are merely demoted. The Hungry Ghost Festival is the only time the Celestial Bureaucracy accepts appeals. The Hollow watches from the missing ninth step, the unpoured ninth cup, the unsaid ninth name.

## Prominent NPCs of Sihai

| <small> p0.2 p0.25 p0.3 p0.15 </small> | <small> p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2 </small> | <small> p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2 </small>                    | <small> p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2 </small>                                                                  |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Name                                   | Role/Title                             | Motivation                                                | Rumoured Quirk                                                                                          |
| Quiet Chancellor Wei                   | Imperial censor                        | Root out corruption before the Mandate fails              | He has never smiled. His seal is a laughing mouth. He speaks to the Kitchen God each evening.           |
| Salt Commissioner Li                   | Head of the Salt Monopoly              | Control the price of salt and the flow of silver          | She tastes every batch of salt before it is stamped. Her tongue is white. She sees ghosts in the brine. |
| Provincial Censor Chen                 | Overseer of the eastern prefectures    | Erase a rebel lineage from the rolls                      | He writes with his left hand. His right hand is for swearing oaths. His left hand has no fingerprints.  |
| Lethai-thora Keeper Lian               | Hidden archivist                       | Protect a scroll that proves the emperor's claim is false | She has not spoken aloud in twenty years. She writes on water. The water never freezes.                 |
| The Hollow's Oath-Keeper               | Spirit of unpaid Mandate               | Collect the ninth name, the ninth step, the ninth cup     | It appears as a scribe with too many fingers. It never blinks. It smells of old incense.                |

## Names of Sihai

Inspired by the central kingdom: short, tonal, with honorifics. Surnames often denote a clan or a prefecture.

| <small> p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2 </small> | <small> p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2 </small> | <small> p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2 </small> | <small> p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2 </small> |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| First Names (Male)                     | First Names (Female)                   | Clan/House                             | Epithets                               |
| Wei                                    | Lian                                   | Chen                                   | <i>the Quiet</i>                       |
| Li                                     | Mei                                    | Zhou                                   | <i>Salt-Tongue</i>                     |
| Chen                                   | Huan                                   | Zhao                                   | <i>the Unerased</i>                    |
| Zhang                                  | Ning                                   | Wu                                     | <i>Ninth Seal</i>                      |

Liu Ping Tang *the Brush*

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**(Hall/Canal/Archive)** Examination hall with ink-stained desks; Grand Canal lock with barges queueing; Lethai-thora hidden archive behind a waterfall.

## Spades — Places

2. **Examination Hall (Hell of Ink)** — A long building with ink-stained desks, silent proctors, and a single bell. *The bell rings when a candidate cheats. It rings once a day on average. The ghosts of failed candidates write answers on the ceiling.* ‘[DEATH]’
3. **Grand Canal Lock (Dragon Gate)** — A stone gate where barges queue for inspection. Officials stamp manifests. *The stamp leaves a watermark that glows under moonlight — a dragon scale. Forgeries are obvious. The dragon knows.* ‘[MAGIC]’
4. **Lethai-thora Hidden Archive** — A pavilion behind a waterfall, filled with forbidden scrolls. *The scrolls are sealed with silk cords. The cords have nine knots. The ninth is a lie. The archivists are all ghosts.* ‘[SECRET]’
5. **Salt Commissioner’s Counting House** — A fortress of ledgers, guarded by armed clerks. *The ledgers are written in disappearing ink. Only the Commissioner knows the reagent — tears of a famine widow.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
6. **Provincial Censorate Office** — A grey building with a brass scale above the door. *The scale weighs truth and lies. It has never balanced. When it tips, someone is erased.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
7. **Emperor’s Forbidden Garden (Kunlun Pavilion)** — A walled garden where no one may enter without permission. *The garden contains a single tree with nine branches. The ninth branch is dead. A phoenix nests in the eighth.* ‘[MYTH]’
8. **Well of Erased Names** — A stone well where the Censorate throws scrolls of erased lineages. *The scrolls burn as they fall. The smoke smells of ink and old blood. The well is bottomless.* ‘[DEATH]’
9. **Tea House of the Ninth Cup (Ghost Festival)** — A popular establishment where the ninth cup is never poured. *The owner has a bell that rings when someone pours the ninth cup. It rings often. The ring attracts hungry ghosts.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
10. **Canal Mother’s Court** — A shaded bench where water rights are assigned. *The bench is carved with the names of every canal mother for nine generations. The ninth name is blank. It waits.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
- J **The Emperor’s Tomb (Unfinished)** — A subterranean complex where the current emperor’s tomb is being built. *The workers are slaves. They will be buried with him. They know. They carve their names into the walls.* ‘[DEATH]’

- Q **The Hollow's Gate (Subterranean)** — A crack in the floor of the Forbidden Garden. *The crack is warm. It whispers the names of emperors who died without heirs. The names are getting longer.* '[MYSTERY]'
- K **The Ninth Ledger's Vault** — A vault beneath the Counting House, accessible only by nine keys. *The ninth key is held by the Hollow. The Hollow will lend it — for a price. The price is a name you have never spoken.* '[WEIGHT]'
- A **The First Examination Hall (Myth)** — Where the first emperor tested his sons. *The hall is invisible. Only those who have passed nine examinations can see it. Inside, the first emperor still grades papers.* '[LEGEND]'

(**Censor/Merchant/Keeper**) Provincial censor with a list of forbidden words; salt merchant with honest scales except when they aren't; Lethai-thora memory-keeper with a silence-token.

## Hearts — People Factions

2. **Provincial Censor** — Grey-robed, a brass seal on a chain. He carries a list of forbidden words. *"Speak the ninth word," he says, "and your name will join the list." The list is written on human skin.* '[AUTHORITY]'
3. **Salt Merchant** — A thin woman with a brass scale. Her weights are hollow. *"The scale is honest," she says. "My hand is not." She has nine weights. The ninth is empty.* '[TRADE]'
4. **Lethai-thora Keeper** — Silent, carrying a brass lamp. She writes on water with a reed brush. *"The words vanish," she says. "That is how I know they are true." Her lamp burns without oil.* '[SECRET]'
5. **Canal Mother** — A matriarch in blue robes, a key to the sluice gate on her belt. *"Water is memory," she says. "The canal remembers every bribe." She has never taken a bribe. She has taken nine stories.* '[COMMUNITY]'
6. **Examination Candidate** — A young man with ink-stained fingers. He has failed nine times. *"The tenth will be different," he says. He has said this nine times. His shadow is missing two fingers.* '[DESPERATION]'
7. **Quiet Chancellor's Spy** — A woman disguised as a tea-seller. She listens at every table. *She writes reports on her own skin. The ink is invisible. Her skin is full. She is running out of space.* '[STEALTH]'
8. **Salt Worker (Slave)** — A man with cracked hands, harvesting salt from pans. *"The salt tastes of tears," he says. "Whose tears, I do not know." He owes nine years of labor. He has served eight.* '[LABOR]'

9. **Hollow's Oath-Keeper** — A tall figure in grey, with too many fingers. It carries a ledger. *It asks: "Where is the ninth name?" It will not leave without an answer. Its ledger is made of human bone.* '[DEATH]'
10. **Emperor's Dreamer** — A woman locked in a tower. She dreams the emperor's nightmares. *She wakes screaming. The dreams are always about the Hollow. She has not dreamed in nine days. The emperor has not slept.* '[MYSTERY]'
- J **The First Censor (Ghost)** — A skeleton in grey robes, sitting in the Well of Erased Names. *He asks: "Did I erase the right name?" The answer is always a lie. He knows. He asks anyway.* '[DEATH]'
- Q **Canal Mother's Ghost** — A translucent figure walking the canal at midnight. *She checks the water level. When it drops, a weight is overdue. She carries a dipper that never empties.* '[COMMUNITY]'
- K **The Ninth Emperor's Ghost** — A crowned skeleton in the unfinished tomb. *He asks: "Is the Mandate renewed?" If you say no, he weeps. His tears turn to ink. The ink writes new laws.* '[LEGEND]'
- A **Kuva's Shadow (Hollow)** — The vast darkness that covers the Forbidden Garden at midnight. *It asks: "Who holds the ninth key?" The answer is a name no one knows. The darkness absorbs the answer.* '[PATRON]'
- (Forgery/Monsoon/Ancessor)** A scroll is found to be a forgery — the party is blamed; monsoon breaks early — the canal closes; an ancestor demands a public accounting of a forgotten weight.

## Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Forged Scroll** — A tax ledger is discovered to be a fake. The forgery is perfect. *The forger is a Censorate clerk. The scroll is not a forgery — it is the original. The Censorate has been lying for centuries.* '[DECEPTION]'
3. **Monsoon Breaks Early** — The canal closes for inspection. Delay 2 segments. *The closure is a cover. The Censorate is searching for a specific barge. The barge carries a forbidden ancestor tablet.* '[WEATHER]'
4. **Ancessor's Demand** — A ghost appears at the family shrine. It demands a public accounting. *The weight is from nine generations ago. The ancestor will not leave until it is paid. It will accept a story if the story is true.* '[DEATH]'
5. **Censorate Audit** — Officials arrive with a warrant. They have a list of forbidden words. *The list includes a word you spoke yesterday. The penalty is erasure. The word was your grandmother's name.* '[AUTHORITY]'

6. **Salt Monopoly Price Hike** — The Commissioner doubles the salt tax. Riots begin. *The hike is a bribe. The bribe is to the Quiet Chancellor. He accepted. The salt is now grey. It used to be white.* ‘[TRADE]’
  7. **Canal Lock Sabotage** — Someone drops a barge at the lock. The canal backs up. *The saboteur is a Canal Mother’s son. He wants to flood the Censorate office. The water is rising. The papers are drowning.* ‘[DISASTER]’
  8. **Examination Cheating Scandal** — A candidate is caught with a cheat sheet. The sheet has your name. *The cheat sheet was planted. The real target is your patron. The cheat sheet is written in disappearing ink. It will be gone by dawn.* ‘[TRAP]’
  9. **Lethai-thora Archive Fire** — A lamp falls in the hidden pavilion. Scrolls burn. *The fire was set by the Censorate. They want to erase a specific history. The history is about the first emperor’s true lineage.* ‘[DESTRUCTION]’
  10. **Hollow’s Weight Called** — A Oath-Keeper appears at the tea house. It points at a party member. *The member owes a weight. The weight is the ninth cup. Pay in story or memory. The Oath-Keeper will know if you lie.* ‘[WEIGHT]’
- J **Emperor’s Health Fails** — The Mandate wavers. Succession rumours spike. *The emperor has no heir. The Hollow is watching. It will collect the ninth name. The name is the emperor’s. He does not know it.* ‘[POLITICS]’
- Q **Forbidden Garden Breached** — Someone enters the garden without permission. The Hollow follows. *The intruder is a child. The Hollow asks: “Why are you here?” The child does not know. The child is a ghost. It has been dead for nine years.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
- K **Ninth Ledger Stolen** — The vault is cracked. The ninth ledger is missing. *The ledger contains the names of everyone the Censorate has erased. The thief is a ghost. The ghost is the first emperor. He wants his name back.* ‘[DEATH]’
- A **Mandate Falls** — The emperor dies without an heir. The Hollow claims the throne. *The Hollow sits on the dragon throne. It asks: “Who will rule?” Silence is the only answer. The Hollow begins to write.* ‘[APOCALYPSE]’

**(Pass/Seal/Token)** Stamped pass from a provincial governor (one use); copy of the Celestial Ledger (reveals one hidden tax); Lethai-thora silence-token (one question the keeper must answer).

## Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Stamped Pass (Governor’s Seal)** — A wax-sealed document. Grants passage through any provincial checkpoint. *The seal is a tiger. It glows when a Censorate agent is nearby. The tiger’s eyes follow you.* ‘[TRAVEL]’

3. **Celestial Ledger (Copy)** — A scroll containing one hidden tax. Use it to blackmail an official. *The ledger is written in disappearing ink. Read it aloud before it fades. The ink tastes of copper.* ‘[BLACKMAIL]’
  4. **Lethai-thora Silence-Token** — A brass charm. Present it to demand a keeper answer one question. *The keeper cannot lie. The question must be about a forgotten secret. The secret is never small.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
  5. **Junk Seal (Official)** — A brass seal. Impersonate a provincial official for one scene. *The seal is warm. It glows when someone tests its authenticity. The glow is the colour of a lie.* ‘[DECEPTION]’
  6. **Canal Mother’s Key** — A bronze key. Open any sluice gate in the Grand Canal. *The key is cold. It warms when a water right is being violated. The warmth is the temperature of a drowning.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
  7. **Salt Commissioner’s Waiver** — A stamped document. Exempts you from the salt tax for one year. *The waiver is written on silk. The silk was stolen from the Commissioner’s own robes. The thread is from a noose.* ‘[TRADE]’
  8. **Examination Answer Key (Forged)** — A cheat sheet that actually works. Pass one examination automatically. *The answers are written in invisible ink. The reagent is moonlight. The answers are wrong — but the examiners cannot tell.* ‘[DECEPTION]’
  9. **Quiet Chancellor’s Seal (Jade)** — A jade seal. Commands the Censorate to ignore one crime. *The seal is a forgery. The Chancellor made it himself. It still works. The jade is warm. It was cut from a tomb.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
  10. **Forbidden Garden Key (Iron)** — A heavy iron key. Opens the gate to the Emperor’s garden. *The key is cursed. Each use ages the wielder one month. The key does not care. It has been waiting for centuries.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
- J **Hollow’s Ninth Ledger Page** — A single page from the ninth ledger. Contains nine erased names. *Speak a name, and that person’s deeds become known. The Hollow will remember too. The page is warm. It has a pulse.* ‘[DEATH]’
- Q **First Censor’s Brush** — A brush made from a phoenix feather. Write any name, and it is erased from all records. *The brush works once. Then it crumbles. The Hollow will know. The phoenix will not forgive.* ‘[LEGEND]’
- K **Canal Mother’s Ghostly Dipper** — A clay dipper used by a dead Canal Mother. Use it to control any sluice gate. *The dipper is cold. It weeps water when a weight is overdue. The water is salt. It tastes of old grief.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
- A **The Mandate Itself (Scroll)** — A scroll that proves the current emperor has no legitimate claim. *Read it aloud, and the Mandate falls. The Hollow will take the throne. The scroll burns after reading. The smoke is a new name.* ‘[APOCALYPSE]’

## Censorate Audit Complications (d6)

When a character faces a Censorate audit (see Additional Features), roll or choose an additional complication that escalates the stakes.

|p1.5cm|p10cm|

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### gray!20 d6 **Complication**

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1 **Erased Name** — The Censorate has struck your name from a ledger. You are legally invisible. Gain -1 Position on all social rolls with officials until resolved.

2 **Ancestor Summons** — A ghost appears at the family shrine demanding a public accounting. The weight is from nine generations ago.

3 **Forged Scroll** — A tax ledger is discovered to be a forgery. The party is blamed. The real forger is a Censorate clerk.

4 **Quiet Chancellor's Interest** — The Chancellor requests a private audience. Refusal is treason. Attendance means owing a favour.

5 **Lethai-thora Silence-Token** — A hidden archivist offers a token in exchange for a secret. The secret will be witnessed by the dead.

6 **Well of Erased Names** — A character sees their own name floating in the well. The Hollow is watching. Gain the *Marked* condition.

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## Hidden Archive Discoveries (d8)

When the party explores the Lethai-thora Hidden Archive or the Ninth Ledger's Vault, roll to determine what forgotten secret they uncover.

|p1.5cm|p10cm|

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### gray!20 d8 **Discovery**

---

1 A scroll that proves the current emperor's claim is false.

2 A map of the Ninth Ledger's vault, sealed with a finger bone key.

3 A forgotten ancestor tablet still warm to the touch.

4 The true name of a Veiled Sister, written in disappearing ink.

5 A Lethai-thora memory-thread containing the last breath of a dead emperor.

6 The original Mandate of Heaven, showing the ninth clause was added later.

7 A canal mother's key that opens any sluice gate — and a ghost that wants it back.

8 A blank scroll that writes itself when no one is watching. It is writing your obituary.

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## Water Rights Disputes (d6)

When a conflict arises over canal access or irrigation, roll to determine the nature of the dispute.

| <div> p1.5cm p10cm </div> <div>gray!20 d6 Dispute</div>                                                            |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 A Canal Mother accuses a rival of diverting water after dark. The evidence is a single wet footprint.            |
| 2 The Dragon King is offended. A barge carrying a forbidden ancestor tablet has contaminated the lock.             |
| 3 A salt merchant claims the right to dam a tributary for his pans. The farmers downstream are sharpening sickles. |
| 4 The water level dropped overnight. A ghostly Canal Mother walks the lock, demanding to know who stole her key.   |
| 5 Two examination candidates accuse each other of bribing the lockmaster. The lockmaster has vanished.             |
| 6 The Ninth Lock has frozen in summer. The Hollow is breathing through the ice. No one will go near it.            |

## Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes, seals, tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **ink-omens**—scrolls that rustle in still air, a lamp that burns green, a forgotten name whispered from a shelf, a ghost that asks for a pen.

## Additional Features (Celestial Bureaucracy)

- **The Mandate Clock [8] (Shared Campaign Clock):** Tracks the stability of the dynasty. The party inherits 2 ticks at the start of any adventure set in Sihai (the old weight). The clock ticks when the emperor's health fails, when a succession dispute arises, when a major corruption scandal is exposed, or when the party breaks an oath witnessed by an ancestor. When the clock reaches 4: the Censorate becomes more aggressive (all audits start at Desperate Position). When it reaches 8: the Mandate fails — the Hollow claims the throne, civil war erupts, and the party must choose a side or flee. Resetting the clock requires an **Ancestor Rite** at the Imperial Ancestral

Temple (downtime, costs 1 Supply and a truthful confession) or a public execution of a corrupt official (costs 1 Boon and may create enemies).

- **The Two Ledgers (Ancestral Names Mechanic):** Every character has two “names”: their **Mortal Name** (what the Censorate knows) and their **Ancestral Name** (recorded in the Celestial Ledger, kept by the Lethai-thora). The Ancestral Name cannot be erased by mortal means. Discovering a character’s Ancestral Name requires a **Research Clock (size 6)** in the Lethai-thora archives. Once known, the player may invoke the Ancestral Name once per session to gain +2 dice on any roll related to that ancestor’s domain (e.g., a farmer’s ancestor aids harvest, a soldier’s ancestor aids battle). However, invoking the Ancestral Name creates an **Ancestral Weight (size 4 clock)**. When it fills, the ancestor demands a service — usually something the ancestor failed to do in life (e.g., “Apologize to my widow” or “Find my stolen seal”). Refusing the demand marks 1 Corruption and adds 2 ticks to the Mandate Clock.
- **Censorate Audit (Social Combat Mechanic):** The Censorate can audit any character at any time. An audit is a social combat with three phases:
  1. **Pleadings** (Presence + Sway vs. Censor’s Lore). Success grants +1 die to the next phase.
  2. **Evidence** (Wits + Investigation vs. DV 4). Success reveals a hidden weight or a forged document; failure gives the Censor a piece of evidence against you.
  3. **Judgment** (Resolve + Lore vs. DV 5). Success: the character is cleared. Failure: the Censorate erases a name — the character loses one Bond (that person no longer remembers them) or one Asset (it is seized), and the Mandate Clock ticks +1.

Players can avoid an audit by: **Bribing the Censor** (costs 1 Honey Jar or 1 Boon), **Presenting a forged document** (requires a Forgery Clock, size 4), or **Calling a ghost witness** (requires a Spirit + Lore test, DV 4; the ghost cannot lie, but it will ask for a favour in return — usually a promise that creates a new Ancestral Weight).

- **Examination Hell (Dungeon Mechanic):** The Forbidden Garden contains a subterranean examination hall where the ghosts of failed candidates still write their answers. The party can enter to find a lost Ancestral Name — but the hall is alive.
  - The hall has a **Stress Clock (size 8)**. Each failed roll, each lie spoken, each broken taboo ticks the clock.
  - At 4: The hall begins to change. Doors lead to different corridors. Navigation becomes Desperate.
  - At 8: The **Examiner Ghost** appears — a skeleton in scholar’s robes. It asks one question. The party must answer in verse. If the verse is good, the ghost grants a boon (reveals one Ancestral Name). If poor, the ghost erases one of the party’s names — that character is forgotten by the living for 1d4 days (lose all Bonds temporarily, cannot be recognised). The Stress Clock resets after the encounter.

- **Paper Soldiers and Hungry Ghosts (Minion Types):**

- **Paper Soldiers (Tier I, Cap 2):** Origami constructs animated by Censorate magic. They have Harm 2, Body 2, Melee 1. They are Vulnerable to fire (double Harm) and to a successful Lore test (reveals their true name, causing them to crumple).
- **Hungry Ghosts (Tier II, Cap 3):** Spirits of those whose names were erased. They have Harm 3, Spirit 3, and the ability **Memory Drain** (touch, target forgets a minor detail – a face, a password, a skill point for one scene). They cannot cross a line of salt or a properly witnessed oath-circle.

- **Water Rights as Ancestral Currency:** In the canal system, water rights are traded like silver, but they are also offerings to the Dragon Kings of the Four Seas. A Canal Mother’s key is worth more than a chest of coins — it can also summon a rain spirit (once per season, calm a storm or flood a district). Forging a water right angers the Dragon King; the forger’s wells run dry for nine years (all Survival tests to find water suffer –2 dice).

- **Lethai-thora Archivists of the First Seal:** The Lethai-thora are not merely librarians — they are the keepers of the original Mandate, written on tortoise shells and dragon bones. They do not serve the emperor; they serve the record that predates the empire. A Lethai-thora keeper can declare any document void by writing “void” in water over it. The water must be from the Well of Erased Names. Doing so costs 1 Obligation to the Lethai-thora and ticks the Mandate Clock +1 (the Censorate will investigate).

- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**

- **The Jade Censor** — The Witness. *A magistrate who never blinks, who writes every truth in a ledger of jade.*
- **The Dragon Salt** — Maelstraeus. *The price of a monopoly; the interest on a nation’s thirst.*
- **The Ninth Ancestor** — Khemesh. *The ghost of the first emperor, who still reviews petitions.*
- **The Brush That Walks** — The Traveler. *A calligraphy brush that guides lost officials through the underworld.*
- **The Kitchen’s Ear** — The Sealed Gate. *The god who reports every secret to the Celestial Bureaucracy.*

## Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Ninth Ledger and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The ninth ledger is said to contain the name of the prince who stole the amulet. The Veiled Sisters want to erase it. The Breath-less want to find it. The Lethai-thora have hidden it in a scroll that unrolls forever.

- **Silence-Tokens and the Covenant (Mykkiel):** The Covenant recognises Lethai-thora silence-tokens as valid requests for closed hearings. A silence token can pause any court proceeding for the duration of a single breath. The token is a strip of silk from a burial shroud.
- **Canal Mothers and the Fhara (Way of Silk):** Fhara well-judges and Sihai canal mothers use similar water-measuring systems. A canal mother's key can be used to negotiate a well contract — but the key must be dipped in the well first. The water will remember.
- **The Mandate and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The Hollow is the unpaid interest on the Mandate. Aelaerem hedge-keepers say that when a dynasty falls, the Hollow eats the ninth name. The name is always the emperor's secret childhood name.

### Sihai Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Canal:** Crumble a crust into the water. Ignore the first *Forged Scroll* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Scroll:** Tie a single knot in a silk cord. Cancel *Censorate Audit* or take -1 die on your next forgery detection roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead censor's name into the Well of Erased Names. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating with the Censorate this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Hollow. '[SUPERSTITION]'

### Thematic SB Spend Table

#### Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Censorate clerks or ancestor ghosts**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **canal patrols or hungry ghosts**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or the Kitchen God**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable water level**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

#### Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local censor or canal mother** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or a ghost procession**.

- **Foe Appears:** A **paper soldier** (origami construct) or a **hungry ghost** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

### Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Censorate guards**, **ancestor spirits**, or **paper soldiers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**ancestor summoned/ledger stolen/mandate questioned**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

### Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Quiet Chancellor**, **Salt Commissioner**, or **First Censor's Ghost** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**canal floods/archive burns/mandate falls**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

### Region-Specific SB Options

- **Sihai (Celestial Bureaucracy):** A ghost clerk appears with a writ, a paper seal floats down from nowhere, the Emperor's Dreamer whispers a warning.
- **Sihai (Ancestor Law):** A family shrine glows, an ancestor's portrait weeps ink, a forgotten weight is recalled in a dream.
- **Sihai (Examination Hell):** A failed candidate's ghost asks for a pen, a test paper bleeds, the proctor's bell rings nine times.

## Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Paper Trail*.
- **Cut the Seal (Presence + Lore):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a stamped pass is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Audit (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Censorate Audit*, you pick who testifies; on a miss, the GM does.

## Boss Seeds (Brush & Mandate)

- **The Forgotten Emperor (Ghost of the Ninth Seal)** — *Phases*: Names Erased → Ledger Stolen → Mandate Reclaimed. *Cracks*: present a true ancestor tablet, expose a forged lineage, survive a night in the Well of Erased Names.
- **The Brush That Writes Itself (Living Ink)** — *Phases*: Paper Soldiers → Scroll Prison → Ink Flood. *Cracks*: a Lethai-thora silence-token, a confession written in water, the First Censor's Brush.

### Patronage & Power

In Sihai, power flows through ink, salt, and the weight of the Mandate. The Emperor rules, but the Censorate audits, the Salt Monopoly finances, the Lethai-thora remember, and the ancestors watch. A well-written couplet can appease a ghost; a forged seal can start a war. The Celestial Bureaucracy is always hiring.

**For the GM:** Power in Sihai is measured in examination scores, salt licenses, and the thickness of a family's archive. Patronage often takes the form of stamped passes, ledger copies, or silence-tokens — each tied to a specific office, canal, or weight. To emphasize the mythological flavour:

- Use the **Mandate Clock** as a visible campaign front. The party's actions can tick or reset it. Ancestor rites are the only safe way to reduce it.
- Enforce **Censorate Audits** as a recurring threat — players must maintain clean papers or face erasure. Ghost witnesses can be summoned by either side.
- Let **water rights** be a form of currency that can be stolen, forged, or contested — but angering the Dragon King has consequences.
- Introduce **paper soldiers** (origami constructs) as low-tier enemies and **hungry ghosts** as mid-tier threats. The Censorate employs both.

In Sihai, the brush forgets nothing — and the Hollow remembers every erased name.

# Chapter 3

## Nihori

*The Isles of the Dawn Spirit.*

Chen Wei frowns: *“The Nihori measure honour in sword-strokes and storms. Their shogun is a ghost; their daimyo are knives. I admire their poetry. I do not envy their politics.”*

Nihori is a chain of volcanic islands, shrouded in mist and lashed by storms – a shattered shogunate where the old empire sank beneath the waves and the Lethai-al guard the drowned kingdom’s memory. The people are wanderers, duelists, shrine maidens, and oni-touched outcasts. They worship the storm spirits (kami of wind, wave, and crater) and fear the ninth wave. The Shogun sits in a half-ruined castle, his authority challenged by three rival daimyo who sharpen their blades and their treaties. Oni cults whisper in the ash wastes, offering forgotten bargains. The ninth taboo is absolute: never speak the name of the drowned capital. The sea will hear you.

*“Never draw steel in a shrine. The kami will witness. They may not forgive.”*

— Shrine Maiden Hana

***What do people eat for breakfast?*** Grilled fish and pickled vegetables – the fish caught in caldera lakes, the vegetables fermented in clay pots buried in volcanic ash. The ash is warm. The mountain dreams of the drowned empire.

***What does a child learn before they can walk?*** To read the tide. Nihori children are taught the eight wave-heights: Calm, Ripple, Swell, Storm, Tsunami, and the ninth – the wave that has no height because it is the sea itself rising. The ninth wave is the drowning.

***What is the first thing you notice about a stranger?*** Their sword. Nihori warriors carry their ancestors’ blades, passed down for generations. A rusted sword means forgotten lineage. A sharp sword means remembered. No sword means a coward.

***What is the most common crime?*** Dueling – but dueling is a conversation. The codes are written in verse. The interpretations are contradictory. The contradictions are settled by dueling. The circle is beautiful.

***What does no one talk about but everyone knows?*** The drowned capital is not underwater. It is beneath – beneath the caldera, beneath the bedrock, beneath the world. The sea is a lid. The lid is cracked.

**Where do people go when they die?** *To the sea cliffs. The dead are placed in caves overlooking the water. The waves sing lullabies. The dead listen.*

**How do you apologize for a serious wrong?** *You offer a duel – a matched contest with the wronged party's choice of weapon. If you lose, you are forgiven. If you win, you are not. If you refuse, you are exiled to the open sea.*

**What is the most important festival?** *The Calling of the Tides (spring). The shrine maidens walk into the water, singing the names of the drowned. The waves answer with the names of the living who will die in the coming year.*

**What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person?** *The Shogun is a ghost. He died in the last oni war, but his body was never found. The daimyo rule in his name because they are afraid of what will happen if they admit he is gone.*

### 3.1 Nihori — “The Isles of the Dawn Spirit”

#### Quick Reference

**Tagline:** *Duel at dawn. Honour the storm. The ninth wave never breaks.*

**Storm Emperor’s Ghost (Elite):** “I ruled the waves before the Hollow learned to walk. My empire sank because I spoke a name I should not have. Do not speak my name. Do not ask what it was. The sea remembers. That is enough.”

**Wanderer (Commoner):** “I carry a broken sword and a grudge. The sword was my father’s. The grudge is mine. The man who killed him died nine years ago. I still walk the isles, looking for his ghost. The ghost is looking for me too.”

**Genre / Mood:** Storm-tossed honour duels, kami politics, oni cults, volcanic doom, drowned ghosts, yokai in the ash.

**Starting Location:** A bamboo grove on a clifftop, where two duelists face each other at dawn. Ash from the volcano dusts their shoulders. A Shrine Maiden rings a copper bell: “The Shogun’s envoy demands the duel stop. The daimyo of the southern isle says it will not. The storm-spirit is watching. Choose a side — or the ninth wave will choose for you.”

#### Theme & Atmosphere

Nihori is a chain of volcanic islands, shrouded in mist and lashed by storms — a shattered shogunate where the old empire sank beneath the waves and the **Lethai-al** guard the drowned kingdom’s memory. The people are wanderers, duelists, shrine maidens, and oni-touched outcasts. They worship the storm spirits (kami of wind, wave, and crater) and fear the ninth wave. The Hollow breathes in the salt foam; Oath-Keepers ride the tide. The Shogun sits in a half-ruined castle, his authority challenged by three rival daimyo who sharpen their blades and their treaties. **Oni cults** whisper in the ash wastes, offering forgotten bargains. **Yūrei** (vengeful ghosts) wail from sunken ships. **Kappa** drag children from tidal pools. **Tengu** mock travellers from the high crags. The Storm Emperor’s ghost does not rule — but his silence haunts every island. The ninth taboo is absolute: never speak the name of the drowned capital. The sea will hear you, and it will ask why you called.

**What you notice first:** The smell of salt and volcanic ash. The way every traveller carries a sword, even the tea-sellers. The constant sound of bells on shrine gates — ringing in the wind. And the silence when a daimyo’s retinue passes. The distant wail of a *funayūrei* (a drowned sailor’s ghost) calling for a boat that never comes.

**The one rule that kills newcomers:** Never draw steel in a shrine. The kami will witness. They may not forgive.

#### Regional Mood: The Weight of the Wave and the Edge of the Blade

Power here is measured in duels won, storms survived, and the number of clans that bow to your banner. The Shogun rules from Castle Kurotani, but his writ fades as the islands

stretch into the mist. Three daimyo vie for supremacy: the **Northern Crane** (old blood, slow to anger, quicker to negotiate), the **Southern Serpent** (pragmatic, pirates in his pay, a smile like a cracked bell), and the **Western Oni** (rumoured to have made a pact with a Crater Oni, his eyes glow faintly red in the dark). Between them, the **Shrine Maidens** keep the peace — not through steel, but through storm-calling and the threat of the ninth wave. A duel is not merely a fight; it is a negotiation sanctified by kami. First blood decides the truth. The loser owes a story. The winner owes a cup of sake — and a prayer at the nearest shrine.

## Prominent NPCs of Nihori

[p0.2][p0.25][p0.3][p0.15]

| Name                              | Role/Title                                               | Motivation                                                  | Rumoured Quirk                                                         |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Shogun Atsumori                   | Figurehead ruler of the shattered realm                  | Keep the daimyo from open war                               | He has not spoken in seven years. His attendants speak for him.        |
| Daimyo Sadako (Southern Serpent)  | Ruler of the southern isles, pirate ally                 | Break the Shogun's peace and claim the throne               | She wears a necklace of brass hooks — one for each ship she has taken. |
| Daimyo Yoritomo (Northern Crane)  | Old-blood traditionalist                                 | Restore the shogunate's authority by the old laws           | He has never lost a duel. He has never drawn first blood.              |
| The Oni-Eyed (Daimyo of the West) | Ruler of the western ash wastes, rumoured oni-touched    | Ascend to a new form — neither human nor spirit             | His eyes glow red in darkness. His retainers wear masks.               |
| Shrine Maiden Hana                | Keeper of the Storm Shrine                               | Pacify the spirit of the ninth wave                         | She rings a bell that can only be heard underwater.                    |
| Wanderer Ronin                    | Masterless swordsman                                     | Find the ghost of his father's killer                       | He has never lost a duel. He has also never drawn first blood.         |
| Pirate Captain Red-Hook           | Kalingan raider                                          | Control the strait between the isles                        | His left hand is a brass hook. The hook is also a key.                 |
| The Drowned Scholar (Ghost)       | A Lethai-al who died before completing his research      | Ask the living to retrieve a scroll from the sunken capital | He appears at low tide, holding a skeletal oar.                        |
| Oni-Brewer (Cult Leader)          | A priest of the Crater Oni who brews memory-erasing sake | Turn the daimyo's court into puppets                        | His breath smells of ash and plum wine. He never blinks.               |
| Kappa-Binder                      | A hermit who catches kappa in clay pots                  | Trade kappa secrets for human memories                      | He has a bowl-shaped dent in his head — a kappa's mark.                |

### Daimyo Strings (Quick Reference)

- **Southern Serpent (Sadako):** Can provide pirate escorts, forged papers, or a safe harbour — for a price in favours or a future raid. *Typical String:* “A ship that will ignore customs once.”
- **Northern Crane (Yoritomo):** Can offer legal arbitration, access to the archive temple, or a duel champion — expects honour and a public oath in return. *Typical String:* “A witnessed verdict that clears your name.”
- **Oni-Eyed:** Can grant oni-touched powers (a die bonus to intimidation, darkvision, etc.) — but accepting gives +1 *Oni Corruption* immediately. *Typical String:* “A favour owed to the Crater Oni — payable in memory or blood.”

### Names of Nihori

Inspired by the northern isles: short, with vowel endings and occasional glottal stops. Surnames denote a clan, a wave, or a drowned ancestor.

| p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2 |                      |               |                       |  |
|-----------------------|----------------------|---------------|-----------------------|--|
| First Names (Male)    | First Names (Female) | Clan/Epithet  | Wave-Name             |  |
| Kenji                 | Hana                 | Wave-walker   | <i>Ninth Breath</i>   |  |
| Ronan                 | Yuki                 | Storm-kin     | <i>Salt-Tongue</i>    |  |
| Kael                  | Mira                 | Drowned-line  | <i>Unforgotten</i>    |  |
| Takeshi               | Sora                 | Foam-born     | <i>Tide-Charm</i>     |  |
| Jiro                  | Nami                 | Ancestor-salt | <i>the Unshadowed</i> |  |
| Yoshio                | Rin                  | Kappa-binder  | <i>Bowl-Head</i>      |  |

**(Forge/Grove/Shrine)** A swordsmith’s forge with a waterfall cooling tank; a bamboo grove where duels are fought at dawn; a storm-shrine on a cliff with ropes for climbing.

### Spades — Places

2. **Swordsmith’s Forge (Volcano-Fired)** — A waterfall cooling tank; prayer strips on the bellows. *The swordsmith prays before each strike. The prayer is a verse from the old epic.* ‘[CRAFT]’
3. **Bamboo Grove (Duel Ground)** — A clearing where the stalks are scarred by blade cuts. *The bamboo bleeds sap when a duel is dishonourable. The sap is red.* ‘[HONOUR]’

4. **Storm-Shrine (Cliff)** — A wooden platform on a sea cliff, with ropes for climbing. *The ropes are braided with human hair. The hair is from sailors who survived shipwrecks.* ‘[KAMI]’
  5. **Drowned Palace (Ruins)** — Half-submerged columns visible at low tide. *The columns are carved with names. The names are the drowned kingdom’s royalty.* ‘[DEATH]’
  6. **Volcano Shrine (Dormant)** — A crater where the forbidden name was spoken. *The crater is warm. Speaking any name aloud here causes the ground to tremble.* ‘[ONI]’
  7. **Castle Kurotani (Shogun’s Seat)** — A half-ruined fortress on a clifftop, roofs patched with salvaged ship timber. *The Shogun’s throne is cracked. The crack is shaped like a wave.* ‘[POLITICS]’
  8. **Southern Serpent’s Fleet Anchorage** — A hidden harbour where pirate dhows and war junks moor together. *The flags are all different. The loyalty is all to the same purse.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
  9. **Oni’s Caldera (Western Ash Wastes)** — A crater lake where the Oni-Eyed daimyo holds court. *The water is warm and red. It tastes of iron and forgotten promises.* ‘[CORRUPTION]’
  10. **Crane Clan’s Archive Temple** — A library built into a sea cliff, scrolls sealed in wax. *The clan has not opened the oldest wing in a century. The seal is still warm.* ‘[TRADITION]’
- J **The Sunken Gate** — An underwater archway that leads to the drowned capital. *It can only be reached by holding your breath for nine heartbeats.* ‘[THRESHOLD]’
- Q **Storm-Reader’s Lookout** — A wooden tower on the highest cliff. *From here, the Storm-Reader can see three storms coming. He has never been wrong.* ‘[WEATHER]’
- K **The Ninth Wave’s Rock** — A black stone that the ninth wave strikes every full moon. *The wave leaves behind a single white shell. The shell contains a memory.* ‘[OMEN]’
- A **The Drowned Capital (Myth)** — A sunken city said to rise once every century. *Those who enter can speak to the dead. The price is a breath.* ‘[LEGEND]’

**(Wanderer/Maiden/Pirate)** Wanderer with a broken sword; Shrine Maiden with a copper bell; Pirate Captain with a brass hook.

## Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Wanderer (Ronin)** — A man with no master, a scarred blade, and a cup of sake. *He offers a cup to every opponent. “Drink,” he says. “The duel will be fair.”* ‘[HONOUR]’

3. **Shrine Maiden Hana** — A woman with a copper bell on a rope. She rings it at dawn. *The bell's tone tells the fishing fleet whether to sail. It has never been wrong.* '[KAMI]'
  4. **Pirate Captain Red-Hook** — A woman with a brass hook for a hand. She lost the original to a sea monster. *The hook is also a key. It opens a chest of treasure maps — and a dossier on the Southern Serpent's spies.* '[STEALTH]'
  5. **Storm-Reader** — Grey-haired, eyes the colour of storm clouds. He can feel the pressure change in his bones. *"The storm will arrive in nine hours," he says. "Bring your offerings — or your prayers."* '[WEATHER]'
  6. **Swordsmith** — A woman with calloused hands and a prayer strip on her forehead. *She names each sword after a dead warrior. The sword remembers. The warrior's ghost may visit.* '[CRAFT]'
  7. **Shogun's Chamberlain** — A soft-spoken man with a fan painted with a crane. He speaks for the silent Shogun. *He never raises his voice. The daimyo lower theirs when he enters.* '[POLITICS]'
  8. **Daimyo Sadako (Southern Serpent)** — A woman with a scarred lip, a fleet of dhows, and a network of informants. *She wears a necklace of brass hooks — one for each ship she has taken. She adds a new one each season.* '[AUTHORITY]'
  9. **Daimyo Yoritomo (Northern Crane)** — An old man with perfect posture, a blade that has never drawn blood, and a library of old laws. *He has never lost a duel. He has never drawn first blood. His opponents always apologise.* '[TRADITION]'
  10. **The Oni-Eyed** — A figure in a tattered mask, one eye glowing red. He rules the ash wastes from a throne of cooled lava. *His retainers wear masks of their own faces — cast from the moment they swore loyalty.* '[CORRUPTION]'
- J **Oni-Brewer (Cult Leader)** — A bald man with burn scars, a ceramic sake jug, and a sweet, rotten smile. *His sake erases memories. He sells it to daimyo who want to forget debts — and to assassins who want to forget guilt.* '[DEBT]' *Mechanic: Drinking the Oni-Brewer's sake clears 1 Obligation segment or 1 Debt Clock segment — but you also lose one random minor memory (a face, a password, a skill point for one scene). The GM records what you forgot; it may return as a nightmare or a ghost.*
- Q **Storm Emperor's Ghost** — A column of steam over the water, shaped like a crowned man. *He asks: "Has anyone spoken the name?" If you say yes, he weeps. If you say no, he waits. Triggered event: When the ninth wave strikes or the Sunken Gate opens, the ghost solidifies into a towering figure of foam and lightning. He points at one character. That character hears the name of the drowned capital whispered in their ear — and now the Hollow knows they know.* '[DEATH]'
- K **Crater Oni (Sealed)** — A horned shadow visible only in the reflection of volcanic vents. *It offers bargains: a year of luck for a memory, a century of life for a death. The Oni-Eyed accepted. He does not remember the price.* '[PATRON]'

- A **The First Drowned (Legend)** — The first Lethai-al who died in the sinking. She sits at the bottom of the sea. *If you bring her a memory, she will teach you to breathe water. If you bring her a lie, she will drown you.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(**Ashfall/Duel/Pirate**) Ashfall from the volcano — all actions Desperate; a duel challenge is issued — refusal loses face; a pirate flotilla claims the strait — pay toll or fight.

## Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ashfall (Volcano)** — The dormant crater emits ash. Visibility drops. All actions are Desperate. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The ash is warm. It smells of old names. Speaking a name makes the ash thicken — and the oni listen.*
3. **Duel Challenge (Issued)** — A Lethai-al challenges a party member to a duel. Refusal loses face. ‘[HONOUR]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The duel is to first blood. The loser owes a story. The story must be true. The winner owes a prayer.*
4. **Pirate Flotilla (Southern Serpent’s Fleet)** — Kalingan pirates block the strait. They demand a toll of one tide-charm. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The charm must be from a drowned ancestor. If the party has no tide-charm, they must offer a memory or a promise instead — the pirates are not picky.*
5. **Oni Cult Initiation** — A traveller is marked by the Oni-Eyed’s cult. Their shadow has horns. ‘[CORRUPTION]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The cult demands a service: steal a scroll from the Crane Clan’s archive, or the mark will spread.*
6. **Tide-Charm Stolen** — Someone steals a pouch of charms. The ancestors are angry. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The thief is a foreign merchant in the pay of the Southern Serpent. The charms are in a cargo hold guarded by oni-touched pirates.*
7. **Daimyo Summit (War Threatened)** — The three daimyo agree to meet. The Shogun’s peace holds — barely. ‘[POLITICS]’ *Any false move could ignite a civil war. The party is there as witnesses — or scapegoats.*
8. **Volcano Name Whispered** — Someone speaks the forbidden name near the crater. The ground shakes. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[DISASTER]’ *The speaker is a child of the Oni-Eyed’s household. The child did not know. The volcano remembers. The oni laughs.*
9. **Ninth Wave Warning** — The full moon is tomorrow. The ninth wave will be larger than any in a century. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The fishing fleet cannot be recalled. Someone must warn them — or bargain with the storm-spirit for their lives.*
10. **Sake House Brawl (Oni-Brewer’s Sake)** — A dispute over a duel’s fairness turns violent. The ninth cup is poured. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The ninth cup is for the dead. Someone has just died. The brawl is now a blood feud — and everyone has forgotten why.*

**J Sunken Gate Opens** — The underwater archway becomes passable. Something swims out. '[THRESHOLD]' '[DEATH]' *It is a drowned spirit. It wants its name back. It will trade a secret for it — or take yours.*

**Q Storm-Reader's Silence** — The old man stops reading the storm. The fishermen do not know where to sail. '[WEATHER]' '[GRIEF]' *He is grieving. His son died at sea. He will not speak until the body is found — or until someone tells him a true story of the sea.*

**K Duel to the Death (Oni-Eyed's Assassin)** — A duel that was meant to be to first blood becomes a killing. '[HONOUR]' '[TRAP]' *The killer is a spy from the Western Ash Wastes. The duel was an assassination. The party is blamed — unless they can prove the oni-touched intervened.*

**A The Ninth Wave Takes** — The massive wave crashes over the cliff shrine. The bells are silent. '[DEATH]' '[CATASTROPHE]' *The shrine maiden is gone. The storm-spirit is free. The Hollow walks the shore. The only way to appease it is to speak the name of the drowned capital — and accept the consequences.*

**(Token/Bell/Charm)** Swordsmith's token (one reroll on a failed melee attack); shrine bell (reveals hidden spirits for one scene); wanderer's oath-bracelet (one use to compel a service).

## Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Swordsmith's Token (Iron)** — A small iron disc. Reroll a failed melee attack once. '[COMBAT]' *The token is stamped with a prayer. The prayer is for a clean cut. The swordsmith made it for a warrior who never returned.*
3. **Shrine Bell (Copper)** — A small copper bell. Ring it to reveal hidden spirits for one scene. '[KAMI]' *The bell's tone is inaudible to humans. The spirits hear it clearly. They may answer — or they may hide.*
4. **Wanderer's Oath-Bracelet (Leather)** — A braided leather bracelet. Demand a service from any wanderer once. '[HONOUR]' *The bracelet is stained with sake. The wanderer cannot refuse. The service is one night's vigil or one day's guide.*
5. **Storm-Charms (Bone)** — A carved bone. Ignore one weather penalty on a journey leg. '[WEATHER]' *The bone is from a sailor who died in a storm. His spirit protects you — but he will ask for a story in return.*
6. **Tide-Charms (Shell)** — A white shell. Whisper a drowned ancestor's name to calm a storm for one hour. '[DEATH]' '[WEATHER]' *The shell is warm. It glows when the ancestor is listening. Do not lie. They know.*

7. **Duelist's Sake Cup** — A ceramic cup used in a fair duel. Demand a duel to first blood. '[HONOUR]' *The cup is chipped. The chip is from a blade that drew first blood. The loser's story is carved into the rim.*
8. **Pirate Captain's Hook (Brass)** — A brass hook prosthetic. Use it as a key to open any chest in the cove. '[STEALTH]' *The hook is also a weapon. It can cut rope and bone. It also fits the lock on the Southern Serpent's war chest.*
9. **Volcano Priest's Whisper** — A single word: the forbidden name. Speak it to cause a tremor. '[DEATH]' '[MAGIC]' *The word burns the tongue. Use once. The volcano will remember. The oni will hear.*
10. **Drowned Scholar's Scroll (Waterproof)** — A scroll retrieved from the sunken capital. Contains a forgotten secret. '[LEGEND]' *The scroll is wet. It will never dry. The secret is about the Storm Emperor's true name — and why he spoke it.*
- J **Ninth Wave's Shell** — A white shell from the Ninth Wave's Rock. Break it to experience a memory. '[OMEN]' *The memory is always a death. The death is always a drowning. The memory may be yours — or an ancestor's.*
- Q **Storm-Reader's Flute (Bone)** — A bone flute. Play it to predict the weather for the next 24 hours. '[WEATHER]' *The tune is sad. It always predicts a storm. It is always right. The Storm-Reader will not explain why.*
- K **Sunken Gate Key (Coral)** — A piece of coral shaped like a key. Opens the Sunken Gate. '[THRESHOLD]' *The key is alive. It grows one size each time it is used. After nine uses, it becomes a coral door that cannot be moved — and the gate is permanently open.*
- A **First Drowned's Breath (Glass Vial)** — Seawater from the bottom of the sunken capital. Drink it to breathe water for one hour. '[LEGEND]' *The water tastes of salt and sorrow. The lungs will ache. The memory of drowning will stay with you.*

## Storm-Spirit Negotiation (d6 Outcomes)

When the party attempts to bargain with a storm kami (at a shrine, during a typhoon, or at the Ninth Wave's Rock), roll on this table to determine the outcome. The GM sets the initial DV based on the offering (a tide-charm, a story, or a cup of sake).

| p2cm p10cm                                                                                                                                                                              |                |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| gray!20                                                                                                                                                                                 | Outcome Result |
| <hr/>                                                                                                                                                                                   |                |
| <b>Critical Success</b> The spirit grants a <i>Storm-Charm</i> (ignore one weather penalty on any future voyage). The kami may also whisper a warning about the next oni cult activity. |                |
| <hr/>                                                                                                                                                                                   |                |
| <b>Success</b> The spirit calms the storm for the party only. Other ships in the area are not protected. Gain +1 <i>Kami Favour</i> .                                                   |                |
| <hr/>                                                                                                                                                                                   |                |



1 **Kami Witness** — A shrine kami manifests as a whirlwind or a flash of lightning. Both duelists must test Resolve (DV 4) or lose their turn. The kami favours the one who offers a prayer.

2 **Interrupted by Ashfall** — Volcanic ash darkens the sky. Ranged attacks (including thrown weapons) suffer -1 die. The duel may be postponed unless both parties agree to continue.

3 **Oni Interference** — A horned shadow flickers at the edge of the grove. The duelist with higher *Oni Corruption* gains +1 die to intimidation but -1 die to honour-based rolls. The oni is betting on the outcome.

4 **The Ninth Echo** — The clashing of blades rings nine times. On the ninth ring, the ground trembles. Both duelists must test Body + Athletics (DV 3) or stumble, losing the next exchange.

5 **A Witness's Secret** — A bystander reveals that one duelist is under an oni bargain. The duel can be halted for a *Geas Test* (Spirit + Lore vs. DV 4). Success cancels the bargain for the duration of the duel; failure binds the bargainer further.

6 **The Loser's Story** — Instead of first blood, the loser must tell a true story of a broken promise. If the story moves the kami, the duel ends in a draw and both parties gain +1 *Kami Favour*. If the story is false, the loser takes Harm 1 (spiritual backlash).

## Kami Favour Boons (d6)

When a character spends *Kami Favour* (see Additional Features), roll or choose a boon from this table. Each boon costs 1–3 Favour as indicated.

| p2cm p10cm                        | gray!20 Boon (Cost) Effect                                                                                                                           |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Calm Seas (1 Favour)</b>       | The kami calms the waters for one leg. All sailing rolls gain +1 Position.                                                                           |
| <b>Wind at Back (1 Favour)</b>    | Your ship gains +1 Speed for one leg. On a critical success, you arrive one segment early.                                                           |
| <b>Kami's Warning (2 Favour)</b>  | Before the next storm, you receive a vision. The GM must answer one yes/no question about the weather or a sea hazard.                               |
| <b>Duel Blessing (2 Favour)</b>   | In your next duel, you gain +1 die to Honour-based actions (e.g., showing mercy, refusing a dirty trick).                                            |
| <b>Ancestor's Tide (3 Favour)</b> | A drowned ancestor guides your ship through a reef or shoal. Ignore one <i>Sunken Gate</i> or <i>Pirate Flotilla</i> complication.                   |
| <b>Oni Ward (3 Favour)</b>        | For the remainder of the current scene, you are immune to oni-touched fear effects. Your shadow does not grow horns even if your Corruption track is |

high.

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## Yokai Encounters (d8)

When travelling through the wilder parts of Nihori (ash wastes, deep forests, forgotten shores), roll on this table for a supernatural encounter. Yokai are not always hostile — they are creditors, tricksters, and reminders of a world older than the shogunate.

|p1.5cm|p10cm|

gray!20 **d8 Encounter**

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**1 Kappa in the Ford** — A river kappa blocks a shallow crossing. It demands a cucumber, a bow, or a memory. Refuse, and it will try to pull a party member underwater (Grapple, Body+Endurance DV 3 to resist). If you win, it may grant a *Kappa's Secret* — +1 die on all Swimming or Sailing rolls for the rest of the journey.

**2 Floating Lantern (Funayūrei)** — A drowned sailor's ghost drifts toward your boat, holding a paper lantern. It asks, "Where is my grave?" If you answer truthfully (a specific cove or shrine), it blesses your voyage (+1 Position on the next sea leg). If you lie, it capsizes your boat.

**3 Tengu on the Pass** — A long-nosed tengu sits on a stone, blocking the mountain trail. It challenges you to a game of riddles or a contest of pride. If you win, it gives you a *Tengu Fan* (once, create a gust of wind to extinguish fires or fill sails). If you lose, it steals your name — you forget one Bond or Skill for 1d4 scenes.

**4 Nure-onna (Wet Woman)** — A serpent-woman with the head of a beautiful woman and the body of a snake appears on the shore. She offers to heal a wound or clear a Debt Clock segment — in exchange for a vial of your blood or a lock of your hair. Refusing angers her (Harm 1, poison). Accepting gives you a *Debt Token* she will call in at the worst moment.

**5 Jorōgumo (Spider Bride)** — A woman in silk robes invites you to her teahouse. The teahouse is a web. She offers you a deal: information about the Oni-Eyed's location in exchange for a memory of a living family member. If you refuse, she attacks (Cap 3, venomous). If you accept, you gain the information — but your family member will dream of spiders for a week.

**6 Yuki-onna (Snow Woman)** — During a sudden cold snap, a woman in white appears. She asks for a fire or a warm cloak. If you give it freely, she grants you a *Frost Charm* (once, ignore a heat-based hazard). If you refuse, she freezes your breath — you gain 1 Fatigue and suffer −1 die on all physical rolls for the next scene.

**7 Onmoraki (Birth-Death Bird)** — A bird with a human face hatches from a corpse. It speaks in riddles about a death that will occur in the next 24 hours. If the party prevents that death, the Onmoraki becomes a guardian spirit (Cap 1 follower for one session). If they fail, it curses them — the next time anyone rolls a 1, it becomes a 10 (but the GM gains 2 SB).

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8 **The Shōjō (Drunkard Sage)** — A red-faced, singing creature floats on a sake barrel offshore. It offers to share its brew. Drinking it gives +2 dice to all social rolls for one scene — but you cannot lie, and every truth you speak is heard by the nearest oni cult spy. The Shōjō laughs and vanishes, leaving an empty barrel.

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## Haunted Blades (Cursed Swords)

In Nihori, every sword has a spirit, and some swords have ghosts. A character who acquires a masterwork blade (cost 8 XP) may choose to make it *haunted*. The blade grants a powerful benefit but also a curse.

|p2cm|p5cm|p5cm|

gray!20 **Blade Benefit Curse**

---

**Whisper of the Drowned** +1 die to attack rolls against pirates and oni. The blade whispers the names of drowning sailors at night. You cannot recover Fatigue from sleep while at sea.

**Storm's Edge** Once per scene, as a free action, gain +1 Effect on a melee attack during a storm. The blade attracts lightning. On a Critical Failure, you are struck for Harm 1 (shock).

**Ancestor's Tooth** The blade can cut through spirit wards. Ignore 1 point of Armor from ghosts and oni. The ancestor's ghost appears in your dreams, demanding you avenge a centuries-old wrong. Start a *Ancestor's Debt* clock [6].

**Broken Vow (Cursed)** +2 dice on the first attack of any duel. If you lose a duel, the blade breaks — and you cannot repair it without a quest to the sunken capital.

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## Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits. Highest rank sets main Clock size: 2–5 → 4 segments, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10.
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (tokens, bells, charms) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea-omens**—a wave that breaks twice, a bell that rings underwater, a name that echoes from the foam.

## Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Duel Law:** Disputes in Nihori are settled by duel to first blood. The loser owes a story; the winner owes a cup of sake. A duel can be witnessed by anyone; the witness's word is law. Refusing a duel is an admission of guilt. In the shogunate courts, a duel verdict can overturn a written contract.

- **Storm Season Clock [8]:** Tracks the approach of the monsoon. When it fills, a typhoon strikes — all travel becomes Desperate for 2 legs. The clock ticks each day during storm season. The Shrine Maidens can delay it by one day for a suitable offering (a tide-charm, a memory, or a promise).
- **Kami Favour (Reputation Track):** Instead of debt, track **Kami Favour [6]**. Gain favour by respecting shrines, winning duels honourably, and appeasing storm-spirits. Spend favour to ask a kami for a boon (see Kami Favour Boons table). At 0 favour, shrines are hostile — all social rolls at shrines are Desperate.
- **Oni Corruption Track [6]:** Represents the influence of the Oni-Eyed's cult and the Crater Oni. Tick when a character makes a bargain with an oni, drinks oni-brewed sake, or speaks the forbidden name. At 3 segments: the character's shadow grows horns. At 6: the character becomes oni-touched — they gain +1 die to intimidation but suffer -1 die to all social rolls with shrine maidens and can never enter a shrine without being attacked.
- **Shogunate Faction Clocks:** Track the three daimyo's schemes:
  - **Southern Serpent's Ambition [6]** — advances when she bribes officials, builds her fleet, or sponsors pirate raids. When full, she declares open war on the Shogun.
  - **Northern Crane's Patience [6]** — retreats when he is humiliated or his allies defect. When it reaches 0, he abandons the Shogun's peace and marches south.
  - **Oni-Eyed's Ascension [8]** — advances each time a character accepts an oni bargain or the party fails to stop a cult ritual. When full, the Crater Oni manifests in the material world.
- **Yokai as Creditors:** Unlike simple monsters, yokai in Nihori treat with travellers. They may offer bargains, demand tolls, or curse those who break taboos. Use the Yokai Encounters table to introduce them, and track any promises made to a yokai as a *Yokai Debt* clock [4]. When it fills, the yokai returns to collect.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
  - **The Storm Emperor's Ghost** — Khemesh + The Witness. \*The pressure of a forbidden name, the memory of a drowned kingdom.\*
  - **The Crater Oni** — Malachai. \*Cursed gifts, bargains that leave scars, power that transforms you from the inside.\*
  - **The Ninth Wave** — Raéyn. \*The storm that does not break, the tide that remembers every sailor.\*
  - **The Bell of Drowned Shrines** — The Sealed Gate. \*The boundary between the living and the dead, guarded by bells and salt.\*

## Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Drowned Capital and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The sunken city is said to contain a temple that holds a fragment of the demon Varash. The Veiled Sisters want it. The Oni-Eyed wants to bargain with it. The Shrine Maidens want it to stay drowned.
- **Tide-Charms and the Tulkani (Way of Silk):** Tulkani story-tellers sometimes carry Lethai-al tide-charms as proof of a witnessed drowning. A charm from Nihori is worth twice as much — and attracts twice as much Hollow attention.
- **Storm-Spirits and the Veiled Sisters (Ashaan):** The Veiled Sisters have tried to bind storm-spirits for use in their fleet. The Lethai-al have foiled nine attempts. The tenth attempt is being funded by the Southern Serpent’s pirate gold.
- **Oni Bargains and the Chain (Bitter Root):** Daughters of the Cord refuse to treat with oni — the interest is always paid in souls, and the Cord cannot collect from a damned spirit. An oni-touched Daughter is a contradiction; one may be hiding in the ash wastes, trying to untie her cord from a Crater Oni’s bargain.
- **The Ninth Wave and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** Aelaerem hedge-keepers say that the ninth wave is the Hollow’s breath. When it crashes, the Hollow exhales. Those who hear it must speak a true name or lose one of their own.

## Nihori Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Foam:** Crumble a crust at the water’s edge. Ignore the first *Pirate Flotilla* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Rope:** Tie a single knot in a shrine climbing rope. Cancel *Storm-Spirit Offended* or take −1 die on your next sailing roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Wave:** Whisper a drowned ancestor’s name into the ninth wave. Gain +1 Effect when navigating a storm this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Hollow. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Sake to the Oni:** Pour a cup of sake onto volcanic stone. Cancel one tick of the *Oni Corruption* track — but the oni will remember your face. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

## Thematic SB Spend Table

### Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **clan retainers or shrine maidens**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **duelists or pirate lookouts**.

- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **oni cultists** or the **Storm-Reader's spies**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favourable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

### Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Local **daimyo's guard** or **shrine keeper** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **ashfall** or **rising water**.
- **Foe Appears:** An **oni-touched ronin** or a **pirate boarding party** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

### Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **oni cultists**, **pirate ships**, or **clan samurai** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**duel becomes a killing** / **volcano trembles** / **ninth wave crests early**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

### Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Shogun's Chamberlain**, **Oni-Eyed**, or **Storm Emperor's Ghost** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**volcano erupts** / **tsunami strikes** / **shrine collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

### Region-Specific SB Options

- **Nihori (Duel Law):** A witness recants, the first blood is disputed, a duelist's story is revealed as false.
- **Nihori (Storm & Kami):** A kami demands a toll, a storm shifts direction, the ninth wave's timing changes.
- **Nihori (Oni Cult):** A shadow grows horns, a memory curdles, an oni bargain's fine print appears.
- **Nihori (Yokai):** A kappa laughs from a riverbank, a tengu's feather falls on your shoulder, a snow woman's breath fogs your vision.

### Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Cut the Duel (Presence + Honour):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a duelist's sake cup is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Wave (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *Ninth Wave Warning*, you pick who keeps their footing; on a miss, the GM does.

### Boss Seeds (Honour & Oni)

- **The Oni-Eyed (Ascended Cultist)** — *Phases:* Whispered Bargain → Horned Shadow → Oni Manifest. *Cracks:* speak his original name, destroy the mask, offer a memory the oni cannot refuse.
- **The Storm Emperor's Ghost (Drowned Sovereign)** — *Phases:* Silent Tide → Wave of Names → The Ninth Breaks. *Cracks:* speak the forbidden name at the Sunken Gate, return the drowned scholar's scroll, let the Storm-Reader negotiate.
- **Southern Serpent (Pirate Admiral)** — *Phases:* Fleet Gathers → Tariff Blockade → Throne Claim. *Cracks:* expose her spy network, sink her flagship, convince the Crane to ally with the Shogun.
- **The Kappa King (Lord of the Freshwater Depths)** — *Phases:* Drown the Ford → Steal the Children → Claim the Well. *Cracks:* return a stolen name, offer a cucumber of great value, survive his grip and pull off his bowl (draining his power).

## Patronage &amp; Power

In Nihori, power flows through duels, storms, the favour of kami, and the dangerous bargains of oni. The Shogun is a figurehead; the three daimyo are the real players. A clan chief's authority rests on how many duels he has won and how many shrines he has funded. A shrine maiden's on how many storms she has predicted and how many oni she has banished. Yokai watch from the margins, ready to lend aid or demand payment.

**For the GM:** Use the **Storm Season Clock** as a visible threat. Let **Duel Law** be a way to resolve conflicts without combat — or a way to escalate them when honour is insulted. Make **Tide-Charms** valuable but dangerous — each use may attract the Hollow or the attention of an oni. Track the three daimyo's **Faction Clocks** as a campaign front; the party's actions can accelerate or delay civil war. Use **Kami Favour** as a reputation currency — players must choose which shrines to support and which kami to appease. The **Storm-Spirit Negotiation** and **Oni Cult Whispers** tables add depth to supernatural encounters, while **Duel Complications** keep combat fresh and honour-bound. Introduce **Yokai Encounters** to make the wilderness feel alive and capricious, and offer **Haunted Blades** to characters willing to accept a curse for power.

# Chapter 4

## Ayokha

*The Monsoon Throne.*

Chen Wei notes: *“The Ayokhan god-king does not rule. He balances – between monsoon and drought, between the nats of the river and the astrologer’s charts. The rain is not weather. It is a negotiation.”*

Ayokha is the land of the Monsoon Throne, where the God-King rules by the rhythm of the rains. Rivers flood, rice terraces glow green, and the wharves are crowded with ships from Dhahara, Sihai, and distant isles. The Lethai-ar witness every contract; the spirit-mediums speak for the nats of the ford – hungry spirits who live in eddies and under bridges. Power is measured in monsoon schedules, silk vouchers, and the favour of the God-King’s astrologer, a man who has not seen the sun in thirty years. The ninth taboo is absolute: never pour the ninth cup, never count the ninth wave, never speak the ninth name. The Hollow watches from the flooded fields.

*“Never refuse a gift of betel leaf. It is an oath of hospitality. Refusing it is an insult that can end a bloodline.”*

— The God-King’s Astrologer

***What do people eat for breakfast?*** *Rice congee with dried shrimp – the rice from the terraces, the shrimp from delta nets. The delta is where the river meets the sea. The sea is the God-King’s mother. The mother is a nat. The nat is hungry.*

***What does a child learn before they can walk?*** *To read the river. Ayokha children are taught the eight currents: Flood, Ebb, Eddy, Whirl, Still, and the ninth – the current that flows upstream. The upstream current is the monsoon’s breath.*

***What is the first thing you notice about a stranger?*** *Their offering. Every traveller carries a gift for the nats – betel leaf, candle, a coin. A generous offering means blessed. A small offering means testing the spirits. No offering means a fool.*

***What is the most common crime?*** *Nat-bribery – but bribery is a negotiation. The nats set the tolls. The merchants pay. The nats spend the offerings. The ash falls on the fields. The circle is the economy.*

***What does no one talk about but everyone knows?*** *The God-King is a puppet. The astrologer is the real ruler. He no longer reads the stars. He reads the nats’ moods. The nats are fickle.*

**Where do people go when they die?** *To the river. Cremated on the ghats. Ashes scattered on the water. The water carries them to the delta. The delta is the land of the nats. The nats decide if they become ancestors or hungry ghosts.*

**How do you apologize for a serious wrong?** *You offer a nat – a spirit of the river, summoned by a medium. The nat hears your apology. If it accepts, the water is calm. If it refuses, the water rises.*

**What is the most important festival?** *The Welcoming of the Monsoon (summer). The God-King stands in the rain. The rain is the nats' blessing. The blessing is measured in inches. The inches determine the harvest.*

**What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person?** *The God-King's daughter is not his daughter. She is the child of the astrologer and a nat, born from a bargain made during a failed monsoon. She can control the rain. She does not know.*

## 4.1 Ayokha — “The Monsoon Throne”

### Quick Reference

**Tagline:** *The rain writes the law. The river witnesses. The ninth cup is for the drowned.*

**God-King’s Astrologer (Elite):** “The monsoon does not come because we pray. It comes because the stars align. I read the stars. I align them. Without me, the rains would fail, the rice would burn, and the kingdom would fall. I am not a servant of the God-King. I am his monsoon.”

**River Merchant (Commoner):** “My boat has more secrets than cargo. The lower deck is for silk. The upper deck is for whispers. The tiller is for favours. I have carried nine spies this year. The ninth was the God-King’s own daughter.”

**Genre / Mood:** Monsoon noir – waterlogged intrigue, spirit bargains, and the tyranny of the rain.

**Starting Location:** A river market on stilts, where boats load silk and spices, and the air smells of brine and betrayal. A Lethai-ar Vigil holds a green lamp: “The God-King’s astrologer has predicted a late monsoon. The merchants are panicking. The rice will fail unless someone makes an offering to the river spirit. You are someone. Go.”

#### Theme & Atmosphere

Ayokha is the land of the Monsoon Throne, where the God-King rules by the rhythm of the rains. Rivers flood, rice terraces glow green like jade stairways, and the wharves are crowded with ships from Dhahara, Sihai, and distant isles. The Lethai-ar witness every contract; the spirit-mediums speak for the *nats* of the ford – hungry spirits who live in eddies and under bridges. Power here is measured in monsoon schedules, silk bales, and the favour of the God-King’s astrologer, a man who has not seen the sun in thirty years. The ninth taboo is absolute: never pour the ninth cup, never count the ninth wave, never speak the ninth name. The Hollow watches from the flooded fields, and the drowned sometimes knock on the hulls of passing boats.

**What you notice first:** The smell of wet earth and fermenting rice, thick as a fever dream. The way every bridge has a spirit shrine at its foot, offerings of betel leaf and candle wax. The constant sound of water — dripping, flowing, raining, whispering.

**The one rule that kills newcomers:** Never refuse a gift of betel leaf. It is an oath of hospitality. Refusing it is an insult that can end a bloodline. And never pour the ninth cup — the ninth is for the river, and the river is always thirsty.

### Regional Mood: The Weight of the Monsoon

Power here is measured in monsoon predictions, silk bales, and the number of spirits placated. The God-King rules from a floating palace, but the astrologer sets the calendar, the Lethai-ar witness the contracts, and the spirit-mediums negotiate with the nats. A merchant who

ignores a nat's demand will find his boat sunk and his name struck from the wharf records. A farmer who disrespects the monsoon will find his fields barren and his children dreaming of drowning. In Ayokha, the rain is not weather – it is a *promise*, and every promise has a season.

## Prominent NPCs of Ayokha

| <small>p0.2</small>     | <small>p0.25</small>      | <small>p0.3</small>                             | <small>p0.15</small>                                              |
|-------------------------|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Name                    | Role/Title                | Motivation                                      | Rumoured Quirk                                                    |
| God-King's Astrologer   | Royal astronomer          | Predict the monsoon before the people starve    | He has not seen the sun in thirty years. He works by candlelight. |
| Vigil Lady Suyin        | Lethai-ar witness-master  | Keep the river's records free of forgeries      | She has cut nine witness cords. The ninth was her own.            |
| River Merchant          | Silk trader               | Smuggle contraband under the God-King's tariffs | She has a hidden deck that only appears at low tide.              |
| Spirit-Medium           | Nat negotiator            | Speak for the spirit of the ford                | She carries a bowl of water; the spirit speaks through ripples.   |
| The Drowned Nat (Ghost) | A spirit of a broken oath | Demand payment before the monsoon fails         | It appears as a wet figure in torn robes. It never blinks.        |

## Names of Ayokha

Inspired by the monsoon kingdoms: soft, flowing consonants, honorifics (Lady, Master). Surnames denote a river, a wharf, or a spirit.

| <small>p0.25</small> | <small>p0.25</small> | <small>p0.2</small> | <small>p0.2</small>    |
|----------------------|----------------------|---------------------|------------------------|
| First Names (Male)   | First Names (Female) | Clan/Epithet        | Monsoon-Name           |
| Hiro                 | Suyin                | River-watch         | <i>the Uncut</i>       |
| Tama                 | Mira                 | Silk-hand           | <i>Ninth Knot</i>      |
| Kaito                | Yuki                 | Lamp-bearer         | <i>Green Flame</i>     |
| Riku                 | Hana                 | Oath-strand         | <i>the Witness</i>     |
| Sora                 | Nami                 | Mud-dyer            | <i>the Unforgotten</i> |

**(Market/Temple/Bridge)** A river market on stilts; a step-pyramid temple with monsoon carvings; a bridge that appears only once a century.

## Spades — Places

2. **River Market (Stilts)** — A floating market where goods are passed from boat to boat. '[COMMERCE]' '[SOCIAL]' *The prices are written in water. They change with the tide.*
  3. **Step-Pyramid Temple** — A stone pyramid rising from the riverbank. Carvings of the first monsoon. '[RELIGION]' '[WEATHER]' *The carvings weep water during the rainy season. The water is holy.*
  4. **Bridge of Three Echoes** — A wooden bridge that appears only once a century. '[MYSTERY]' '[THRESHOLD]' *Those who cross it see three versions of themselves: past, present, and future.*
  5. **Silk Village (Mulberry Groves)** — A village where silk is spun and cords are woven. '[CRAFT]' '[OATH]' *The mulberry trees were planted by the first God-King. Their leaves are sacred.*
  6. **Astrologer's Observatory** — A roofless tower with a bronze armillary sphere. '[MAGIC]' '[SECRET]' *The sphere has nine rings. The ninth ring is broken. The astrologer refuses to fix it.*
  7. **River Court (Floating)** — A barge that serves as a mobile courthouse. '[LAW]' '[SOCIAL]' *The barge is anchored at a different spot each day. The river is the judge.*
  8. **Spirit-Medium's Hut** — A small shelter on the riverbank, surrounded by offering bowls. '[SPIRIT]' '[MYSTIC]' *The bowls are filled with rice, flowers, and small coins. The spirits take the offerings at night.*
  9. **Well of the Drowned Nat** — A stone well where a spirit was trapped. '[DEATH]' '[WEIGHT]' *The well is covered by a stone slab. The slab has nine holes. The spirit breathes through them.*
  10. **God-King's Palace (Floating)** — A wooden palace built on pontoons, anchored in the river. '[AUTHORITY]' '[WEALTH]' *The palace rises and falls with the flood. The God-King never touches dry land.*
- J **The Ninth Terrace** — A rice terrace that is flooded only once every nine years. '[FORBIDDEN]' '[LEGEND]' *The rice grown there is for the God-King alone. Eating it is treason.*
- Q **Monsoon Bell Tower** — A stone tower with a single brass bell. The bell is rung at the first rain. '[WEATHER]' '[RITUAL]' *The bell's tone determines the harvest. A high tone means abundance. A low tone means famine.*
- K **The First Bridge (Myth)** — Where the first God-King crossed the river and claimed the throne. '[LEGEND]' '[THRESHOLD]' *The bridge is invisible. Only those who have witnessed nine true oaths can see it.*

- A **The Monsoon's Eye** — A still pool in the astrologer's observatory. It reflects the sky. '[OMEN]' '[MAGIC]' *The pool shows the future of the monsoon. The astrologer is the only one who can read it.*

(**Merchant/Medium/Vigil**) River merchant with a boat of secrets; spirit-medium with a bowl of water; Lethai-ar Vigil with a green lamp.

## Hearts — People & Factions

2. **River Merchant** — A woman with a brass earring and a hidden deck. She never sails without a bribe. '[COMMERCE]' '[DECEPTION]' *"The tariff is negotiable," she says. "My silence is not."*
  3. **Spirit-Medium** — A woman with a bowl of water. She watches the ripples. '[SPIRIT]' '[SOCIAL]' *"The nat says the river is angry," she says. "Someone broke a promise."*
  4. **Vigil Lady Suyin** — Grey-robed, a green lamp at her hip. She never blinks when witnessing an oath. '[LAW]' '[OATH]' *"The cord will tighten," she says. "I do not need to watch. The river watches for me."*
  5. **God-King's Astrologer** — A pale man in silk robes, surrounded by candles. '[MAGIC]' '[SECRET]' *"The monsoon will be late," he says. "The rice will fail unless..." He trails off.*
  6. **Rice Farmer** — A woman with mud-stained feet and a straw hat. She leaves offerings at the terrace edge. '[SURVIVAL]' '[SPIRIT]' *"The spirits are hungry," she says. "Feed them, or they feed on you."*
  7. **Silk Weaver** — A man with thread between his fingers. He weaves witness cords for the Lethai-ar. '[CRAFT]' '[OATH]' *"The cord must be perfect," he says. "A single flaw can break an oath."*
  8. **Monsoon Bell Ringer** — A young woman who rings the bell at the first rain. She has never been late. '[RITUAL]' '[WEATHER]' *"The rain waits for me," she says. "I do not wait for the rain."*
  9. **Drowned Nat's Ghost** — A wet figure in torn robes, standing by the well. '[DEATH]' '[WEIGHT]' *It asks: "Who sealed me here?" The answer is a name. The name is the God-King's.*
  10. **God-King (Offstage)** — Never seen, rarely heard. His decrees are delivered by astrologer. '[AUTHORITY]' '[MYSTERY]' *Rumour says he is a spirit. Rumour says he is a child. Rumour says he is the river itself.*
- J **The First God-King's Ghost** — A crowned skeleton in the palace's lower deck. '[DEATH]' '[LEGEND]' *He asks: "Is the monsoon still on time?" If you say no, he weeps.*

- Q **Monsoon Spirit (Kami)** — A whirlwind with eyes, seen over the river during storms. ‘[SPIRIT]’ ‘[WEATHER]’ *It asks: “Who rang the bell?” The answer must be the ringer’s name.*
- K **The Ninth Terrace’s Keeper** — An old woman who tends the forbidden rice. ‘[FORBIDDEN]’ ‘[WISDOM]’ *She has never eaten the rice. She has never been tempted.*
- A **Kuva’s Shadow (Hollow)** — A vast darkness that covers the river at midnight. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[HORROR]’ *It asks: “Who poured the ninth cup?” The answer is a name. The name is the speaker’s.*

(**Flood/Rumor/Offense**) The river floods — a bridge is swept away; a rival merchant spreads rumours of cursed silk; the nat of the well is offended — no one may draw water.

## Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **River Floods** — The monsoon rises. The bridge is gone. The wharf is isolated. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DISASTER]’ *The flood is not natural. A river-spirit is angry. An oath was broken upstream.*
3. **Rumour of Cursed Silk** — A merchant claims that a bale of silk is cursed. Trade stops. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DECEPTION]’ *The curse is a lie. The merchant wants to drive down prices.*
4. **Well-Spirit Offended** — A traveller threw trash into the sacred well. The spirit refuses water. ‘[SPIRIT]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’ *The spirit demands an apology. The apology must be an oath. The oath must be witnessed.*
5. **Monsoon Late** — The astrologer’s prediction fails. The rains do not come. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[CRISIS]’ *The astrologer is a fraud. Or the spirits are angry. Either way, the rice is dying.*
6. **Witness Cord Cut (False)** — Someone cuts a witness cord that was tied in good faith. ‘[OATH]’ ‘[BETRAYAL]’ *The cutter is the Vigil’s own apprentice. She thought the oath was false. It was true.*
7. **Silk Village Poisoned** — Someone poisons the mulberry trees. The silkworms die. ‘[CRIME]’ ‘[ECONOMY]’ *The poisoner is a rival merchant. He wants to monopolise the silk trade.*
8. **River-Spirit Demands a Story** — The nat appears at the ford. It asks for a broken oath. ‘[SPIRIT]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’ *It will not leave until someone confesses. The confession must be true.*
9. **God-King’s False Oath** — The king swears a vow he does not intend to keep. The Vigil knows. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[POLITICS]’ *If she exposes him, the king will exile the Lethai-ar. If she stays silent, the cord tightens.*

10. **Astrologer's Betrayal** — The astrologer sells the monsoon schedule to a foreign power. '[TREASON]' '[WAR]' *The foreign power is Ashaan. They want to time an invasion with the floods.*
- J **The Ninth Cup Poured (By Mistake)** — A stranger pours the ninth cup at a river market. The Hollow comes. '[DEATH]' '[TABOO]' *The Hollow asks: "Who poured this cup?" The stranger points at the party.*
- Q **First Bridge Appears** — The mythic bridge manifests. Crossing it grants a new name. '[THRESHOLD]' '[WEIGHT]' *The new name is a promise. The promise is to the first God-King. He will collect.*
- K **Monsoon Bell Cracked** — The bell is struck too hard. It cracks. The tone is wrong. '[SABOTAGE]' '[OMEN]' *The bell-ringer is a spy. She cracked it on purpose. The monsoon will fail.*
- A **The Monsoon Fails** — The rains do not come for nine weeks. The river dries. The Hollow walks. '[APOCALYPSE]' '[DEATH]' *The Hollow asks: "Who failed to ring the bell?" The answer is a name.*

(**Schedule/Voucher/Cord**) Monsoon schedule (predicts safe sailing days); silk voucher (trade goods at 10% profit); Lethai-ar witness cord (enforce any oath).

## Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Monsoon Schedule (Astrologer's Copy)** — A scroll of safe sailing days for the next season. '[TRAVEL]' '[WEATHER]' *The schedule is written on dried palm leaf. The leaf will crumble after use.*
3. **Silk Voucher (Merchant's Seal)** — A stamped document. Trade goods at 10% profit in any Ayokha port. '[COMMERCE]' '[WEALTH]' *The seal is a fish. The fish glows when the voucher is genuine.*
4. **Lethai-ar Witness Cord** — A silk cord dyed with river mud. Enforce any oath. '[OATH]' '[MAGIC]' *The cord tightens when the oath is broken. It will not stop until blood is drawn.*
5. **God-King's Blessing (Scroll)** — A royal decree. One national favour in Ayokha. '[AUTHORITY]' '[SOCIAL]' *The scroll is sealed with river clay. The clay is from the palace's foundation.*
6. **River Merchant's Hidden Deck Key** — A brass key. Access any smuggler's hold on the river. '[STEALTH]' '[CRIME]' *The key is warm. It glows when a customs boat is near.*
7. **Spirit-Medium's Bowl** — A clay bowl. Fill it with water to speak with any river-spirit once. '[SPIRIT]' '[KNOWLEDGE]' *The spirit will answer one question. The answer will be a ripple.*

8. **Vigil's Lamp (Green Flame)** — A small oil lamp. Gain +1 die to social rolls in any Lethai-ar court. '[SOCIAL]' '[TRUTH]' *The flame flickers when someone lies. It also flickers when you lie.*
9. **Silk Weaver's Needle** — A needle carved from a mulberry branch. Tie a witness cord without cutting the silk. '[CRAFT]' '[OATH]' *The needle can also cut a cord without making a sound. Use once.*
10. **Monsoon Bell Tone (Recording)** — A clay cylinder that captured the bell's ring. Play it to summon a monsoon spirit. '[MAGIC]' '[WEATHER]' *The spirit will come. It will demand an offering. The offering must be a promise.*
- J **First Bridge Plank** — A piece of the mythic bridge. Cross any river as if on solid ground once. '[TRAVEL]' '[LEGEND]' *The plank crumbles after use. The first God-King will remember.*
- Q **Ninth Terrace Rice (Grain)** — A single grain from the forbidden terrace. Eat it to gain a vision of the future. '[MAGIC]' '[OMEN]' *The vision is always a flood. The flood is always coming.*
- K **Astrologer's Sphere Ring (Broken)** — The ninth ring from the armillary sphere. Touch it to predict the monsoon's arrival. '[WEATHER]' '[MAGIC]' *The ring is cold. It warms when the rains are nine days away.*
- A **The Monsoon's Eye (Water)** — A vial of water from the astrologer's pool. Drink it to see the future of the harvest. '[VISION]' '[WEIGHT]' *The water tastes of salt. The vision is always a famine. The famine is not inevitable.*

## Monsoon-Spirit Negotiation (d6 Outcomes)

When the party attempts to bargain with a monsoon spirit (at a shrine, during a drought, or at the Monsoon Bell Tower), roll on this table to determine the outcome. The GM sets the initial DV based on the offering (a silk voucher, a story, or a promise witnessed by a Lethai-ar).

| p2cm p10cm              | gray!20 Outcome Result                                                                                                                                                                              |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Critical Success</b> | The spirit grants a <i>Monsoon Schedule</i> (see Diamonds) or advances the Monsoon Clock by -2 (rains arrive early). The spirit may also whisper the location of a hidden spring or a sunken relic. |
| <b>Success</b>          | The spirit delays the drought. The Monsoon Clock does not advance for 1d4 days. Gain +1 <i>River Favour</i> .                                                                                       |
| <b>Partial</b>          | The spirit accepts the offering but demands an additional payment: a broken oath must be confessed, or a ninth cup poured into the river. Gain an <i>Obligation Clock</i> [4].                      |

**Failure** The spirit is offended. The Monsoon Clock advances by +2. All river travel is Desperate for the next leg. The spirit may send a *nat* to harass the party (see Nat Encounters table).

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**Critical Failure** The spirit calls the ninth wave. A flash flood sweeps the area. Test Body + Athletics (DV 5) or be swept away. Lose 1 Supply and gain the *Marked by the Monsoon* condition (all weather hazards are one step worse for the next journey).

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## Nat Encounters (d8)

When the party travels along rivers, crosses bridges, or disturbs spirit shrines, roll on this table for a nat (river-spirit) encounter. Nats are not always hostile — they are keepers of weights.

|         |                     |
|---------|---------------------|
| p1.5cm  | p10cm               |
| gray!20 | <b>d8 Encounter</b> |

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1 **The Toll Nat** — Appears at a ford, demanding a betel leaf or a coin. Refusal capsizes the nearest boat. Payment grants safe passage for one day.

2 **The Drowned Child** — A child's ghost sits on a rock, weeping. It has lost its name. If the party returns it (by speaking the child's true name from a village record), the nat grants a *River Charm* (ignore one flood hazard).

3 **The Serpent Nat (Naga)** — A serpent with golden scales rises from the water. It demands a story about a broken promise. If the story pleases it, the nat blesses the party's boat (+1 Speed for one leg). If the story offends it, the nat capsizes the boat.

4 **The Bridge Nat** — A spirit lives under every bridge. It asks: "Why do you cross?" Answer truthfully (e.g., "to trade," "to flee," "to honour a promise") and the bridge holds. Lie, and the planks splinter.

5 **The Ferryman's Nat** — A hooded figure rows a spectral boat. It offers passage to the other side — but the price is a memory of a living person. Accept and lose a random memory (GM chooses). Refuse and the nat follows the party for 1d4 days, appearing in reflections.

6 **The Well Nat (Drowned)** — A hand reaches out of a well. It holds a wet scroll. The scroll contains a forgotten water right. Taking it angers the nat (must pay a story or a cup of blood). Leaving it earns the nat's gratitude (+1 *River Favour*).

7 **The Laughing Nat** — A trickster spirit that swaps cargo between boats. Roll Wits + Navigation (DV 4) to notice. On failure, the party loses 1 Supply (stolen) and gains 1 random item (a silk scarf, a jar of pickled fish, a forged customs seal).

8 **The Ninth Nat (The Hollow's Breath)** — A figure made of mist and rain. It asks: "Who poured the ninth cup?" The party must answer with a name or a story. If they cannot, the Hollow gains 1 tick on its Attention clock. If they answer with a true regret, the

nat vanishes and the party gains +1 die on their next river roll.

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## Rice Terrace Hazards (d6)

When the party travels through the flooded rice terraces (especially during the monsoon), roll on this table for environmental hazards.

|p1.5cm|p10cm|

gray!20 **d6 Hazard**

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1 **Levee Breach** — Water pours through a crack. Test Body + Athletics (DV 4) to avoid being swept down the terrace. Failure costs 1 Fatigue and 1 Supply (rice washed away).

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2 **Hungry Ghosts (Farmers)** — The spirits of farmers who starved during a drought appear, demanding a share of the harvest. Offer 1 Supply or face a ghost attack (Cap 2, Harm 1).

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3 **Mudslide** — A section of the terrace collapses. Navigation becomes Desperate. Lose 1 segment of progress.

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4 **Crab Swarm** — Thousands of small crabs climb the levees, snapping at ankles. Test Resolve (DV 3) or mark 1 Fatigue. The crabs also eat exposed food — lose 1 Supply if the party fails a Wits + Survival test.

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5 **Sunken Shrine** — A submerged spirit shrine emerges at low water. Investigating reveals a *Ninth Terrace Rice* grain (see Diamonds) but angers the local nat. The nat will demand a story or a promise.

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6 **The Ninth Terrace Opens** — The forbidden terrace floods unexpectedly. The party can harvest a single grain of the sacred rice (requiring three actions, each triggering a Hungry Ghost attack). If they succeed, they gain a *Ninth Terrace Rice* grain — but the God-King's astrologer will sense its theft.

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## Monsoon Omens (d8)

When the party consults the astrologer, reads the sky, or experiences a shift in weather, roll on this table for a prophetic omen that affects upcoming travel or social encounters.

|p1.5cm|p10cm|

gray!20 **d8 Omen**

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1 The river runs red at dawn — a blood promise is overdue. The party's next negotiation with a merchant suffers -1 Position.

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2 The Monsoon Bell rings twice — the astrologer has lied about the schedule. The next weather prediction is automatically wrong.

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3 The Bridge of Three Echoes appears a day early — the Hollow is restless. The first person to cross must test Resolve (DV 4) or gain the *Haunted* condition (nightmares).

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4 A nat asks for a story at the ford. Refusal means the river rises. Accept and tell a true story; the GM gains 1 SB but the party gains +1 *River Favour*.

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5 The Vigil's green lamp burns blue — a witness cord has been cut. The party will encounter a Lethai-ar seeking justice in the next 24 hours.

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6 Rice terraces flood without rain — the God-King has forgotten an offering. The party must perform a *Rain Offering* (costs 1 Supply) or the Monsoon Clock advances by +1.

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7 The Ninth Terrace blooms in winter — the forbidden rice is ready. The keeper is dead. The party can attempt to harvest (see Rice Terrace Hazards) but the astrologer will send guards.

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8 The Monsoon's Eye shows a face — the face is yours, but older. The astrologer will not explain. Gain a *Prophecy Token*: once, reroll a failed roll related to weather or rivers, but the GM may introduce a complication.

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## Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (schedules, vouchers, cords) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **monsoon-omens**—water that flows upstream, a lamp that burns green without oil, a cord that ties itself.

## Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Rain's Due (Shared Clock, size 8):** Every broken promise to a river-spirit, every unpaid offering, every late monsoon payment ticks the clock. The party inherits the God-King's obligation at the start of any adventure set in Ayokha – they begin with 2 ticks already accrued (the old weight). When the clock reaches 4: the astrologer's predictions become unreliable (roll twice for weather, take worse). When it reaches 8: a **Oath-Keeper** rises from the river and demands payment in memories, names, or a season of servitude. Resetting the clock requires a **Monsoon Rite** (downtime, costs 1 XP or a story worth a season's wages) or a sacrifice to the Drowned Nat (a memory or a magical item).
- **Monsoon Clock [6]:** Tracks the approach of the rainy season. When it fills, the monsoon arrives — all river travel becomes Desperate for 2 legs. The clock ticks each day during the dry season. The astrologer can predict the exact day; a successful Wits + Lore test (DV 4) reveals the remaining ticks. The party can slow the clock by performing **Rain Offerings** (betel leaves, silk scraps, or stories) – each offering ticks the clock back by 1, but adds 1 tick to **Rain's Due**.

- **River Court Justice:** Disputes on the river are settled by a floating court. The judge is a Lethai-ar Vigil. The verdict is written on a clay tablet and thrown into the water. If the tablet floats, the verdict is true. If it sinks, the verdict is false — and the judge is drowned. A character may attempt to influence the verdict by offering a bribe (a Diamond or a story) before the tablet is thrown. If the bribe is a story, the GM gains 1 SB; if a Diamond, the judge's verdict tilts in your favour automatically (no test).
- **Betel Leaf Hospitality:** Offering a betel leaf is an oath of hospitality. Refusing is a grave insult. Accepting binds both parties to non-violence for the duration of the visit. Breaking this oath marks 1 Corruption and begins a **River's Grudge [4]** clock. When the clock fills, a nat appears and demands an equal price (1 Harm, a memory, or a public apology).
- **Astrologer's Scroll (Player Resource):** A character who earns the astrologer's trust (or steals his notes) may carry a copy of his calendar. The scroll has 3 pages. Each page can be used to:
  - **Predict the Monsoon:** Once per journey, ask the GM if the weather will turn against you in the next leg. The GM answers truthfully (yes/no).
  - **Forge a Schedule:** Once per session, treat a failed navigation roll as a success, but add 1 tick to **Rain's Due** (the astrologer will notice the forgery eventually).
  - **Blackmail an Official:** Gain +1 Position on social rolls against any Ayokha official who relies on the monsoon schedule (harbor masters, customs officers, grain factors). Using this burns the page.

Refilling the scroll requires a downtime action and a bribe to the astrologer (1 Boon or a story worth a season's gossip).

- **The Ninth Terrace (Forbidden Zone, Mechanic):** The terrace is flooded only once every nine years. The rice grown there is for the God-King alone – eating it is treason. But the rice is also the *only* thing that can cure the monsoon blight (a crop disease that ticks the Monsoon Clock by 2 each day). Entering the Ninth Terrace requires a **Water-Key** (a coral token, acquired from the astrologer or a nat). The terrace is guarded by **Hungry Ghosts** – the spirits of farmers who starved when the monsoon failed. They attack anyone whose **Rain's Due** clock is 4 or higher. Harvesting the rice takes 3 actions. Each action triggers a ghost attack (Resolve test DV 4 or take 1 Fatigue). Success yields a **Ninth Terrace Rice** grain (see Diamonds).
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
  - **The Rain That Waits** – Ikasha. *She Who Sleeps beneath the flood; her dream is the monsoon's hesitation.*
  - **The Unbroken Cord** – Inaea. *The river's memory woven into silk; every oath is a knot.*
  - **The Drowned King** – Khemesh. *Pressure from the deep; the ninth wave is his breath.*

- **The Green Lamp** – The Witness. *The Vigil's flame; it flickers when a lie enters the record.*

## Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Kalrantha Fragment (Malachai, the Chained Angel):** A silver coin that never spends was found floating in the Monsoon's Eye. The astrologer keeps it in a jar of brine. It whispers to him at night — promises of perfect predictions, of rains that never fail. The coin's warmth spreads through the palace like a fever.
- **The Drowned Courier (The Grey Wanderer's Grimoire):** A Breath-less agent drowned in the river last monsoon, but her ghost still carries messages. She appears at midnight on the Bridge of Three Echoes, offering to deliver secrets to the dead. The price is a memory of living sunlight.
- **The Root That Drinks (The Bitter Root):** A Daughter of the Cord has taken refuge in the well of the Drowned Nat. She claims the spirit is not a nat but a Hollowed — one of the High Mother's own, lost when a witness cord was cut. She asks the party to help her re-tie the cord before the monsoon fails.
- **The Ninth Terrace's Promise (Ukwe – Sekogo):** The forbidden rice of the Ninth Terrace is said to be grown from seeds stolen from the Ukwe's roots. The Green Council demands its return, but the God-King refuses. A Sekogo druid offers the party a way to steal the rice without angering the spirits — if they also bring back a vial of water from the Monsoon's Eye.

## Ayokha Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the River:** Crumble a crust into the current. Ignore the first *River Floods* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Cord:** Tie a single knot in a witness cord before using it. Cancel *Witness Cord Cut* or take -1 die on your next oath. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead Vigil's name into the well. Gain +1 Effect when witnessing an oath, but mark *Obligation* to the Monsoon Spirit. '[SUPERSTITION]'

## Thematic SB Spend Table

### Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **river merchants or spirit-mediums**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **bell-ringer or customs boats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **river-spirits or the Vigil**.

- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

### Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised: Local Vigil or spirit-medium** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **flood or fog**.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival **merchant's boat or a river-spirit** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

### Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **spirit-mediums, customs boats, or river-spirits** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **monsoon fails / well runs dry / cord is cut**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

### Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **God-King's Astrologer, Vigil Lady Suyin, or the Drowned Nat** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **flood sweeps the market / bell tower cracks / ninth terrace floods**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears / blessing lost / curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

### Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ayokha (Monsoon Law):** Rain falls upward, the river changes course, a cord ties itself.
- **Ayokha (Spirit Law):** A nat laughs from the well, an offering steams, the Vigil's lamp burns blue.
- **Ayokha (Rice & Silk):** A terrace floods for no reason, a silk bale weeps water, the bell rings twice.

### Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Monsoon Swell*.
- **Cut the Cord (Presence + Lore):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a witness cord is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Flood (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *River Floods*, you pick who keeps their boat; on a miss, the GM does.

### Boss Seeds (Monsoon & Promise)

- **The Rain-Eater (Nine Dry Fields)** — *Phases:* Wells Sinking → Orchestrated Drought → Terrace Coup. *Cracks:* find a hidden spring, expose a false monsoon schedule, survive a night on the Ninth Terrace.
- **The Drowned Vigil (Cord of the River)** — *Phases:* Broken Oaths → Procession of Empty Barges → Flood-Baptism of a Merchant. *Cracks:* relic witness cord, survivor testimony, the bell ringer refusing to strike.

## Patronage &amp; Power

In Ayokha, power flows through the monsoon, the river, and the weight of a witnessed oath. The God-King rules from his floating palace, but the astrologer sets the calendar, the Lethai-ar hold the records, and the spirit-mediums speak for the nats. No one rules alone — and everyone owes a tithe to the rain.

**For the GM:** Use the **Monsoon Clock** as a visible campaign timer — it ticks down to famine or flood. Let **River Court Justice** be a high-stakes social encounter where a single lie can drown a judge. Enforce **Betel Leaf Hospitality** as a binding ritual — breaking it invites the Hollow and advances the **River's Grudge** clock. Offer Diamonds as monsoon schedules, silk vouchers, and witness cords — each a tool to survive the next storm or the next audit. Track **Rain's Due** as the region's central pressure; the party's actions can reduce it (by performing rites or paying sacrifices) or increase it (by breaking oaths or ignoring nats). The God-King's astrologer is a potential ally, but his calendar is for sale to the highest bidder.

The new generator tables — **Monsoon-Spirit Negotiation**, **Nat Encounters**, **Rice Terrace Hazards**, and **Monsoon Omens** — add depth to supernatural encounters and environmental storytelling, drawing inspiration from Southeast Asian mythologies of river spirits, naga serpents, and the sacred balance of rain and rice.

## Chapter 5

# Aelaerem of the Eastern Realms

*The Hollow's Neighbors.*

Chen Wei writes: *“The Aelaerem tie red threads at every crossroads. They leave rice for the Hollow. They count to eight and stop. I asked one why. She said, ‘Because the ninth step is not ours.’ I did not ask again.”*

The Aelaerem of the eastern realms have adapted their hedge-magic to thresholds of a different kind: bamboo groves that whisper in the dark, temple stairs that count your heartbeats, and the silence after a storm bell that has no clapper. Here, the Hollow wears the face of the uncanny – not hunger, but absence. It is the space between two bamboo stalks, the step that is always missing, the name you cannot quite remember. They survive through ritual precision: a red thread tied at a crossroads with exactly eight knots, a bowl of rice left at dusk and never checked until dawn, a single bell rung once and then muffled with cloth washed in salt water.

*“Never count the steps between your door and the crossroads. The Hollow counts with you. If you reach nine, it will be waiting at the ninth step. It will ask, ‘Where are you going?’ Do not answer.”*

— Hedge-Keeper Mila

***What do people eat for breakfast?*** Rice porridge with pickled vegetables – the rice from the paddies, the vegetables salted in clay pots buried at the boundary. The salt is blessed by the hedge-keeper. The vegetables are always a little bitter.

***What does a child learn before they can walk?*** To tie the eight boundary knots. The ninth knot is never tied – it is left loose for the Hollow to find. If a child ties the ninth knot, the Hollow will visit that night.

***What is the first thing you notice about a stranger?*** Their shadow. A shadow too short has been touched by the Hollow. A shadow that moves independently is already lost. No shadow is the Hollow itself, wearing a borrowed face.

***What is the most common crime?*** Thread-theft – stealing a red thread from a boundary marker. The thread is not valuable, but cutting it breaks a promise. The Hollow becomes restless. The thief's shadow shrinks one inch each night.

***What does no one talk about but everyone knows?*** The Hollow is not a single thing. It is a place – the space between heartbeats, the pause before a sneeze, the silence

*after a bell. The Aelaerem guard against the gaps.*

***Where do people go when they die?*** *To the salt. Cremated, ashes mixed with salt and scattered along the boundary. The salt draws the Hollow's attention away from the living. The dead become the new boundary.*

***How do you apologize for a serious wrong?*** *You leave a cup of sake and a lock of hair at the place where the wrong was done. The Hollow will witness. If the sake is gone by dawn and the hair untouched, you are forgiven.*

***What is the most important festival?*** *The Retting of the Threads (spring). All red threads are taken down, washed in salt water, and re-tied. The village is silent for one night. The Hollow listens. If a thread is tied wrong, the Hollow corrects it.*

***What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person?*** *The first red thread was not tied by an Aelaerem. It was tied by the Hollow itself, before it forgot what it was. The thread is still there, at the First Boundary. If it is untied, the Hollow will remember its true name.*

## 5.1 Aelaerem (Eastern) — “The Hollow’s Neighbors”

**Hedge-Keeper (Elite):** “My grandmother taught me that the Hollow is not evil. It is a forgetfulness. It forgets where the boundary lies, forgets that we are not food, forgets that it was once something else. So we remind it. With a thread, a bell, a bowl of salt. We are its memory.”

**Thread-Binder (Commoner):** “I tied a red thread around my wrist this morning. The Hollow walked past my door last night. It saw the thread. It kept walking. That is the bargain. I give it a boundary. It respects the boundary. Mostly. But last week it forgot the thread’s colour. I had to tie two.”

### Theme & Atmosphere

The Aelaerem of the eastern realms have adapted their hedge-magic to thresholds of a different kind: bamboo groves that whisper in the dark, temple stairs that count your heartbeats, and the silence after a storm bell that has no clapper. Here, the Hollow wears the face of the uncanny — not hunger, but absence. It is the space between two bamboo stalks, the step that is always missing, the name you cannot quite remember. They survive through ritual precision: a red thread tied at a crossroads with exactly eight knots, a bowl of rice left at dusk and never checked until dawn, a single bell rung once and then muffled with a cloth that has been washed in salt water. They whisper that the Hollow is the shadow of Kuva, cast when the first sun turned away, and that it wanders the world looking for the name it forgot. Unlike western Aelaerem, who live in close-knit villages, the Eastern Aelaerem are often solitary or live in small family groups—yamabushi of the boundary, shrine hermits of the between. They are the ones who know where the veil is thinnest, and they are the ones paid to keep it closed. Their magic is humble: a knot to bind a promise, a thread to guide a lost ghost, a cup of sake to buy a night’s silence.

**What you notice first:** Red threads tied to every gate, every bridge, every well. The smell of burnt rice and old salt. The way the Aelaerem never whistle after dusk—the Hollow thinks you are calling it. And the way they never, ever count to nine.

**The one rule that kills newcomers:** Never count the steps between your door and the crossroads. The Hollow counts with you. If you reach nine, it will be waiting at the ninth step. It will ask, “Where are you going?” Do not answer.

### Regional Mood: The Weight of the Unspoken

Power here is measured in red threads tied, offerings left, and the gaps between words. The Aelaerem have no leaders, no courts, no written laws. Each hedge-keeper knows her own stretch of boundary. She knows where the Hollow walks, when it is restless, and what gesture will turn it aside. Her authority is not given by any king — it is earned by surviving the uncanny. The Aelaerem are not feared or respected; they are tolerated, because without them the Hollow would seep into every threshold. They are the neighbours of the thing that lives between the notes of a song.

**Starting Location:** A crossroads at dusk, where a red thread is tied around a wooden post. An old Aelaerem woman is pouring a cup of sake onto the ground. She looks up: “The Hollow walked last night. I left salt. It took the salt. It left a single red thread tied around my wrist. It moved. Sleep with that knot, and it will know where you are. Do you want to know where it went? It went toward your camp.”

## The Almanac of Ordinary Days (Eastern Aelaerem)

**What do people eat for breakfast?** *Rice porridge with pickled vegetables—the rice is from the paddies, the vegetables are salted in clay pots buried at the boundary. The salt is blessed by the hedge-keeper. The vegetables are always a little bitter. The bitterness is a reminder.*

**What does a child learn before they can walk?** *To tie the eight boundary knots. The ninth knot is never tied—it is left loose for the Hollow to find. If a child ties the ninth knot, the Hollow will visit that night and ask for a name. The child’s name.*

**What is the first thing you notice about a stranger?** *Their shadow. A stranger whose shadow is too short has been touched by the Hollow. A stranger whose shadow moves independently is already lost. A stranger with no shadow is the Hollow itself, wearing a borrowed face. Do not invite them in.*

**What is the most common crime?** *Thread-theft—stealing a red thread from a boundary marker. The thread is not valuable, but cutting it breaks a promise. The Hollow becomes restless. The thief is marked: their shadow will shrink one inch each night until they return the thread.*

**What does no one talk about but everyone knows?** *The Hollow is not a single thing. It is a place—the space between heartbeats, the pause before a sneeze, the silence after a bell. The Aelaerem do not guard against a monster. They guard against the gaps.*

**Where do people go when they die?** *To the salt. The dead are cremated, and their ashes are mixed with salt and scattered along the boundary. The salt draws the Hollow’s attention away from the living. The dead become the new boundary. They do not rest. They watch.*

**How do you apologize for a serious wrong?** *You leave a cup of sake and a lock of hair at the place where the wrong was done. The Hollow will witness. If the sake is gone by dawn and the hair is untouched, you are forgiven. If the hair is gone, the Hollow has taken your apology as a promise. You are now bound. Do not break that promise.*

**What is the most important festival?** *The Retting of the Threads (spring). All red threads on the boundary are taken down, washed in salt water, and re-tied. The village is silent for one night—no bells, no songs, no whispers. The Hollow listens. The Hollow remembers. If a thread is tied wrong, the Hollow will correct it. The correction is always a death.*

**What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person?** *The first red thread was not tied by an Aelaerem. It was tied by the Hollow itself, before it forgot what it was. The thread is still there, at the First Boundary. If it is untied, the Hollow will*

*remember its true name. Then it will stop being hungry. It will become something else.  
No one knows what.*

## Prominent NPCs of the Eastern Aelaerem

| <small>p0.2</small>      | <small>p0.25</small>                      | <small>p0.3</small>                                                | <small>p0.15</small>                                                                                 |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Name                     | Role/Title                                | Motivation                                                         | Rumoured Quirk                                                                                       |
| Hedge-Keeper Mila        | Warden of the Moss Road                   | Keep the Hollow from crossing into the lowlands                    | She has never slept indoors. She sleeps at the boundary, on a bed of salt.                           |
| Thread-Binder Yuki       | Ties red threads at crossroads            | Bind the Hollow's path before it reaches the village               | She carries a spindle of red thread that never runs out—but it grows shorter each year.              |
| Offering-Keeper Taro     | Leaves rice and salt at dusk              | Feed the Hollow's forgetfulness so it does not remember the living | He has not eaten rice in nine years. He gives it all away. His shadow has begun to fade.             |
| Bell-Muffler Rin         | Rings and silences copper bells           | Signal to the Hollow that the boundary is attended                 | She wears earplugs made of wax and salt. She does not need to hear the bell—she feels its vibration. |
| The Oath-Keeper (Hollow) | A spirit that collects unpaid obligations | Demand the ninth cup, the ninth step, the forgotten name           | It appears as a shadow with too many fingers. It never speaks first. It smells of old salt.          |

## Names of the Eastern Aelaerem

Inspired by the rural traditions of the eastern islands and coast: short, earthy, often with repeated syllables. Surnames denote a boundary, a thread, or a shrine.

| <small>p0.25</small> | <small>p0.25</small> | <small>p0.2</small> | <small>p0.2</small>    |
|----------------------|----------------------|---------------------|------------------------|
| First Names (Male)   | First Names (Female) | Clan/Epithet        | Thread-Name            |
| Taro                 | Mila                 | Hedge-kin           | <i>the Uncrossed</i>   |
| Ren                  | Yuki                 | Thread-born         | <i>Ninth Knot</i>      |
| Kai                  | Rin                  | Bell-muffler        | <i>the Silent</i>      |
| Sho                  | Nami                 | Offering-hand       | <i>Boundary-Keeper</i> |
| Jiro                 | Hana                 | Root-walker         | <i>the Still</i>       |

**(Crossroads/Threshold/Well)** A crossroads with a red thread tied around a post; a threshold with a missing ninth step; a well with a bowl of rice at its base and a bell on a frayed rope.

## Spades — Places (Eastern)

2. **Crossroads of the Red Thread** [BOUNDARY] [OMEN]  
 A wooden post at a meeting of three paths, wrapped in red cord.  
*The thread is retied each new moon. The Hollow cannot cross a fresh knot—but it can wait.*
  
3. **Threshold of the Missing Step** [THRESHOLD] [TRAP]  
 A doorway with eight steps leading up. The ninth is absent.  
*The gap is a handspan wide. Step over it. Do not step in it. The Hollow is below, counting.*
  
4. **Offering Well** [RITUAL] [DEBT]  
 A stone well where rice and salt are left at dusk.  
*The offerings are gone by dawn. The Hollow takes them. Sometimes it leaves a thread—or a finger bone.*
  
5. **Boundary Stone** [BOUNDARY] [COLD]  
 A moss-covered rock that marks where the Hollow's territory begins.  
*The stone is warm on one side and cold on the other. The cold side is the Hollow's. Touch it, and you will dream of forgetfulness.*
  
6. **Hedge-Keeper's Hut** [REFUGE] [LIMINAL]  
 A small shelter built exactly on the boundary line.  
*The door faces both ways. Inside, the floor is split—one half is safe, one half is not. Guests sleep on the safe half. The hedge-keeper sleeps on the line.*
  
7. **Thread-Binder's Stall** [TRADE] [WARD]  
 A cart where red thread is sold by the knot.  
*The thread is dyed with hibiscus and iron filings. The Hollow is repelled by iron—but the hibiscus attracts it. The balance is careful.*
  
8. **Bell-Muffler's Shrine** [RITUAL] [SILENCE]  
 A small stone shrine with a copper bell on a rope.  
*The bell is rung once at dusk, then muffled with a leather strap soaked in salt water. The Hollow hears the ring but not the silence. The silence is the boundary.*
  
9. **Rice Paddy of the Uncut Stalk** [HARVEST] [OMEN]  
 A field where one stalk is never cut.  
*The uncut stalk is an offering. The Hollow takes one grain each night. When the stalk is bare, the Hollow will walk through the paddy. No one sleeps that night.*
  
10. **Oath-Keeper's Path** [DEATH] [CURSE]  
 A straight line of bare earth through the grass, seen only at dawn.  
*The path was walked by an Oath-Keeper. Follow it, and you will find what it was collecting—or it will find you.*

**J The Hollow's Door (Seasonal)** [THRESHOLD] [DANGER]

A crack in a hillside that appears only on the new moon.

*The crack is warm. It smells of old salt and forgotten names. Do not enter. If you do, leave a thread behind you. You may need it to find your way out.*

**Q The Ninth Cup's Altar** [RITUAL] [TABOO]

A stone table with eight cups. The ninth spot is empty.

*The ninth cup is for the Hollow. If you pour it, you must drink with it—or the Hollow will drink from your shadow.*

**K Thread Tree** [OMEN] [MEMORY]

An old pine covered in red threads, each tied by a different hand.

*The threads are promises to the Hollow. Untie one, and the Hollow will remember the promise as broken. The tree will weep sap. The sap is salt.*

**A The First Boundary (Myth)** [MYTH] [PERMANENT]

Where the first Aelaerem tied the first red thread—or where the Hollow tied it for them.

*The thread is still there. It has never been retied. It is older than memory. It is beginning to fray.*

**(Keeper/Binder/Muffler)** Hedge-Keeper Mila with a red thread around her wrist and a pouch of salt; Thread-Binder Yuki with a spindle of red thread that hums; Bell-Muffler Rin with earplugs of wax and salt.

**Hearts — People & Factions (Eastern)****2. Hedge-Keeper** [AUTHORITY] [KNOWLEDGE]

Old, grey-haired, a red thread tied around her left wrist. She never enters a house.

*"The Hollow watches the thresholds," she says. "I sleep where it cannot see—on the boundary line, where it can see everything. The seeing is the ward."*

**3. Thread-Binder** [CRAFT] [RITUAL]

A young woman with a spindle of red thread. She ties knots at crossroads.

*"A fresh knot each new moon," she says. "The Hollow respects the new thread. For a while. Then the thread forgets, and we tie again."*

**4. Offering-Keeper** [SACRIFICE] [HUNGER]

A man with a bowl of rice and a pouch of salt. He leaves them at dusk.

*"The Hollow is forgetful," he says. "Feed it salt, and it remembers the boundary. Feed it rice, and it forgets to be hungry. Feed it nothing, and it remembers you."*

**5. Bell-Muffler** [RITUAL] [SILENCE]

A woman with wax earplugs and a copper bell on a rope. She rings it at dusk, then muffles it.

*“The Hollow hears the ring. It knows we are watching. The silence is the boundary. If I forget to muffle it, the Hollow will hear the silence as an invitation.”*

6. **Oath-Keeper (Visible)** [SPIRIT] [DEBT]  
 A tall shadow with too many fingers. It walks the path at midnight.  
*It does not speak. It points. The direction is where a debt is owed. If it points at you, you have until dawn to pay.*
  
7. **Thread-Cutter (Exile)** [EXILE] [CURSE]  
 A man who cut a red thread. He is marked by the Hollow.  
*His shadow is missing. The Hollow took it. He follows his shadow’s memory. He will never find it.*
  
8. **Rice Farmer (Boundary-Knower)** [HARVEST] [KNOWLEDGE]  
 A woman who leaves one stalk uncut each harvest.  
*“The Hollow takes one grain a night,” she says. “When the stalk is bare, I move my family to the other side of the paddy. The Hollow follows the stalk, not us.”*
  
9. **Hollow-Watcher Child** [OMEN] [PERCEPTION]  
 A boy who can see the Hollow when it walks. He points.  
*He never speaks. He only points. The adults throw salt where he points. The salt does not stop the Hollow—it just reminds it of the boundary.*
  
10. **Boundary Breaker (Desperate)** [DESPERATION] [DEBT]  
 A traveller who crossed the boundary without an offering.  
*The Hollow followed him. He asks the Aelaerem for help. The price is a story—a true story, one that ends with a promise kept.*
  
- J **The First Hedge-Keeper (Ghost)** [GHOST] [MYTH]  
 A translucent figure tying a thread at the mythic boundary.  
*She asks: “Is the thread still there?” If you say yes, she smiles. If you say no, she weeps. Her tears are salt.*
  
- Q **The Hollow’s Voice** [SPIRIT] [OMEN]  
 A whisper from the crack in the hillside. It speaks in counting rhymes.  
*“One, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight,” it says. Then it stops. It never says nine. It is waiting for someone else to say it.*
  
- K **The Thread Tree’s Keeper** [MEMORY] [AUTHORITY]  
 An old woman who tends the pine. She knows every thread’s story.  
*“This thread was tied by a mother who lost her child,” she says. “The Hollow did not take the child. It took the thread. The child is still alive, somewhere, on the other side of the boundary.”*
  
- A **Kuva’s Shadow (The Hollow Itself)** [SPIRIT] [CURSE]  
 A vast darkness that covers the boundary at midnight.  
*It asks: “Who tied the first thread?” The answer is a name no one remembers. If you guess, it will know you are lying. If you stay silent, it will wait.*

**(Ashes/Cut/Step)** Ash from a burnt offering—the Hollow has been fed; a cut red thread—the boundary is broken; a missing step—the Hollow has crossed.

## Clubs — Complications/Threats (Eastern)

2. **Cut Red Thread** [BOUNDARY] [VIOLATION]  
 Someone cut a boundary thread. The Hollow crosses. The village is at risk.  
*The cutter is a stranger who did not know. Ignorance is not a defence. The Hollow demands a new thread—tied with a drop of the cutter’s blood.*
3. **Hollow Walks (Debt Called)** [DEBT] [SPIRIT]  
 An Oath-Keeper appears at the crossroads. It points at a party member.  
*The member owes a debt. The debt is forgotten. The Hollow remembers. Pay in story, memory, or a name you have never spoken.*
4. **Missing Offering** [RITUAL] [HUNGER]  
 The offering bowl is empty at dawn. The Hollow took it and left a mark.  
*The mark is a single red thread tied around the bowl in a knot that has no end. The Hollow wants more. It will return tomorrow.*
5. **Bell Not Muffled** [RITUAL] [ALERT]  
 Someone rings a bell at dusk and does not silence it. The Hollow hears.  
*The Hollow follows the sound. It will arrive at midnight. Muffle the bell before then—or ring it nine times, and the Hollow will think you are inviting it to count.*
6. **Ninth Step Taken** [TABOO] [TRAP]  
 A traveller counts the steps to a threshold and reaches nine. The Hollow appears.  
*The Hollow asks: “Who counted?” The traveller points at the party. The party must answer. The correct answer is silence.*
7. **Ninth Cup Poured** [TABOO] [DEBT]  
 A stranger pours the ninth cup at a hedge-keeper’s table. The Hollow drinks.  
*The Hollow is now a guest. It will not leave until it is offered a story. The story must be true. If the story is sad, the Hollow will weep salt. If the story is happy, the Hollow will forget it by morning.*
8. **Thread Tree Burned** [DESTRUCTION] [CURSE]  
 Someone sets fire to the pine. The threads burn. The promises are broken.  
*The Hollow is furious. It will walk every boundary. The Aelaerem cannot stop it alone. The party must help re-tie each thread from memory—or the Hollow will take one memory from each villager.*
9. **Boundary Stone Moved** [BOUNDARY] [SHIFT]  
 A traveller moves the moss-covered rock. The boundary shifts.  
*The Hollow now owns a new stretch of land. The village must negotiate. The negotiator is the party. The Hollow’s price is always a promise. Do not promise what you cannot keep.*

**10. Oath-Keeper's Path Crossed** [CURSE] [DEBT]

The party camps on the straight line of bare earth. The Hollow comes.

*It asks: "Why are you on my path?" The answer must be a promise. Break it, and you become an Oath-Keeper—a shadow that walks the path forever, collecting debts.*

**J Hollow's Door Opens** [THRESHOLD] [DANGER]

The crack in the hillside widens. Cold air pours out.

*The Hollow invites the party inside. The invitation is a test. Refuse, and the Hollow is offended. Accept, and you may not return—or you may return with a memory you did not have before.*

**Q Thread-Cutter's Shadow Returns** [SPIRIT] [DEBT]

The exile's shadow appears at the boundary. It is looking for him.

*The shadow asks: "Where is my body?" The body is the exile. He is hiding. Do not tell. The shadow will offer a bargain: a year of safety in exchange for the exile's name.*

**K First Thread Untied** [MYTH] [CURSE]

Someone unties the mythic thread at the First Boundary. The Hollow is free.

*The Hollow spreads across the land. The Aelaerem have one day to re-tie the thread. The party must help. The thread must be tied with a hair from each villager. One hair. One knot. The ninth knot is the Hollow's.*

**A Kuva's Shadow Falls** [CURSE] [DARKNESS]

The Hollow covers the sun. Day becomes night. The boundary is invisible.

*The Hollow asks every person: "What is your name?" Answer, and it knows you. Refuse, and it takes your shadow. The only defence is to speak a name that is not yours—a name you borrowed, a name you forgot, a name that belongs to the dead.*

**(Thread/Cup/Stone)** Red thread bundle (one safe crossing); Hollow cup (proof of a debt paid in memory); offering plate (right to camp in a dangerous spot).

## Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (Eastern)

**2. Red Thread Bundle** [WARD] [ONCE]

A bundle of red-dyed thread. Tie it at a crossroads to mark a safe boundary for one night.

*The thread glows faintly at dusk. The Hollow will not cross—but it will wait until dawn.*

**3. Hollow Cup (Clay)** [PROOF] [DEBT]

A clay cup that has been used for a Hollow offering. Present it to prove a debt was paid.

*The cup is warm. It smells of old salt and forgotten names. The Hollow will recognise it—and it will remember the debt as settled.*

**4. Offering Plate (Wooden)** [REFUGE] [ONCE]

A wooden plate used for rice offerings. Camp anywhere on the boundary for one night.

*The plate is carved with eight circles. The ninth is missing. Place it on the ground, and the Hollow will see the offering, not you.*

5. **Thread-Binder's Spindle (Iron)** [WARD] [ONGOING]  
 A spindle of red thread that never runs out—but grows shorter each year. Tie an unbreakable boundary.  
*The thread is cold. It will not burn. The Hollow cannot cross it. Use once per session. Each use shortens the spindle by one handspan. When it reaches the ninth handspan, it will break.*
6. **Bell-Muffler's Strap (Leather)** [SILENCE] [ONCE]  
 A leather strap soaked in salt water. Muffle any bell to hide its sound from the Hollow.  
*The strap is stiff with salt. The Hollow cannot hear a bell muffled by it—but it can smell the salt. It will know someone is nearby.*
7. **Boundary Stone Fragment** [SENSE] [ONGOING]  
 A chip of the moss-covered rock. Touch it to sense the nearest boundary line.  
*The fragment is cold on one side. The cold side points to the Hollow. The warm side points to safety. The warmth fades each time you use it.*
8. **Oath-Keeper's Finger (Bone)** [SUMMON] [ONCE]  
 A dried finger bone from an Oath-Keeper. Use it to call an Oath-Keeper once.  
*The Oath-Keeper will collect one debt for you. Then it will ask for yours. The finger bone will turn to dust.*
9. **Hedge-Keeper's Salt Pouch** [BANISH] [ONCE]  
 A leather pouch of salt blessed by a hedge-keeper. Throw it to banish an Oath-Keeper for one scene.  
*The salt is bitter. The Oath-Keeper will taste it. It will remember your face. It will not forget.*
10. **Ninth Cup's Altar Shard** [NEGOTIATION] [ONCE]  
 A piece of the stone altar. Pour a cup of sake on it to summon the Hollow for negotiation.  
*The Hollow will come. It will listen. It will not attack—unless you lie. If you lie, it will take your voice.*
- J **Thread Tree Branch** [WARD] [PERMANENT]  
 A branch from the pine, still covered in red threads. Plant it to create a new boundary.  
*The branch will grow. The threads will remain. The Hollow will respect the new tree—for a generation. Then the threads will fade, and the tree will need new ones.*
- Q **First Hedge-Keeper's Thread (Fragment)** [PERMANENT] [ONCE]  
 A piece of the mythic first thread. Touch it to any boundary to make it permanent.  
*The thread is old. It crumbles after use. The boundary will last a century—or until the Hollow forgets it is there.*

**K The Hollow's Name (Whisper)** [COMMAND] [ONCE]

A single word: the name the Hollow had before it became forgetful.

*Speak it, and the Hollow will stop for one minute. Then it will remember why it is hungry. Use once. It will not work a second time.*

**A Kuva's Shadow (Glass Shard)** [FORGET] [ONCE]

A piece of green glass that contains a fragment of the Hollow's original form.

*Once, touch it to make the Hollow forget a debt. The shard will shatter. The Hollow will not forget who broke it. It will remember your face forever.*

## Quick use notes (Eastern)

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (threads, cups, plates) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **boundary-omens**—a red thread that ties itself, a cup that pours without a hand, a step that counts itself, a shadow that points.

## Additional Features (Eastern Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Empty Cup (Eastern):** Once per journey, when you are lost or pursued, you may pour a cup of sake or water onto the ground and whisper a name that is not yours. The Hollow will lead you away from danger—but you will forget one minor memory (the GM chooses a trivial fact; if you have no minor memories, advance the Hollow Attention clock [4]). The forgotten memory can be recovered by returning to the same spot and speaking your own name.
- **Neighbor's Courtesy (Eastern):** When camping, if you leave a small offering (rice, salt, a button) at the edge of the light, the night's travel hazard roll is made with Advantage (roll twice, take the less severe). If you forget three nights in a row, the Hollow begins to watch. Start a Hollow Attention clock [4].
- **Kuva's Eavesdrop (Eastern):** Once per night, if you sleep under open sky, you may ask one yes/no question about the next day's weather; the GM answers truthfully, but the question must be whispered to the wind. On a 1, the wind answers but the Hollow also hears. The Hollow will remember the question.
- **Red Thread Binding (Eastern):** You may tie a red thread around an object or a threshold to ward against minor spirits (Cap 1) for one scene. If the thread is cut, the spirits notice—start a Spirit Attention clock [4]. If the thread is tied with exactly eight knots, the ward lasts until dawn.

- **The Unspoken Step (Eastern):** When crossing a threshold, you may choose to take only eight steps. The ninth step is a gap. The Hollow cannot cross a gap it cannot count. If you take nine steps, the Hollow will follow. This is not a superstition. It is a fact.

### Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks — Eastern)

- **Red Threads and the Lethai-ar (Crimson Valley):** Lethai-ar witness cords are sometimes dyed with the same hibiscus and iron as Aelaerem boundary threads. A witness cord tied with Aelaerem red thread is considered unbreakable—but the Hollow will watch the witness.
- **The Hollow’s Name and the Breath-less (Ashaan):** The name of the Hollow is said to be a forgotten aspect of Ikasha—the part of her that did not fall asleep. Breath-less agents sometimes whisper the name to distract Oath-Keepers. The Hollow does not appreciate being used as a tool.
- **Boundary Stones and the Mountain Satrapies (Dhahara):** Aeler engineers have tried to replicate Aelaerem boundary stones using breath-bonds. The attempt failed; the mountain does not recognise iron. The Hollow, however, is very interested in the attempt.
- **The Ninth Cup and the Tulkani (Way of Silk):** Tulkani caravans never pour a ninth cup even when not in Aelaerem territory. The custom spread from the hedge-keepers. A Tulkani who pours a ninth cup is exiled—not by the caravan, but by the road. The road will forget them.
- **The Hollow’s Hunger and the Savage Heart (The Wilds):** In the deep wilderness, the Hollow is sometimes conflated with the Red Maw—a bear-spirit of endless appetite. Aelaerem hedge-keepers leave offerings of raw meat at the boundary during winter, when the Hollow is said to wear fur. The meat is always salted. The Hollow prefers salt.

### Eastern Aelaerem Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Boundary:** Crumble a crust at the base of a boundary stone. Ignore the first *Cut Red Thread* penalty.
- **Knot the Thread:** Tie a single knot in a red thread at a crossroads. Cancel *Ninth Step Taken* or take −1 die on your next stealth roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Hollow:** Whisper a dead hedge-keeper’s name into the empty cup. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating with the Hollow this scene, but mark *Obligation* to Kuva.
- **Salt to the Shadow:** Throw a pinch of salt over your shoulder at dusk. The next time the Hollow walks, it will hesitate for one exchange. The salt must be from a hedge-keeper’s pouch. Any other salt will attract it.

## Patronage &amp; Power (Eastern)

Among the Aelaerem, power flows through threads, offerings, and the memory of the boundary. A Hedge-Keeper's authority rests on how long she has kept the Hollow at bay—and how many offerings she has given. There are no kings, no councils, no written laws—only the boundary, and the knowledge of where it lies. And the Hollow, always listening.

**For the GM:** Power in Eastern Aelaerem society is measured in threads tied, offerings given, and boundaries maintained. Patronage often takes the form of red thread bundles, hollow cups, or offering plates—each tied to a specific crossroads, threshold, or debt. To emphasize the folk horror and ritual precision:

- Use **The Empty Cup** as a desperate escape tool, but with a real cost (forgotten memories, Hollow Attention).
- Enforce **Neighbor's Courtesy** — offerings matter. A party that forgets to leave offerings will attract the Hollow. The Hollow is patient.
- Let **Kuva's Eavesdrop** be a useful divination, but with a risk of Hollow attention on a roll of 1. The Hollow listens to questions.
- Track **Red Thread Binding** as a temporary ward; cut threads have consequences. The consequences are always a visit.
- Introduce **The Unspoken Step** as a recurring tension—players must remember to count to eight, not nine. The GM can spend SB to have them forget.

In Eastern Aelaerem society, the boundary forgets nothing—and the Hollow remembers every thread, every cup, every step. The Hollow is not evil. It is forgetful. But it is learning to remember.

# Chapter 6

## Aelinnel of the Inland Sea

*The Bell-Tenders.*

Chen Wei taps his quill: *“The Aelinnel count everything – steps, bells, offerings – because precision is their armour against the tide. They do not fear the sea. They fear a miscount.”*

The Aelinnel of the East do not hide from the spirits; they coexist. Small spirits inhabit every rock, tree, and wave. The Aelinnel have learned to negotiate with them using copper bells, precise counting, and occasional offerings of pickled plums. They are the engineers of shrines, the builders of floating bridges, and the keepers of the bell-lines that keep tide-spirits from straying. Some say Kuva, the sky, taught them the first counting song, and that the Hollow is simply the space where the count fails. Unlike their western kin, the Eastern Aelinnel practice a folk mathematics that blends logic and superstition. Every spirit has a number-name – a frequency that can be rung out of a bell, a sequence of steps that can be walked, a knot that can be tied. To offend a spirit is to miscount.

*“Never count to nine aloud near a shrine. The spirits count with you. When you reach nine, they will ask: ‘What comes after nine?’ The answer is always the Hollow.”*

— Bell-Warden Tumble

***What do people eat for breakfast?*** Rice porridge with pickled plums – the plums fermented in salt brine and stored in copper-lidded barrels. The brine is never poured out; it is passed down through generations.

***What does a child learn before they can walk?*** To count the eight safe numbers. Children count pebbles, footsteps, and bell-rings – but always stop at eight. A child who says nine aloud is sent to sit by the missing plank until they forget they ever said it.

***What is the first thing you notice about a stranger?*** Their fingers. Tide-counters often have only eight fingers – the ninth was a miscount they paid for. Nine fingers means never made a mistake. Seven means paid a heavy debt. No fingers means either a spirit or someone who counted to nine and lost everything.

***What is the most common crime?*** Bell-theft – not for the copper. A stolen bell can be rung at the wrong time, creating a miscount. The thief is given to the tide-spirit whose count was broken.

***What does no one talk about but everyone knows?*** The First Bell was not cast by an Aelinnel. It was found already ringing, already counting. Its shards are scattered

*across the Inland Sea. When the ninth shard is found, the First Bell will ring again.*

***Where do people go when they die?*** *To the bell-line. Ashes mixed with copper dust and cast into new bells. The bells are hung on the bell-lines. When the tide-spirits ring them, the dead speak.*

***How do you apologize for a serious wrong?*** *You offer a count – a public recitation of the wrong, spoken in eights. Then you wait. If a spirit rings a bell eight times, you are forgiven. If it rings nine times, you are cursed.*

***What is the most important festival?*** *The Retuning of the Bells (autumn). Every bell is struck once in sequence, from highest tide to lowest. The sound travels for miles. If a bell is out of tune, the spirits will correct it by morning. The correction is always a death.*

***What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person?*** *The ninth bell was never meant to be cast. It was a mistake – a foundry worker poured one bell too many. It rang once on its own. The tone was the Hollow's name. The bell still exists, buried under a shrine on a small island.*

## 6.1 Aelinnel — “The Bell-Tenders of the Inland Sea”

### Quick Reference

**Tagline:** *Count to eight. Stop. The ninth is for the Hollow.*

**Bell-Warden of the Seventh Tide (Elite):** “The Hollow is not a place. It is a miscount. The ninth step that is never there, the ninth cup that is never poured, the ninth name that is never spoken. We do not fight the Hollow. We leave one empty chair, one unlit lamp, one uncounted stone. That is the price of sitting at the table.”

**Tide-Counter (Commoner):** “I asked an Aelinnel bell-tender how she kept the tide-spirits from flooding her village. She tapped her temple. ‘I count them,’ she said. ‘One, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight. Then I stop. They know that if I ever count nine, I am not counting them.’”

**Genre / Mood:** Folk mathematics, coastal spirit-bargaining, horror of the miscount.

**Starting Location:** A floating shrine on the Inland Sea, where copper bells hang from every corner. A Bell-Warden rings a bell eight times, then stops: “The tide-spirit is restless. It wants a ninth bell. I will not give it. You — count the waves. Tell me how many break before the sun sets. If you miscount, the spirit will ask you for a story. Do not miscount.”

#### Theme & Atmosphere

The Aelinnel of the East do not hide from the spirits — they coexist. Small spirits inhabit every rock, tree, and wave. The Aelinnel have learned to negotiate with them using copper bells, precise counting, and occasional offerings of pickled plums. They are the engineers of shrines, the builders of floating bridges, and the keepers of the bell-lines that keep tide-spirits from straying. Some say Kuva, the sky, taught them the first counting song, and that the Hollow is simply the space where the count fails. Unlike their western kin, who lean toward the Gift of the Mind, the Eastern Aelinnel practice a folk mathematics that blends logic and superstition. They believe every spirit has a number-name — a frequency that can be rung out of a bell, a sequence of steps that can be walked, a knot that can be tied. To offend a spirit is to miscount.

**What you notice first:** The sound of copper bells — not ringing in sequence, but chiming in overlapping waves. The way every bridge has a missing ninth plank. The smell of pickled plums and salt.

**The one rule that kills newcomers:** Never count to nine aloud near a shrine. The spirits count with you. When you reach nine, they will ask: “What comes after nine?” The answer is always the Hollow.

### Regional Mood: The Weight of the Count

Power here is measured in bells rung, tides predicted, and the precision of a threshold. The Aelinnel have no kings or councils; their authority rests on the bell-wardens who maintain

the shrines and the tide-counters who read the waves. A village that loses its bell-warden is a village that the tide-spirits will flood. A bridge without its ninth plank missing is a bridge that the Hollow will cross. The Aelinnel do not worship the spirits; they transact with them. An offering is not a prayer — it is a payment. A bell is not a musical instrument — it is a contract.

## Prominent NPCs of the Aelinnel

| <small>p0.2</small>    | <small>p0.25</small>              | <small>p0.3</small>                               | <small>p0.15</small>                                                         |
|------------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Name                   | Role/Title                        | Motivation                                        | Rumoured Quirk                                                               |
| Bell-Warden Tumble     | Keeper of the Seventh Tide        | Keep the bell-lines ringing and the Hollow at bay | He writes letters on copper wax; the wax is his only memory.                 |
| Tide-Counter Mira      | Reader of the ninth wave          | Predict the flood before it comes                 | She counts on her fingers but has only eight. The ninth is a phantom.        |
| Shrine-Builder Orin    | Engineer of floating shrines      | Build a bridge that never needs a missing plank   | He uses no nails; the wood is joined by counting songs.                      |
| Spirit-Negotiator Luma | Bargainer with tide-spirits       | Trade pickled plums for safe passage              | She has never lost a negotiation. The spirits fear her.                      |
| The Miscount (Ghost)   | A bell-warden who counted to nine | Warn others of the Hollow's attention             | It appears as a flickering shadow, holding one copper bell that never rings. |

## Names of the Aelinnel

Inspired by the inland sea cultures: short, melodic, often with doubled consonants. Surnames denote a tide, a shrine, or a counting song.

| <small>p0.25</small> | <small>p0.25</small> | <small>p0.2</small> | <small>p0.2</small>     |
|----------------------|----------------------|---------------------|-------------------------|
| First Names (Male)   | First Names (Female) | Clan/Epithet        | Bell-Name               |
| Tumble               | Mira                 | Seventh Tide        | <i>the Nine-Counter</i> |
| Orin                 | Luma                 | Copper-kin          | <i>Bell-Born</i>        |
| Kellen               | Nori                 | Wave-reader         | <i>the Unrung</i>       |
| Pip                  | Suki                 | Shrine-hand         | <i>Ninth Plank</i>      |
| Rinn                 | Tali                 | Counting-song       | <i>the Still Bell</i>   |

**(Shrine/Bridge/Cove)** A floating shrine with copper bells; a bridge with a missing ninth plank; a spirit cove where offerings are left.

## Spades — Places

2. **Floating Shrine (Copper Bells)** — A wooden platform on pontoons, hung with bells. *The bells ring when a spirit passes. The tone tells if the spirit is friendly.* ‘[SPIRIT]’
  3. **Bridge of the Missing Plank** — A wooden bridge with eight planks. The ninth is absent. *The gap is exactly one foot wide. Step over it. Do not step in it.* ‘[THRESHOLD]’
  4. **Spirit Cove (Offering Rocks)** — A sheltered beach where offerings are left at low tide. *The offerings are rice, pickled plums, and small copper coins. The spirits take them at night.* ‘[SPIRIT]’
  5. **Bell-Line Tower** — A stone tower with a rope of bells stretching across the channel. *The rope is made of braided hair and seaweed. The bells are tuned to the tide’s frequency.* ‘[BELL]’
  6. **Counting School** — A wooden hut where children learn the eight-number system. *The teacher has only eight fingers. She was born that way. The children count on theirs.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
  7. **Tide-Watcher’s Post** — A high platform on stilts, overlooking the sea. *The watcher marks each wave with a pebble. Nine pebbles mean the tide is turning.* ‘[WEATHER]’
  8. **Shrine of the Uncounted** — A small shrine with no bells, no offerings, no threshold. *It is for the spirits that have no number. They are the most dangerous.* ‘[DEATH]’
  9. **Plum Orchard (Pickled)** — A grove of plum trees, the fruit fermented in salt brine. *The pickling barrels are sealed with copper lids. The lids have eight holes.* ‘[TRADE]’
  10. **Copper Foundry** — A forge where bells are cast and tuned. *The foundry is silent. The workers use hand signals. Sound would disturb the spirits.* ‘[CRAFT]’
- J **The Ninth Bell (Forgotten)** — A bell that was cast but never hung. It sits in a field, overgrown. *It rings once a year, on the night of the ninth tide. No one knows why.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
- Q **Hollow’s Gate (Submerged)** — A stone arch underwater, visible only at the lowest tide. *The arch is covered in counting marks. Eight marks, then a space. The space is the gate.* ‘[DEATH]’
- K **The Counting Stone** — A flat rock carved with eight grooves. Water flows through them. *The ninth groove is missing. The water falls into a hole. The hole is bottomless.* ‘[MAGIC]’
- A **The First Bell (Myth)** — A bell that rang once and shattered. Its shards are scattered across the Inland Sea. *Find all nine shards, and you can ring the bell that ended the first war with the Hollow.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(**Warden/Counter/Builder**) Bell-Warden Tumble with a copper bell; Tide-Counter Mira with eight fingers; Shrine-Builder Orin with a counting song.

## Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Bell-Warden** — Old, grey-haired, a copper bell on a leather thong. He never speaks above a whisper. *“The spirits hear everything,” he says. “A whisper is a negotiation. A shout is a declaration of war.”* ‘[SOCIAL]’
3. **Tide-Counter** — A young woman with eight fingers. She counts waves by tapping her knee. *“The ninth wave is the spirit’s breath,” she says. “Do not count it. It counts you.”* ‘[WEATHER]’
4. **Shrine-Builder** — A man with calloused hands and a wooden mallet. He never uses nails. *“Nails are for coffins,” he says. “Joinery is for shrines. The spirits respect wood grain.”* ‘[CRAFT]’
5. **Spirit-Negotiator** — A woman with a basket of pickled plums. She speaks to the air. *“I offer eight plums,” she says. “The ninth is for later. Do you accept?”* The air ripples. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[SPIRIT]’
6. **Copper-Smith (Silent)** — A dwarf-like figure who works in complete silence. He uses hand signs. *His hands are scarred from molten copper. He has not spoken in forty years.* ‘[CRAFT]’
7. **Tide-Spirit (Visible)** — A shimmer of light over the water, shaped like a woman. *It asks: “How many waves have you counted today?” Answer with eight, or it will flood.* ‘[SPIRIT]’ ‘[FEAR]’
8. **Counting Teacher** — An old woman with a slate and chalk. She teaches children to stop at eight. *“What comes after eight?” she asks. The children chorus: “Nothing. We stop.”* ‘[SOCIAL]’
9. **Hollow-Watcher** — A boy who sits at the edge of the bridge at dusk, watching the missing plank. *He can see the Hollow when it crosses. He whistles to warn the village.* ‘[DEATH]’
10. **Offering-Keeper** — A woman who tends the spirit cove. She sweeps the beach at dawn. *“The offerings are gone,” she says. “The spirits were satisfied. We have one more day.”* ‘[SPIRIT]’
- J **The Miscount’s Ghost** — A flickering shadow with a copper bell that never rings. *It follows travellers who count to nine. It whispers: “Nine. Nine. What comes after nine?”* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’
- Q **First Bell’s Shard (Keeper)** — A woman who holds one of the nine shards. She guards it with her life. *The shard is warm. It hums at low tide. It wants to be reunited.* ‘[MAGIC]’

K **The Still Bell (Legend)** — A bell that hangs in a submerged shrine. It rings only when the Hollow walks. *No one has heard it ring in a century. The Hollow has been quiet. Too quiet.* ‘[LEGEND]’

A **Kuva’s Echo (Sky Spirit)** — A voice from the bell-line tower, speaking in counting songs. *“You have counted eight,” it says. “That is enough. The ninth is mine.”* ‘[PATRON]’

**(Squall/Pirate/Whirlpool)** A sudden squall — all navigation rolls at disadvantage; a pirate attack — pay cargo or fight; a spirit-whirlpool — lose 1 Supply to escape.

## Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Sudden Squall** — A storm rises from calm waters. Navigation DV +2. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The squall was summoned by an offended tide-spirit. Someone miscounted.*
3. **Pirate Attack (Kalingan)** — Fast dhows appear from behind a reef. They demand cargo. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The pirates are not human. They are spirit-touched. They count in nines.*
4. **Spirit-Whirlpool** — A whirlpool opens beneath the boat. Lose 1 Supply to escape. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The whirlpool is a spirit’s mouth. It is hungry. Feed it a memory.*
5. **Bell-Line Breaks** — A rope of bells snaps. The tide-spirits are no longer bound. ‘[SPIRIT]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The tide rises. The village will flood in nine hours. Repair the line.*
6. **Miscount (Offended Spirit)** — A traveller counted to nine near a shrine. The spirit demands compensation. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The compensation is a story that ends with the number eight. The spirit will check.*
7. **Missing Offering** — The spirits took the offering, but they left a mark. The mark is a warning. ‘[OMEN]’ *The warning says: “The Hollow is coming. Ring the ninth bell.” But the ninth bell does not exist.*
8. **Copper Foundry Fire** — The silent forge catches fire. The bells crack. The tones are wrong. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The fire was set by a rival bell-warden. He wants to replace the old bells with his own.*
9. **Bridge Plank Replaced (By Mistake)** — Someone nails a ninth plank onto the bridge. The Hollow crosses. ‘[DEATH]’ *The Hollow asks: “Who built this bridge?” The builder is the party’s ally.*
10. **Counting School Poisoned** — The teacher’s chalk is laced with a memory-erasing dust. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The children forget to stop at eight. They count to nine. The Hollow comes for them.*

**J The Ninth Bell Rings (Once)** — The forgotten bell in the field rings. Everyone hears it. ‘[OMEN]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The Hollow’s gate opens. Spirits flood the Inland Sea. The Aelinnel are terrified.*

**Q Tide-Spirit Demands a Name** — A spirit rises from the water. It asks: “What is the ninth number?” ‘[RIDDLE]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *There is no ninth number. The correct answer is silence. The wrong answer is death.*

**K First Bell Shard Stolen** — Someone steals one of the nine shards. The Hollow stirs. ‘[THEFT]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The thief is a foreign merchant. He wants to sell the shard to the Veiled Sisters.*

**A Kuva’s Silence** — The counting song stops. The sky is empty. No birds, no wind, no waves. ‘[APOCALYPSE]’ *Kuva has turned away. The Hollow is free. The Aelinnel are counting their last breaths.*

**(Charter/Bead/Stone)** Bell-charter (right to ring a named shrine); tide-bead (safe passage on the Inland Sea for one crossing); counting stone (one reroll on a navigation test in fog).

## Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Bell-Charter (Copper Token)** — A small copper disc. Right to ring any named shrine bell once. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The token is stamped with eight dots. The ninth dot is missing.*

3. **Tide-Bead (Glass)** — A blue glass bead. Safe passage on the Inland Sea for one crossing. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The bead was blessed by a tide-spirit. It glows when a storm is coming.*

4. **Counting Stone (Smooth Pebble)** — A pebble with eight grooves. Reroll a failed navigation test in fog. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The stone was worn by waves for a century. It knows the tide’s schedule.*

5. **Offering Box Key (Copper)** — A small key. Opens any Aelinnel offering box. ‘[STEALTH]’ *The key is warm. It glows when an offering has been accepted.*

6. **Shrine-Builder’s Mallet** — A wooden mallet with no nails. Build a temporary shrine anywhere. ‘[CRAFT]’ *The shrine lasts one night. The spirits will respect it.*

7. **Spirit-Negotiator’s Plum (Pickled)** — A pickled plum in a brine jar. Offer it to any tide-spirit. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The spirit will grant one favour. The favour is never large. It is always fair.*

8. **Bell-Line Rope (Hair and Seaweed)** — A length of braided rope. Use it to bind a tide-spirit for one hour. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The rope smells of salt. The spirit will remember the binding.*

9. **Tide-Counter’s Pebble Pouch** — A leather pouch of marked pebbles. Predict the tide for the next day. ‘[WEATHER]’ *Count the pebbles. Eight mean high tide. Seven mean low. Nine mean run.*
10. **Copper Bell (Untuned)** — A small bell that has not been tuned. Ring it to confuse a spirit. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The spirit will hesitate for one exchange. The bell will crack after use.*
- J **Forgotten Bell’s Tone (Recording)** — A clay cylinder that captured the ninth bell’s ring. ‘[MAGIC]’ *Play it to open the Hollow’s gate. Use once. The Hollow will be angry.*
- Q **First Bell Shard (Green Glass)** — A shard of the mythic first bell. Touch it to any spirit to command obedience for one minute. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The shard is warm. It hums. The spirit will obey — but it will remember.*
- K **Kuva’s Counting Song (Flute)** — A bone flute that plays the eight-note counting song. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *Play it to calm any spirit. The spirit will listen. It will not attack.*
- A **The Hollow’s Silence (Bell)** — A copper bell that rings only for the Hollow. Ring it to banish a Oath-Keeper. ‘[DEATH]’ *The bell will ring once. Then it will shatter. The Hollow will not forget.*

## Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters, beads, stones) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **bell-omens**—a bell that rings without being struck, a missing plank that appears, a count that reaches nine and stops.

## Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Bell-Tending:** Once per scene, when near a shrine or threshold, you may ring a copper bell. The next environmental hazard (tide, fog, landslide) is delayed by 1 segment of the relevant clock. The bell’s tone also pacifies minor spirits (Cap 1) for the scene.
- **Fae Courtesy:** An Aelinnel never says “no” to a spirit. They say “that road is closed for repairs” or “the season is not right.” This phrasing cancels the first Story Beat generated by a spirit encounter. If forced to refuse outright, they mark 1 Fatigue (the spirit’s disappointment is heavy).

- **Kuva’s Count:** Once per journey, a character may roll Wits + Lore (DV 3) to recall a forgotten sky-omen; on success, the next travel leg ignores the first Club card drawn. On a miss, the omen is true, but the GM draws an additional Club for that leg.
- **The Ninth Step:** When you cross a threshold that has a missing ninth step (a stair, a bridge, a door), you may count the absence. Gain +1 die to resist the Hollow’s attention for the scene, but mark 1 Obligation (the Hollow now knows your name).
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
  - **The Unrung** — The Witness. \*A bell that never rings, yet remembers every promise.\*
  - **The Counter** — Mykkiel. \*The divine arithmetician; a miscount is a sin.\*
  - **The Ninth Wave** — Khemesh. \*The pressure beneath the tide; the hunger that waits after eight.\*
  - **Kuva’s Echo** — The Traveler. \*The sky-road and the counting song that guides lost ships.\*

### Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord sometimes serve as bell-wardens, using the Hollow’s attention to collect debts. A renegade Sister hides in a floating shrine, trying to untie her cord from a tide-spirit’s bargain.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends appears in offering boxes. Take it, and the spirits will accept any gift — but the coin will reappear in the mouth of a drowned sailor.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Aelinnel psions are called “Echo-Readers.” They hear the count of waves in their dreams and can predict a miscount three tides before it happens.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Ninth Bell is a Class III Procession — the sound of the bell walks the Inland Sea once a year, and those who hear it must answer a riddle or join the march.
- **The Ninth:** In any Aelinnel scene, the ninth bell rung in an hour opens a threshold. The wise stop at eight. Those who ring the ninth see a grey figure standing on the water — waiting.

### Regional Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Bell:** Crumble a crust at the base of a shrine bell. Ignore the first *Bell-Line Breaks* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Rope:** Tie a single knot in a bell-line rope. Cancel *Miscount* or take –1 die on your next spirit negotiation (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

- **Name to the Wave:** Whisper a dead tide-counter's name into the sea. Gain +1 Effect when counting waves this scene, but mark *Obligation* to Kuva. '[SUPERSTITION]'

## Thematic SB Spend Table

### Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **bell-wardens** or **tide-spirits**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **shrine builders** or **offering-keepers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **spirits** or **the Hollow**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favourable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

### Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Bell-Warden** or **tide-counter** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog** or **rising water**.
- **Foe Appears:** An **offended tide-spirit** or **Hollow agent** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

### Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **spirits**, **bell-wardens**, or **Hollow manifestations** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**bell-line breaks/miscount called/ninth bell rings**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

**Major Turns (4+ SB)**

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** Bell-Warden Tumble, Kuva’s Echo, or the Miscount’s Ghost intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**shrine floods/bell-line snaps/ninth plank appears**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

**Region-Specific SB Options**

- **Aelinnel (Bell Law):** Bells ring in harmony, then stop; a missing plank glows; the count of waves becomes audible.
- **Aelinnel (Spirit Law):** A tide-spirit laughs, an offering steams, a copper bell tarnishes instantly.
- **Aelinnel (Hollow Law):** The ninth step appears, then vanishes; a whisper says “count again”; a shadow crosses the bridge.

**Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)**

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Cut the Bell (Presence + Lore):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a bell-charter is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *Sudden Squall*, you pick who keeps their footing; on a miss, the GM does.

**Boss Seeds (Bell & Count)**

- **The Miscount-King (Nine Errors)** — *Phases:* Bell-Lines Severed → Orchestrated Miscount → Shrine Coup. *Cracks:* re-tie a bell-line, expose a false count, survive a night at the forgotten bell.
- **The Drowned Counter (Spirit of the Ninth Tide)** — *Phases:* Waves Miscalculated → Procession of Empty Shrines → Bell-Baptism of a Warden. *Cracks:* relic tide-bead, survivor testimony, the ninth bell refusing to ring.

### Patronage & Power

Among the Aelinnel, power flows through bells, counts, and the precision of a threshold. A Bell-Warden's authority rests on the number of shrines he tends; a Tide-Counter's on the accuracy of her predictions. There is no government, only the shared understanding that a miscount kills everyone.

**For the GM:** Power in Aelinnel society is measured in bells rung, offerings given, and miscounts avoided. Patronage often takes the form of bell-charters, tide-beads, or counting stones — each tied to a specific shrine, tide, or spirit. To emphasize the cultural mechanics:

- Use **Bell-Tending** as a hazard mitigation tool. Let players delay environmental clocks by ringing bells.
- Enforce **Fae Courtesy** — never say “no” to a spirit. Creative phrasing is rewarded.
- Let **Kuva's Count** be a journey-saving ability, but with a risk of additional complications.
- Track **The Ninth Step** as a source of Hollow Obligation. Each crossing of a threshold is a negotiation.

In Aelinnel society, the count forgets nothing — and the ninth bell is never rung.

# Chapter 7

## Lethai-al of Nihori

*The Storm-Touched Wanderers.*

Chen Wei says: *“The Lethai-al carry their dead in tide-charms. They walk the processional roads and never settle. I asked one why. He said, ‘Because we already drowned once. The land is the sea that forgot to swallow.’”*

The Lethai-al of Nihori once guarded a drowned kingdom – an archipelago that sank when a forbidden name was spoken. Their blood still carries the salt of that ancient catastrophe. Now they are wanderers in the oldest sense: masterless, landless, bound to no lord but fiercely bound to each other and to the storm spirits that swirl above the waves. They walk from shrine to shrine, from port to port, following the processional roads that circle the island. They do not farm. They do not build. They carry everything on their backs or in wooden carts. Their duels are to first blood – the loser carries the winner’s burden for a season. Their courts are crossroads. Their temples are the road itself. The ninth wave is never the largest; it is the one that remembers your name.

*“Never walk under a torii gate without making an offering. The gate is a threshold. The road on the other side is not the same road you left.”*

— Procession Elder Kenji

***What do people eat for breakfast?*** *Dried fish and rice balls – the fish smoked over driftwood fires, the rice pressed into shapes that fit in a pouch. The food is always cold. The road does not wait.*

***What does a child learn before they can walk?*** *To count the nine waves. Children watch the sea and count: one, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight – then stop. The ninth wave is the spirit’s wave. It counts you.*

***What is the first thing you notice about a stranger?*** *Their feet. Calloused soles cracked like dry earth have walked many circuits. Soft feet have not walked far. No feet means a ghost who lost the road.*

***What is the most common crime?*** *Charm-theft – stealing a tide-charm from a sleeping traveller. The thief gains the dead ancestor’s favour for one night. Then the ancestor wakes. The punishment is to carry the victim’s burden for the rest of the circuit.*

***What does no one talk about but everyone knows?*** *The drowned kingdom did not sink by accident. The forbidden name was spoken by a Lethai-al – a woman who lost her child to the sea. She wanted the sea to remember. It remembered too well.*

***Where do people go when they die?*** *Into the tide-charms. The dead are not buried. Their names are carved onto shells and placed in oiled leather pouches. The living carry them. When the pouch is lost, the dead become the Hollow.*

***How do you apologize for a serious wrong?*** *You walk a crossroads circuit – nine times around a crossroads shrine, counting your steps in eights. On the ninth circuit, you speak the wrong aloud. If the wind carries your voice away, you are forgiven.*

***What is the most important festival?*** *The Procession of the Ninth Wave (autumn). All Lethai-al bands walk to the shore at low tide. When the ninth wave crashes, they wade into the foam and whisper the names of those who drowned that year.*

***What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person?*** *The Ninth Wave Herald is not a child. She is the first drowned – the woman who spoke the forbidden name. She did not die. She became the ninth wave. She returns every year to point at the horizon – at the day the sea will rise again.*

## 7.1 Lethai-al — “The Storm-Touched Wanderers of Ni-hori”

### Quick Reference

**Tagline:** *We do not own the land. We walk it. The road is our shrine. The storm is our law.*

**Procession Elder (Elite):** “The sea does not forgive, but it does forget. If you can wait long enough, the waves will erase your debt. But we do not wait. We walk. From shrine to shrine, from storm to storm, we carry the names of the drowned. The road is a prayer. Every step is a syllable.”

**Tide-Charm Keeper (Commoner):** “My grandmother drowned in the ninth wave. Her name became a tide-charm. I keep it in a pouch of oiled leather. When the storm grows angry, I whisper her name. The sea remembers her. It calms for a moment — long enough to breathe. We are wanderers. The road is our home. The dead travel with us.”

**Genre / Mood:** Processional pilgrimage, wandering monks, duellists at crossroads, storm-folk.

**Starting Location:** A procession trail winding along the sea cliffs, marked by weathered torii gates and small stone shrines. A group of Lethai-al walk in single file, chanting a counting song. One carries a palanquin with a covered object — a tide-charm shrine. The leader stops: “You stand on the processional road. The drowned are watching from the waves. Do you walk with us? If so, you must carry nothing. The road provides. The road takes away.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Lethai-al of Nihori once guarded a drowned kingdom — an archipelago that sank when a forbidden name was spoken. Their blood still carries the salt of that ancient catastrophe. Now they are wanderers in the oldest sense: masterless, landless, bound to no lord but fiercely bound to each other and to the storm spirits that swirl above the waves. They walk from shrine to shrine, from port to port, following the processional roads that circle the island. They do not farm. They do not build. They carry everything they own on their backs or in wooden carts. Their duels are not to the death — they are to the first draw of blood, after which the loser must join the procession and carry the winner’s burden for a season. Their courts are crossroads. Their temples are the road itself. The Eastern Ninth lives here: the Hollow does not hide under hills — it breathes in the salt foam. The ninth wave is never the largest; it is the one that remembers your name.

**What you notice first:** The smell of salt and incense. The way the Lethai-al never sit with their backs to the sea. The constant, low murmur of waves being predicted — not by instruments, but by the tilt of a head, the twitch of a finger. The worn wooden plaques hung from their belts, each carved with a dead ancestor’s name.

**The one rule that kills newcomers:** Never walk under a torii gate without making an offering. The gate is a threshold. The road on the other side is not the same road you left.

Regional Mood: The Processional Road

Power here is measured in shrines visited, storms survived, and the number of dead ancestors carried as tide-charms. The Lethai-al have no king, no courts, no written law. Their authority is personal and processional: a Procession Elder’s word is law because she has walked the circuit more times than anyone else. Their guilds are not guilds — they are processional bands, each with its own rhythm, its own counting song, its own patron shrine. A band that walks too fast offends the spirits; one that walks too slow loses the tide. The Lethai-al do not believe in ownership of land; they believe in passage rights, storm oaths, and the memory of the drowned. Every crossroads is a court. Every storm is a messenger. Every sunrise is a departure.

**Starting Location (alternative):** A crossroads shrine at the edge of a fishing village. A procession of Lethai-al has stopped for the night. Their carts are arranged in a circle, painted with wave patterns. A Procession Elder sits by a small fire, offering cups of sake to travellers who pause. “The road is long. The dead are many. Stay one night. Tell us a story. If we like it, we will carry it to the next shrine. If we do not, you will walk alone tomorrow.”

Prominent NPCs of the Lethai-al

| p0.2 | p0.25      | p0.3       | p0.15          |
|------|------------|------------|----------------|
| Name | Role/Title | Motivation | Rumoured Quirk |

Procession Elder Kenji Leader of the Ninth Wave Band Complete the circuit before the monsoon He has walked the circuit 99 times. He plans to stop at 100.

Tide-Charm Keeper Yuki Guardian of drowned names Prevent the Hollow from taking her grandmother's charm She carries an oiled pouch with nine charms. The ninth is empty — for herself.

Wandering Ronin Masterless duelist Find a worthy opponent before the next full moon He has never lost a duel. He has also never drawn first blood.

Shrine Maiden Hana Keeper of the processional bells Ring the storm-spirits to sleep She rings a bell that can only be heard underwater.

The Drowned Captain (Ghost) A Lethai-al who died before completing the circuit Ask the living to carry his charm to the final shrine He appears on foggy nights, holding a tide-charm that hums.

## Names of the Lethai-al

Inspired by Japanese and coastal Ainu traditions: short, with vowel endings, honorifics (-san, -sama, -dono). Surnames denote a band, a wave, or a drowned ancestor.

| p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2 |                      |                |                                |
|-----------------------|----------------------|----------------|--------------------------------|
| First Names (Male)    | First Names (Female) | Band/Clan      | Tide-Name                      |
| Kenji                 | Yuki                 | Ninth Wave     | <i>of the Drowned Shore</i>    |
| Ronan                 | Hana                 | Foam-kin       | <i>of the Salt Breath</i>      |
| Kael                  | Mira                 | Storm-walker   | <i>of the Empty Pouch</i>      |
| Takeshi               | Sora                 | Shore-bearer   | <i>of the Ancestor's Shell</i> |
| Jiro                  | Nami                 | Circuit-keeper | <i>of the Unfinished Road</i>  |

(**Crossroads/Grove/Shrine**) A crossroads shrine with a missing stone; a bamboo grove where duels are fought at dawn; a processional torii gate at the edge of a cliff.

## Spades — Places

2. **Crossroads Shrine (Stone)** — A small stone shrine at the meeting of three roads. *Older travellers leave a pinch of salt on the altar. The spirits take it. The salt never depletes.* ‘[THRESHOLD]’
3. **Bamboo Grove (Duel Ground)** — A clearing where the stalks are scarred by blade cuts. *The bamboo bleeds sap when a duel is dishonourable. The sap is red.* ‘[DUEL]’

4. **Torii Gate (Processional)** — A wooden gate standing alone on a cliff path. *Walk through it, and the wind changes direction. The gate was built by a drowned mason.* ‘[THRESHOLD]’
5. **Cart Circle (Night Camp)** — A ring of painted wooden carts, their wheels touching. *Inside the circle, the Hollow cannot enter. Outside, the road waits.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
6. **Tide-Charm Vault (Sea Cave)** — A cave where processional bands store charms during the winter. *The charms hum when the sea is angry. The cave is watched by a blind keeper.* ‘[MEMORY]’
7. **Storm Shrine (Peak)** — A stone circle with bells that ring in the wind. *Each bell has a different tone. The tones predict the weather. The shrine maiden reads them.* ‘[WEATHER]’
8. **Foam-Ford (Crossing)** — A shallow channel that can only be crossed at low tide. *The crossing lasts nine breaths. Count carefully. The ninth breath belongs to the sea.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
9. **Volcano Shrine (Dormant)** — A crater where the name that sank the kingdom was spoken. *The crater is warm. Speaking any name aloud here causes the ground to tremble.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
10. **Sake House of the Ninth Cup** — A tavern at a crossroads, where duels are negotiated. *The ninth cup is never poured. It is for the dead. The dead sometimes drink it.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- J **Ancestor’s Salt Pan** — A flat where seawater is evaporated to make salt. *The salt is mixed with ash from funeral pyres. It tastes of grief. The widows sell it to remember.* ‘[LABOR]’
- Q **The Sunken Gate** — An underwater archway that leads to the drowned kingdom. *It can only be reached by holding your breath for nine heartbeats. The gate is guarded by a spirit.* ‘[DEATH]’
- K **Procession Elder’s Lookout** — A wooden tower on the highest cliff. *From here, the Elder can see three storms coming. He has never been wrong.* ‘[WEATHER]’
- A **The Drowned Capital (Myth)** — A sunken city said to rise once every century. *Those who enter can speak to the dead. The price is a breath. The dead are talkative.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(Elder/Keeper/Ronin) Procession Elder Kenji with a tally stick; Tide-Charm Keeper Yuki with an oiled pouch; Wandering Ronin with a sake cup.

## Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Procession Elder** — Grey-haired, sunburned, a tally stick in his belt. *“The circuit is 108 shrines. I have walked it 99 times. The 100th will be my last.”* ‘[AUTHORITY]‘
3. **Tide-Charm Keeper** — A young woman with a leather pouch at her hip. She never swims. *“My grandmother is in this pouch. She cannot get wet. When the storm comes, I whisper her name.”* ‘[MEMORY]‘
4. **Wandering Ronin** — A man with no master, a scarred blade, and a cup of sake. *He offers a cup to every opponent. “Drink. The duel will be fair. The loser carries the winner’s burden for a season.”* ‘[DUEL]‘
5. **Shrine Maiden** — A woman with a copper bell on a rope. She rings it at dawn. *The bell’s tone tells the procession whether to walk or wait. It has never been wrong.* ‘[RITUAL]‘
6. **Cart Builder** — A silent craftsman who builds the painted carts. He uses no nails. *“Nails are for coffins. The road does not forgive splinters.” The joints are held by counting songs.* ‘[CRAFT]‘
7. **Wave-Walker** — A woman who can walk on water during a storm. She does not know how. *“The storm carries me. I just don’t fight it. The road is wet, but the road is still the road.”* ‘[MYSTIC]‘
8. **Sake Brewer** — A fat man with a wooden ladle. He brews sake from rice and seawater. *“The salt makes it strong. The sea makes it honest. The dead like it. It helps them remember.”* ‘[TRADE]‘
9. **Drowned Scholar (Ghost)** — A translucent figure who haunts the Sunken Gate. *He asks: “Has anyone spoken the name?” He will not say which name. He has been asking for a century.* ‘[DEATH]‘
10. **Storm-Spirit (Kami)** — A whirlwind with eyes. It speaks in the roar of the wind. *It demands a gift before it will leave. The gift must be a promise. The promise must be kept.* ‘[SPIRIT]‘
- J **Tide-Hunter** — A woman who hunts sea monsters. She has a harpoon made from a ship’s keel. *She has never killed a monster. She has ridden nine of them. They recognise her whistle.* ‘[COMBAT]‘
- Q **Volcano Priest** — A man who tends the dormant crater. He speaks only in whispers. *“The name that sank the kingdom is still here. Do not ask what it is. The crater knows. It is waiting.”* ‘[MYSTIC]‘
- K **The Ninth Wave’s Herald** — A child who appears before every storm. She points at the horizon. *She never speaks. She only points. The direction tells where the storm will hit. She has never been wrong.* ‘[OMEN]‘

- A **The First Drowned (Legend)** — The first Lethai-al who died in the sinking. She sits at the bottom of the sea. *If you bring her a memory, she will teach you to breathe water. The memory must be your own.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(**Duel/Pirate/Ashfall**) A duel challenge is issued — refusal loses face; a pirate flotilla claims the strait — pay toll or fight; ashfall from the volcano — all actions Desperate.

## Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Duel Challenge (Issued)** — A Lethai-al challenges a party member to a duel. Refusal loses face. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The duel is to first blood. The loser owes a story or carries the winner’s burden for a season.*
  3. **Pirate Flotilla** — Kalingan pirates block the strait. They demand a toll of one tide-charm. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The charm must be from a drowned ancestor. Refuse, and they attack. The pirates count in nines.*
  4. **Ashfall (Volcano)** — The dormant crater emits ash. Visibility drops. All actions are Desperate. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The ash is warm. It smells of old names. Speaking a name makes the ash thicken.*
  5. **Storm-Spirit Offended** — A traveller insulted the wind. The storm-spirit demands compensation. ‘[DEBT]’ *The compensation is a promise about the sea. Break it, and the spirit drowns you.*
  6. **Tide-Charm Stolen** — Someone steals a pouch of charms. The ancestors are angry. ‘[THEFT]’ *The thief is a foreign merchant. The charms are in a cargo hold. The ship sails at dawn.*
  7. **Drowned Capital Rising** — The sunken city emerges at low tide. Spirits walk the streets. ‘[DEATH]’ *They ask for news of the surface. Lies will anger them. Truths will sadden them. Both are dangerous.*
  8. **Volcano Name Whispered** — Someone speaks the forbidden name near the crater. The ground shakes. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The speaker is a child. The child did not know. The volcano remembers. It will not forget.*
  9. **Ninth Wave Warning** — The full moon is tomorrow. The ninth wave will be larger than any in a century. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The fishing fleet cannot be recalled in time. Someone must warn them. The wave is already forming.*
  10. **Sake House Brawl** — A dispute over a duel’s fairness turns violent. The ninth cup is poured. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The ninth cup is for the dead. Someone has just died. The brawl is now a blood feud.*
- J **Sunken Gate Opens** — The underwater archway becomes passable. Something swims out. ‘[DEATH]’ *It is a drowned spirit. It wants its name back. It will trade a secret for it. The secret is always bad.*

- Q Procession Elder's Silence** — The Elder stops reading the weather. The band does not know where to walk. '[CRISIS]' *He is grieving. His son was lost at sea. He will not speak until the body is found.*
- K Duel to the Death (Betrayal)** — A duel that was meant to be to first blood becomes a killing. '[COMBAT]' *The killer is a spy from Ashaan. The duel was an assassination. The party is blamed.*
- A The Ninth Wave Takes** — The massive wave crashes over the cliff shrine. The bells are silent. '[APOCALYPSE]' *The shrine maiden is gone. The storm-spirit is free. The Hollow walks the shore.*

**(Charm/Arrow/Cup)** Storm-charm (one weather bypass); broken arrow (proof of oath); sake cup (right to demand a fair duel).

## Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Storm-Charm** — A bone carved with wave patterns. Use it to ignore one weather penalty on a journey leg. '[WEATHER]' *The bone is from a sailor who died in a storm. His spirit protects you. He asks for a story in return.*
3. **Broken Arrow (Oath-Proof)** — A snapped arrow shaft. Present it to prove an oath was fulfilled. '[SOCIAL]' *The arrow was broken by a duelist who lost fairly. It carries his honour. It is warm to the touch.*
4. **Sake Cup (Duel Right)** — A ceramic cup used in a fair duel. Present it to demand a duel to first blood. '[SOCIAL]' *The cup is chipped. The chip is from a blade that drew first blood. The loser owes a burden.*
5. **Tide-Charm (Leather Pouch)** — A small pouch containing a drowned ancestor's name on a shell. '[MEMORY]' *Whisper the name to calm a storm for one hour. The ancestor will remember the favour.*
6. **Procession Pass (Wooden Plaque)** — A carved name-tag. Grants safe passage with any Lethai-al band. '[TRAVEL]' *The name is a dead ancestor. The band will recognise it. They will feed you.*
7. **Shrine Maiden's Bell (Copper)** — A copper bell. Ring it to pacify a storm-spirit for one scene. '[RITUAL]' *The bell's tone is unique. The spirit will recognise it. It may ask for a second favour.*
8. **Volcano Priest's Whisper** — A single word: the name that is forbidden. Speak it to cause a tremor. '[MAGIC]' *The word burns the tongue. Use it once. The volcano will remember. The ground will crack.*
9. **Wave-Walker's Sandal** — A single sandal woven from sea grass. Wear it to walk on calm water for one minute. '[TRAVEL]' *The sandal will not get wet. Your foot will. The water is cold.*

10. **Drowned Captain's Oar** — A skeletal oar that weighs nothing. Use it to row any boat against the current. '[TRAVEL]' *The captain's ghost will row with you. He will ask for a story. He knows if it is true.*
- J **Ninth Wave's Shell** — A white shell found on the Ninth Wave's Rock. It contains a memory. '[MEMORY]' *Break it to experience the memory. The memory is always a death. The death is always a drowning.*
- Q **Procession Elder's Flute** — A bone flute. Play it to predict the weather for the next 24 hours. '[WEATHER]' *The tune is sad. It always predicts a storm. It is always right. The storm will find you.*
- K **Sunken Gate Key (Coral)** — A piece of coral shaped like a key. Opens the Sunken Gate. '[DEATH]' *The key is alive. It grows. It will only fit the gate once. The gate will remember your face.*
- A **First Drowned's Breath (Glass Vial)** — A vial of seawater from the bottom of the sunken capital. '[LEGEND]' *Drink it to breathe water for one hour. The taste is salt and sorrow. Your lungs will ache.*

## Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charms, arrows, cups) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **processional omens**—a gate that creaks without wind, a cart wheel that turns backward, a name that echoes from the sea.

## Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Processional Circuit:** The Lethai-al walk a circuit of 108 shrines. A character who walks the circuit (over several sessions) may, at the end, gain +1 die to all rolls involving storms, spirits, or the sea. The circuit takes nine months. A character who completes the circuit nine times becomes a Procession Elder.
- **Walking Court (Crossroads Justice):** When two Lethai-al dispute, they settle it at a crossroads. Each party speaks their truth once. Then they walk away in opposite directions. The road decides. A character who lies at a crossroads gains the condition *Wave-Walker's Shame* (-1 die to all social rolls until they walk the circuit again).
- **Storm-Reading:** Once per journey, a character with Lethai-al training may predict the weather for the next 24 hours (Wits + Survival vs. DV 3). On success, choose one leg to ignore weather penalties. On a miss, the storm finds you anyway, and the GM gains 1 Story Beat to spend on a thunderclap or flash flood.

- **Tidal Resilience:** Once per scene, when a character would take Harm from a water-based or storm-based effect, they may reduce it by 1 level (to a minimum of 0). Mark 1 Fatigue.
- **The Eastern Ninth (Hollow in Salt Foam):** When a Lethai-al drowns, their name becomes a tide-charm. Living kin may whisper it to calm a storm, but the Hollow will collect the debt at the next full moon. The Hollow's attention ticks whenever a tide-charm is used.

### Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Tide-Charms and the Tulkani (Way of Silk):** Tulkani story-tellers sometimes carry Lethai-al tide-charms as proof of a witnessed drowning. A charm can be traded for a story that the Tulkani have not heard. The story must be about the sea.
- **Storm-Spirits and the Veiled Sisters (Ashaan):** The Veiled Sisters have tried to bind storm-spirits for use in their fleet. The Lethai-al have foiled nine attempts. A Procession Elder may ask the party to sabotage a Sister's ritual.
- **The Drowned Capital and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The sunken city is said to contain a temple that holds a fragment of the demon Varash. The amulet's creator visited the capital before it sank. The fragment whispers the forbidden name.
- **The Ninth Wave and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The Hollow's Oath-Keepers ride the ninth wave. Lethai-al who survive the ninth wave are said to owe the Hollow nothing. Aelaerem leave offerings of salt at the high tide line to appease the wave.

### Lethai-al Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Foam:** Crumble a crust at the water's edge. Ignore the first *Pirate Flotilla* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Rope:** Tie a single knot in a shrine climbing rope. Cancel *Storm-Spirit Offended* or take -1 die on your next sailing roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Wave:** Whisper a drowned ancestor's name into the ninth wave. Gain +1 Effect when navigating a storm this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Hollow. '[SUPERSTITION]'

### Thematic SB Spend Table

#### Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **storm-spirits or pirate scouts**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **shrine maidens or duelists**.

- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **tide-hunters or the Hollow**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

### Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised: Local Procession Elder or shrine maiden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **ashfall or rising tide**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **pirate crew or a storm-spirit** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

### Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **pirates, storm-spirits, or volcanic ash clouds** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**duel becomes death/storm shifts/sunken gate opens**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

### Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Procession Elder Kenji, Drowned Captain, or Ninth Wave Herald** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**volcano erupts/storm breaks/sunken capital rises**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

### Region-Specific SB Options

- **Lethai-al (Processional Law):** A torii gate creaks, a cart wheel turns backward, a name echoes from the sea.
- **Lethai-al (Duel Law):** Blades glow faintly, spilled sake steams, the first drop of blood evaporates.
- **Lethai-al (Drowned Law):** A name appears in wet sand, a wave carries a message, a drowned face looks up from still water.

### Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Sail):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Storm Cover*.
- **Cut the Duel (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a sake cup is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Storm (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *Storm-Spirit Offended*, you pick who is struck by lightning; on a miss, the GM does.

### Boss Seeds (Wave & Procession)

- **The Name-Eater (Nine Drownings)** — *Phases:* Tide-Charms Stolen → Orchestrated Storm → Drowned Coup. *Cracks:* recover a stolen charm, expose a false ancestor, survive the ninth wave.
- **The Unforgotten Storm (Spirit of the Ninth Wave)** — *Phases:* Waves Rising → Procession of Empty Shrines → Foam-Baptism of a Storm-Reader. *Cracks:* relic storm-charm, survivor testimony, the ninth wave breaking on a calm sea.

### Patronage & Power

Among the Lethai-al, power flows through the procession, the road, and the memory of the drowned. A Procession Elder's word is law because he has walked the circuit more than anyone else. A Tide-Charm Keeper holds the names of the dead; she can calm a storm or call one. There are no kings, no courts, no written laws — only the road, and the road does not negotiate.

**For the GM:** Power in Lethai-al society is measured in shrines visited, storms survived, and tide-charms kept. Patronage often takes the form of storm-charms, broken arrows, or processional passes — each tied to a specific ancestor, duel, or shrine. To emphasize the cultural mechanics:

- Use **Processional Circuit** as a long-term character goal. Completing it is a major achievement.
- Enforce **Walking Court** — a character who lies at a crossroads suffers social penalties until they make amends.
- Let **Storm-Reading** be a journey-saving ability, but with a risk of additional complications.
- Track the **Hollow's Attention** when tide-charms are used. The Oath-Keepers may appear at the worst moment.

In Lethai-al society, the sea forgets nothing — and the ninth wave remembers every name.

# Chapter 8

## Lethai-ar of Ayokha

*The River-Bound Oath-Keepers.*

Chen Wei observes: *“The Lethai-ar do not carry swords. They carry witness cords. A knot tightens when the oath is broken. I have seen a merchant’s wrist bleed because he lied about a shipment of silk. The cord does not forgive.”*

The Lethai-ar of Ayokha are the living bridges between mortals and the river spirits that launder the world’s promises. Their ancestors were river-folk that ascended to the realm of the fair folk, and they now walk the middle path, a step between water and the world of men. They keep lanterns that never go out, record every contract spoken on the monsoon wharves, and bind their vows with silken cords dyed in river mud. Unlike their northern kin who swore to distant deities, the Lethai-ar serve Benzaiten (the river of words) or Inari (the fox’s ledger). Their vows are physical cords, braided from their own hair and dyed with river mud. When a vow is fulfilled, the cord is burned. When it is broken, the cord tightens around the oath-breaker’s wrist until blood is drawn. The ninth cup of tea or sake is never poured – it is for the river spirits, and pouring it is an invitation to the Hollow.

*“Never pour the ninth cup of tea or sake in a Lethai-ar’s presence. The ninth cup is for the witness. Pour it, and you have invited the river to judge you. The river is not merciful.”*

— Vigil Lady Suyin

***What do people eat for breakfast?*** Rice porridge with river fish – the fish caught in sacred currents, the bones returned to the water as an offering. The porridge is salted with evaporated river brine. It tastes of memory.

***What does a child learn before they can walk?*** To tie the eight witness knots. Each knot is a clause of a fair contract. The ninth knot is never tied – it is left for the river to judge.

***What is the first thing you notice about a stranger?*** Their lamp. A Lethai-ar’s lamp is a public record of their witness. A green flame means kept every oath. A flickering lamp means witnessed a broken vow. A dark lamp means cut from the Vigil.

***What is the most common crime?*** Cord-forging – creating a false witness cord that mimics the dye of a respected Vigil. The forger’s hands are bound with a cord that tightens each time they speak. If they never lie, it loosens. If they lie once, it cuts.

***What does no one talk about but everyone knows?*** *The First Cord was not woven by a Lethai-ar. It was found already knotted, already witnessing – floating down the river on a broken barge. No one knows what oath it witnessed.*

***Where do people go when they die?*** *To the green flame. Cremated, ashes mixed with lamp oil. The oil is poured into the Vigil lanterns. The dead become the light. The light witnesses.*

***How do you apologize for a serious wrong?*** *You offer a new cord – woven from your own hair, dyed with your own blood. Tied between you and the wronged party. If the cord tightens, you are not forgiven. If it loosens, you are.*

***What is the most important festival?*** *The Reckoning of the Cords (spring). All cut or broken witness cords are burned in a barge on the river. If a cord does not burn, the oath is still unpaid. The Hollow comes.*

***What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person?*** *The God-King's own witness cord is a forgery. He swore a vow to protect the Lethai-ar nine years ago. His cord was cut the next day. The Vigil knows. They have not told anyone because the cord that cut his was their own.*

## 8.1 Lethai-ar — “The River-Bound Oath-Keepers of Ayokha”

### Quick Reference

**Tagline:** *The cord remembers. The river witnesses. The flame judges.*

**Vigil of the Silent Lamp (Elite):** “A witness cord is not a leash. It is a mirror. If you speak truly, you see yourself. If you lie, you see what you could have been. I have cut two cords in my life. I still dream of the faces in the silk. The river remembers every word spoken on its banks. We are merely the scribes.”

**Wharf-Witness (Commoner):** “My lamp has burned for nine years without being refilled. The flame is green. It flickers when a merchant lies about the weight of his silk. The river does not need oil. It needs witnesses. I sit on this wharf and watch. That is my offering.”

**Genre / Mood:** Riverine legal drama, oath-magic, communal memory, spirit diplomacy.

**Starting Location:** A monsoon wharf on the great river, where silk barges are being loaded. A Vigil in grey robes holds a lantern of green flame: “The merchant and the captain have made a vow. The captain says the silk is eight bales. The merchant says it is nine. The witness cord is tied. It will tighten around the liar’s wrist. I do not need to know who is lying. The cord will tell me. But you — you are not bound. Watch. Learn. And do not pour the ninth cup.”

#### Theme & Atmosphere

The Lethai-ar of Ayokha are the living bridges between mortals and the river spirits that launder the world’s promises. Their ancestors were river-folk that ascended to the realm of the fair folk, and they now walk the middle path, a step between bodies of water and the world of men. They keep lanterns that never go out, record every contract spoken on the monsoon wharves, and bind their vows with silken cords dyed in river mud. Unlike their northern kin who swore to distant deities, the Lethai-ar serve **Benzaiten** (the river of words) or **Inari** (the fox’s ledger). Their vows are physical cords, braided from their own hair and dyed with river mud. When a vow is fulfilled, the cord is burned. When it is broken, the cord tightens around the oath-breaker’s wrist until blood is drawn. The Ayokhan taboo against the ninth cup is enforced by the Lethai-ar: the ninth cup is for the river spirits, and pouring it is an invitation to the Hollow.

**What you notice first:** The smell of river water and oiled silk. The way every Lethai-ar carries a small oil lamp, even at noon. The constant murmur of contracts being witnessed — a merchant’s promise, a captain’s oath, a lover’s vow.

**The one rule that kills newcomers:** Never pour the ninth cup of tea or sake in a Lethai-ar’s presence. The ninth cup is for the witness. Pour it, and you have invited the river to judge you. The river is not merciful.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Witness Cord

Power here is measured in lanterns kept lit, cords tied, and the number of oaths witnessed. The Lethai-ar have no army, no treasury, no territory. They have the river, and the river remembers everything. Every contract in Ayokha requires a Lethai-ar witness to be legally binding. The God-King’s astrologers may set the calendar, but the Lethai-ar hold the ledger. Their neutrality is absolute: they will witness a vow between enemies as readily as between allies. The price of a witness cord is not silver — it is a promise to keep the river clean, to light a lamp at dusk, to speak no word that cannot be unsaid.

Prominent NPCs of the Lethai-ar (Ayokha)

| <div>p0.2p0.25p0.3p0.15</div> Name | Role/Title                       | Motivation                                | Rumoured Quirk                                             |
|------------------------------------|----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Vigil Lady Suyin                   | Master of the central wharf      | Keep the river’s ledger free of forgeries | She has cut nine witness cords. The ninth was her own.     |
| Cord-Maker Tama                    | Weaver of witness silk           | Create a cord that cannot lie             | She dyes her silk in river mud that glows under moonlight. |
| Lamp-Keeper Hiro                   | Guardian of the undying flame    | Ensure the green lamp never goes out      | He has not slept in nine years. The lamp keeps him awake.  |
| River-Spirit (Nat)                 | Benzaiten’s messenger            | Collect stories from broken oaths         | It appears as a woman with wet hair and riverweed.         |
| The Oath-Broken (Exile)            | A Lethai-ar who cut a false cord | Earn back her place in the Vigil          | She carries a cord with nine knots. The ninth is cut.      |

Names of the Lethai-ar (Ayokha)

Inspired by the river kingdoms and monsoon coasts: soft, flowing consonants, honorifics (Lady, Master). Surnames denote a river, a wharf, or a cord.

| <div>p0.25p0.25p0.2p0.2</div> First Names (Male) | First Names (Female) | Clan/Epithet           | Cord-Name |
|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------|------------------------|-----------|
| Hiro Suyin                                       | River-watch          | <i>the Uncut</i>       |           |
| Tama Mira                                        | Silk-hand            | <i>Ninth Knot</i>      |           |
| Kaito Yuki                                       | Lamp-bearer          | <i>Green Flame</i>     |           |
| Riku Hana                                        | Oath-strand          | <i>the Witness</i>     |           |
| Sora Nami                                        | Mud-dyer             | <i>the Unforgotten</i> |           |

(**Wharf/Temple/Cord-House**) A monsoon wharf with silk barges and green lanterns; a step-pyramid temple where the river spirit is honoured; a cord-maker's house with hanging strands of dyed silk.

## Spades — Places

2. **Monsoon Wharf (Central)** — A stone pier where silk is loaded and oaths are witnessed. *The pier is carved with the names of every oath kept. The names glow when a vow is fulfilled.* '[TRADE]' '[SOCIAL]'
3. **Step-Pyramid Temple (Benzaiten)** — A stone pyramid rising from the riverbank. The top is a pool. *The pool reflects not your face but the faces of those you have wronged.* '[SPIRIT]' '[TRUTH]'
4. **Cord-Maker's House** — A wooden building with silk strands hanging from the rafters. *The strands are dyed in nine shades of brown. The ninth shade is made from grave mud.* '[CRAFT]' '[MAGIC]'
5. **Lamp-Keeper's Shrine** — A small stone hut with a single green flame. *The flame has not gone out in three centuries. The keeper sleeps on a bed of ashes.* '[RITUAL]' '[COMMUNITY]'
6. **River Court (Floating)** — A barge that serves as a mobile courthouse. *The barge is anchored at a different spot each day. The river is the judge.* '[JUSTICE]' '[SOCIAL]'
7. **Vigil's Archive** — A cave behind a waterfall, filled with witness cords. *Each cord is labelled with a date and an oath. The oldest cord is nine centuries old.* '[MEMORY]' '[LEGEND]'
8. **Silk Village (Mulberry Groves)** — A village where silk is spun and cords are woven. *The mulberry trees were planted by the first Vigil. Their leaves are sacred.* '[COMMUNITY]' '[TRADE]'
9. **Bridge of the Ninth Clause** — A wooden bridge where contracts are signed. *The ninth clause is always the same: "This oath is witnessed by the river."* '[THRESHOLD]' '[LAW]'
10. **Well of Broken Oaths** — A dry well where cut cords are thrown. *The well is bottomless. The cords burn as they fall. The smoke smells of betrayal.* '[DEATH]' '[MEMORY]'
- J **The Oath-Broken's Hut** — A small shelter on the river's far bank, away from the wharves. *The exile lives here. She tends a single lamp. The flame is blue, not green.* '[SOCIAL]' '[MYSTERY]'
- Q **River-Spirit's Pool** — A still pool behind the temple where Benzaiten's messenger appears. *The pool is warm. It whispers. The whispers are the stories of broken oaths.* '[SPIRIT]' '[TRUTH]'

**K The God-King's Witness Chamber** — A hall where the king's own oaths are recorded. *The walls are covered in witness cords. The king has broken nine. The cords are still tight.* '[AUTHORITY]' '[JUSTICE]'

**A The First Cord (Myth)** — A silk strand said to be woven from the river's first current. *Whoever holds it can witness any oath anywhere. The price is a year of silence.* '[LEGEND]' '[TRUTH]'

**(Vigil/Cord-Maker/Spirit)** Vigil Lady Suyin with a green lamp; Cord-Maker Tama with silk-dyed fingers; the River-Spirit with wet hair and riverweed.

## Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Vigil (Lady Suyin)** — Grey-robed, a green lamp at her hip. She never blinks when witnessing an oath. *"The cord will tighten," she says. "I do not need to watch. The river watches for me."* '[JUSTICE]' '[SOCIAL]'
3. **Cord-Maker (Tama)** — A woman with hands stained brown from river mud. She weaves silk and hair. *"Each cord is a promise," she says. "The colour tells the weight. White for truth. Red for blood. Black for death."* '[CRAFT]' '[TRUTH]'
4. **Lamp-Keeper (Hiro)** — An old man with ash on his face. He tends the green flame. *"If the flame goes out," he says, "the river will forget every oath. I cannot sleep."* '[RITUAL]' '[COMMUNITY]'
5. **River-Spirit (Benzaiten's Messenger)** — A woman in wet robes, her hair dripping riverweed. *She speaks only in the voices of those who have broken oaths. "Pay your debt," she whispers.* '[SPIRIT]' '[TRUTH]'
6. **Merchant of the Ninth Bale** — A silk trader who always weighs his bales short by one. *He has never been caught. His witness cord is tied by a Vigil he has bribed.* '[TRADE]' '[SOCIAL]'
7. **Captain of the Monsoon Ship** — A woman with a brass earring and a scarred hand. *She has never broken an oath. Her witness cord has nine knots. All are tight.* '[TRAVEL]' '[HONOR]'
8. **Oath-Broken Exile** — A woman with a cut cord on her wrist. She sits apart from the wharf. *"I cut a false cord," she says. "I thought the merchant was honest. He was not. Now I wait."* '[COMMUNITY]' '[REDEMPTION]'
9. **God-King's Astrologer** — A man who reads the monsoon and advises on oath timing. *"Never swear an oath during an eclipse," he says. "The river cannot see you."* '[POLITICS]' '[WEATHER]'
10. **Lamp-Child (Apprentice)** — A young girl learning to tend the green flame. *She has never spoken. The lamp is her voice. The flame flickers when she is happy.* '[RITUAL]' '[INNOCENCE]'

- J **The Cut Cord's Ghost** — A translucent strand that floats through the archive at night. *It follows the oath-breaker. It whispers the words of the broken promise.* '[DEATH]' '[FEAR]'
- Q **River-Spirit's Rival (Inari's Fox)** — A fox with nine tails, seen at the cord-maker's house. *It offers a deal: a cord that cannot break, in exchange for a memory. The memory must be sweet.* '[MAGIC]' '[TRICKERY]'
- K **The First Vigil (Legend)** — A skeleton in grey robes, sitting at the bottom of the Well of Broken Oaths. *She holds a cord with nine knots. The ninth knot is loose. Untie it, and she will speak.* '[LEGEND]' '[DEATH]'
- A **Benzaiten (The River of Words)** — A voice heard from the step-pyramid's pool. *"Every word is a current," it says. "Speak gently, or you will drown."* '[PATRON]' '[TRUTH]'

(**Flood/Rumor/Curse**) The river floods — a bridge is swept away; a rival merchant spreads rumours of cursed silk; the nat of the well is offended — no one may draw water until appeased.

## Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **River Floods (Bridge Swept)** — The monsoon rises. The bridge is gone. The wharf is isolated. '[WEATHER]' '[TRAVEL]' *The flood is not natural. A river-spirit is angry. An oath was broken upstream.*
3. **Rumour of Cursed Silk** — A merchant claims that a bale of silk is cursed. Trade stops. '[SOCIAL]' '[TRADE]' *The curse is a lie. The merchant wants to drive down prices. He will buy cheap.*
4. **Well-Spirit Offended** — A traveller threw trash into the sacred well. The spirit refuses water. '[SPIRIT]' '[DEBT]' *The spirit demands an apology. The apology must be an oath. The oath must be witnessed.*
5. **Witness Cord Cut (False)** — Someone cuts a witness cord that was tied in good faith. '[JUSTICE]' '[SOCIAL]' *The cutter is the Vigil's own apprentice. She thought the oath was false. It was true.*
6. **Green Lamp Gutters** — The eternal flame flickers. The Lamp-Keeper is dying. '[RITUAL]' '[COMMUNITY]' *He has one day to train a successor. The successor is the party's least likely candidate.*
7. **Cord-Maker's Silk Poisoned** — Someone dyes the silk with a solvent that weakens it. '[CRAFT]' '[TRAP]' *The cords will break under pressure. The poisoner is a rival cord-maker.*

8. **River-Spirit Demands a Story** — Benzaiten’s messenger appears. She asks for a broken oath. ‘[SPIRIT]’ ‘[TRUTH]’ *She will not leave until someone confesses. The confession must be true.*
9. **God-King’s False Oath** — The king swears a vow he does not intend to keep. The Vigil knows. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[JUSTICE]’ *If she exposes him, the king will exile the Lethai-ar. If she stays silent, the cord tightens on her wrist.*
10. **Oath-Broken’s Redemption Attempt** — The exile tries to rejoin the Vigil. She offers a true cord. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The cord is her own hair. Cutting it would kill her. The Vigil must decide.*
- J **The Ninth Cup Poured (By Mistake)** — A stranger pours the ninth cup at a tea house. The Hollow comes. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The Hollow asks: “Who poured this cup?” The stranger points at the party.*
- Q **First Cord Found (Forgery)** — Someone claims to have found the mythic First Cord. It is a fake. ‘[LEGEND]’ ‘[TRAP]’ *The forger is the God-King’s astrologer. He wants to control all oaths.*
- K **River Changes Course** — The river shifts overnight. The wharf is now on dry land. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DISASTER]’ *The river was offended by a broken oath. It will return when the oath is fulfilled.*
- A **Benzaiten Speaks (Judgment)** — The river itself speaks from the step-pyramid pool. ‘[PATRON]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *“Nine oaths have been broken this season. The ninth was yours. Pay or drown.”*

**(Lamp/Cord/Mirror)** Vigil lantern (social edge); silk witness cord (enforce any oath); monsoon mirror (reflects hidden intentions, one use).

## Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Vigil Lantern** — A small oil lamp with a green flame. Gain +1 die to social rolls in any Lethai-ar court. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The flame flickers when someone lies. It also flickers when you lie.*
3. **Silk Witness Cord (Crimson)** — A braided cord dyed with river mud. Use it to enforce any oath. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The cord tightens when the oath is broken. It will not stop until blood is drawn or the promise is kept.*
4. **Monsoon Mirror** — A polished brass disc. Reflects hidden intentions for one scene. ‘[TRUTH]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *Hold it before a speaker. If they lie, the mirror fogs. The fog smells of river water.*
5. **Cord-Maker’s Needle (Bone)** — A needle carved from a river-fish’s spine. Tie a cord without cutting the silk. ‘[CRAFT]’ *The needle can also cut a cord without making a sound. Use once.*

6. **Lamp-Keeper's Ash** — A pouch of ash from the green flame's hearth. Throw it to calm a river-spirit. '[SPIRIT]' *The ash is warm. It glows faintly. The spirit will recognise it.*
  7. **River-Spirit's Tear (Vial)** — A vial of water from the step-pyramid pool. Drink it to recall a forgotten oath. '[MEMORY]' '[TRUTH]' *The water tastes of iron. The memory is painful. The pain is the price.*
  8. **Oath-Broken's Cord (Cut)** — A severed witness cord. Present it to demand a second chance from any Vigil. '[SOCIAL]' '[REDEMPTION]' *The cord will re-tie itself if the demand is just. The sound is a whisper.*
  9. **God-King's Witness Seal** — A golden seal. Commands a Lethai-ar to witness any oath, regardless of price. '[AUTHORITY]' '[SOCIAL]' *The seal is heavy. It was stolen from the king's chamber. He will want it back.*
  10. **Bridge of the Ninth Clause Map** — A chart showing every bridge where contracts can be witnessed. '[TRAVEL]' '[LAW]' *The map is written on silk. The silk is a witness cord. Do not cut it.*
- J **First Cord Fragment (Silk Strand)** — A piece of the mythic First Cord. Touch it to witness any oath without a cord. '[LEGEND]' '[JUSTICE]' *The fragment burns after use. The oath is still binding. The river will remember.*
- Q **Benzaiten's Whisper (Shell)** — A river shell that contains the voice of the river-spirit. '[TRUTH]' '[SPIRIT]' *Once, ask the river one question. The answer will be true. The river will remember the favour.*
- K **The Cut Cord's Ghost (Bottle)** — A ghost of a broken oath sealed in a glass jar. '[DEATH]' '[SOCIAL]' *Release it to haunt an oath-breaker. The ghost will whisper the broken promise until the oath is fulfilled.*
- A **The River's Pardon** — A scroll signed by Benzaiten herself. Voids any oath, any witness cord. '[LEGEND]' '[JUSTICE]' *The scroll is wet. It will never dry. The river will ask for a new oath in exchange.*

## Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (lanterns, cords, mirrors) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **river-omens**—water that flows upstream, a lamp that burns green without oil, a cord that ties itself.

## Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Witness Clause:** Once per session, when you are present for an oath or contract, you may declare yourself a witness. That oath gains +1 DV to break, and if broken, the oath-breaker owes you a personal favour (in addition to any other penalty). The witness cord glows faintly for the duration.
- **Lantern of Attendance:** You carry a small oil lamp (the Vigil lantern). As long as it burns, you cannot be surprised in social situations (the flame flickers when deception begins). If the lamp goes out, you lose this benefit for the scene. Refilling the lamp requires a minor offering (a prayer to Benzaiten, a coin in a river).
- **Silk Favour:** Once per arc, you may offer a witness cord as a token to a faction or NPC. While they hold it, you gain +1 die to all social rolls against them, but they may also call on you to witness one of their own oaths (refusing costs the token and 1 Fatigue).
- **The Ninth Cup Taboo:** In Ayokha, the ninth cup of tea or sake is never poured. Pouring it invites the Hollow to witness the conversation. The Lethai-ar enforce this taboo strictly; a character who pours the ninth cup gains the Hollow's Attention (advance the clock by 1 segment) and must succeed on a Spirit + Resolve test (DV 3) or forget the next minute of conversation.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
  - **Benzaiten** — The Witness. \*The river of words; every oath flows to her.\*
  - **Inari** — The Traveler. \*The fox's ledger; contracts are paths, and paths must be witnessed.\*
  - **The Green Flame** — The Sealed Gate. \*The lamp that never goes out; the threshold between truth and lie.\*
  - **The Ninth Current** — Khemesh. \*The depth beneath the words; the pressure of unspoken promises.\*

## Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Witness Cords and the Covenant (Mykkiel):** The Covenant recognises Lethai-ar witness cords as legally binding. A Vigil may be called to testify in a Covenant court; her cord is admissible as evidence.
- **Silk Cords and the Sidhi (Way of Silk):** Sidhi freedmen sometimes carry Lethai-ar witness cords as proof of emancipation. A cord from a respected Vigil is worth more than a freedman's seal.
- **The River Spirit and the Ukwe (Sekogo):** Benzaiten's river is said to flow from the Ukwe's roots. A Lethai-ar who visits the Ukwe can read the water's memory without a context key.

- **The Ninth Cup and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The Hollow’s Oath-Keepers are attracted to the ninth cup. Aelaerem hedge-keepers never pour a ninth cup in a Lethai-ar’s presence; they pour the ninth cup into the ground instead.

### Lethai-ar Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the River:** Crumble a crust into the current. Ignore the first *River Floods* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Cord:** Tie a single knot in a witness cord before using it. Cancel *Witness Cord Cut* or take –1 die on your next oath (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Lamp:** Whisper a dead Vigil’s name into the green flame. Gain +1 Effect when witnessing an oath this scene, but mark *Obligation* to Benzaiten. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

### Thematic SB Spend Table

#### Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Vigils or river-spirits**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **lamp-keepers or cord-makers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **oath-breakers or the Hollow**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable witness rates**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

#### Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Vigil or wharf-master** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **rising river or lantern failure**.
- **Foe Appears:** An oath-breaker’s **ghost or a rival cord-maker** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

**Serious Trouble (3 SB)**

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Vigils**, **river-spirits**, or **Hollow agents** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**cord cut/lamp out/river changes course**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

**Major Turns (4+ SB)**

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Vigil Lady Suyin**, **River-Spirit**, or **Benzaiten's voice** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**wharf floods/temple cracks/cords tighten everywhere**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

**Region-Specific SB Options**

- **Lethai-ar (Witness Law):** Green flames flicker in unison, cords glow, a river's current reverses.
- **Lethai-ar (Cord Law):** A witness cord tightens without cause, a knot unties itself, a cut cord re-knots.
- **Lethai-ar (River Law):** Water levels rise without rain, a fish speaks a name, the ninth cup pours itself.

**Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)**

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Lantern Glare*.
- **Cut the Cord (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a witness cord is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Flood (Body + Athletics):** On a hit in *River Floods*, you pick who reaches high ground; on a miss, the GM does.

## Boss Seeds (Cord & River)

- **The Cord-Cutter (Nine Broken Oaths)** — *Phases*: Witness Cords Severed → Orchestrated Perjury → Vigil Coup. *Cracks*: re-tie a cut cord, expose a false Vigil, survive a night in the Well of Broken Oaths.
- **The River-Dryer (Benzaiten's Wrath)** — *Phases*: Water Levels Dropping → Procession of Empty Wharves → Flood-Baptism of a Merchant. *Cracks*: relic river water, survivor testimony, the green flame burning without oil.

### Patronage & Power

Among the Lethai-ar of Ayokha, power flows through witness cords, lantern flames, and the memory of the river. A Vigil's authority rests on the number of oaths she has witnessed and never broken. The lamp is the symbol of that authority; a Vigil without a lamp is not a Vigil.

**For the GM:** Power in Lethai-ar society is measured in cords tied, lamps kept lit, and oaths witnessed. Patronage often takes the form of lanterns, witness cords, or mirrors — each tied to a specific Vigil, wharf, or contract. To emphasize the cultural mechanics:

- Use the **Witness Clause** to create social dilemmas: should the party witness an oath that might be broken?
- Enforce the **Lantern of Attendance** — a party member who carries a Vigil lantern gains social advantages but must maintain the flame.
- Let **Silk Favour** be a form of communal currency: a witness cord given to a faction creates a mutual obligation.
- Track the **Ninth Cup Taboo** as a source of Hollow Attention. A single mistake can summon a Oath-Keeper.

In Lethai-ar society, the river forgets nothing — and the witness cord remembers every word.

## Chapter 9

# Lethai-thora of Sihai

*The Silent Ledgers.*

Chen Wei confesses: *“I have stood in the Lethai-thora archive. The scrolls do not rustle. They listen. I asked a keeper for a tax ledger from three centuries ago. She handed it to me without looking. The shelf behind me held the true history of my own grandfather’s death. I did not turn around.”*

The Lethai-thora were once courtiers of a celestial fey realm that spanned the Valewood and the eastern hills. When the old fey courts fell – when the Alder King withdrew and the Hazel Queen sealed her gates – many Lethai-thora fled east. They crossed the mountains with nothing but armfuls of scrolls and the memory of a civilisation that had forgotten how to die. In the fertile river valleys of what would become Sihai, they taught the scattered tribes to write contracts instead of drawing blood, to measure grain instead of stealing it, to record names instead of nursing grudges. Over generations, the tribes became a kingdom, the kingdom became an empire, and the empire became Sihai. The Lethai-thora became its memory. Now they dwell in hidden pavilions, preserving forgotten ledgers that record what the Mandate of Heaven prefers to forget. A Lethai-thora who guards a forbidden truth may find she can no longer recall the colour of her mother’s dress – a small price, she says, for keeping the ledger whole.

*“Never touch a scroll without announcing your lineage. Even a false lineage is better than silence. The scrolls remember who opened them, and they will whisper your name to the Hollow.”*

— Keeper Lian

***What do people eat for breakfast?*** *Rice porridge with dried fish – the fish smoked over fires fed with old scrolls. The smoke smells of forgotten contracts. The porridge is always lukewarm.*

***What does a child learn before they can walk?*** *To read without moving their lips. A child who whispers a secret aloud is sent to sit in the Chamber of the Ninth Scroll until they learn that silence is a shield.*

***What is the first thing you notice about a stranger?*** *Their ink-stained fingers. A Lethai-thora has ink under every fingernail. Clean fingers have never copied a forbidden*

*text. Black-stained fingers have copied too many. Red-stained fingers have copied a death warrant – their own.*

***What is the most common crime?*** *Context key theft – stealing the carved stone that unlocks a scroll’s meaning. The thief is given a blank scroll and told to write their own confession. The scroll fills itself if they lie.*

***What does no one talk about but everyone knows?*** *The Ninth Scroll is not a scroll. It is a memory so dangerous that nine different keepers each sealed a fragment of it in their own minds. When the ninth keeper dies, the memory will be lost forever – or will escape.*

***Where do people go when they die?*** *To the Well of Forgotten Names. Bodies are placed in the well. The well swallows them. The water turns black – the ink of their unwritten secrets.*

***How do you apologize for a serious wrong?*** *You offer a silence – a period of total stillness, no breath, no heartbeat, no word. Timed by a water clock. If you hold the silence for nine drops, you are forgiven. If you break it, you must speak the wrong aloud in the Chamber of the Ninth Scroll.*

***What is the most important festival?*** *The Unrolling of the Ledgers (winter). Once a year, the keepers unroll a single forbidden scroll and read it aloud to each other – but in a whisper, and only the walls hear. The festival ends with all nine keepers drinking ink from a silver cup. The ink is their own memory.*

***What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person?*** *The emperor’s true lineage is recorded on a scroll that no living keeper has opened. It is sealed with a cord tied by the first keeper. The cord has nine knots. The ninth knot is a lie – the emperor’s grandfather was not of the blood. The empire was founded by a concubine’s son.*

## 9.1 Lethai-thora — “The Silent Ledgers of Sihai”

### Quick Reference

**Tagline:** *We do not burn the dangerous scrolls. We bury them on shelves where no one thinks to look. Silence is not emptiness. It is a door that opens only inward.*

**Keeper of the Seventh Gutter (Elite):** “We do not burn the dangerous scrolls. We bury them in plain sight, on shelves where no one thinks to look. The Emperor’s Censor once stood in our archive and asked for a tax ledger. We gave him one. He did not notice the shelf behind him held the true history of his own grandfather’s death. Silence is not emptiness. It is a door that opens only inward.”

**Scroll-Binder (Commoner):** “My grandmother tied this scroll with a silk cord. The cord has nine knots. The ninth knot is a secret she never told me. When I die, I will tie a tenth. Someone will untie it in a century. They will learn why the emperor’s concubine wept on the night of the lantern festival. Some secrets are too heavy for one lifetime.”

**Genre / Mood:** Bureaucratic melancholy, hidden history, silence as power.

**Starting Location:** A hidden pavilion behind a waterfall, where scrolls are stacked to the ceiling and the air is dry as bone. A Keeper of the Seventh Gutter looks up from a brass lamp: “The Emperor’s Quiet Chancellor has sent a messenger. He wants a scroll that does not exist. He wants the truth about his mother’s death. The truth is written in water. It will vanish if we speak it. But you — you are not bound by our silence. Will you carry a memory for us?”

### Theme & Atmosphere

The Lethai-thora were once courtiers of a celestial fey realm that spanned the Valewood and the eastern hills. When the old fey courts fell — when the Alder King withdrew and the Hazel Queen sealed her gates — many Lethai-thora fled east. They crossed the mountains with nothing but armfuls of scrolls and the memory of a civilisation that had forgotten how to die.

In the fertile river valleys of what would become Sihai, they found scattered agrarian tribes fighting over water and silence. The Lethai-thora did not conquer. They taught. They taught the tribes to write contracts instead of drawing blood, to measure grain instead of stealing it, to record debts instead of nursing grudges. Over generations, the tribes became a kingdom, the kingdom became an empire, and the empire became Sihai. The Lethai-thora became its memory.

Now they dwell in hidden pavilions, preserving “forgotten ledgers” that record what the Mandate of Heaven prefers to forget. Their knowledge is a burden: each secret they preserve slowly erases a piece of themselves. An Lethai-thora who guards a forbidden truth may find that she can no longer recall the colour of her mother’s dress — a small price, she says, for keeping the ledger whole. They are no longer fey. They are no longer fully human. They are something in between: scribes of a story that has no ending, archivists of a past that never quite happened.

**What you notice first:** The smell of old parchment and incense. The way scrolls are stacked with their spines facing the wall — so the words cannot see who reads them. The silence when a secret is spoken; even the insects stop chirping.

**The one rule that kills newcomers:** Never touch a scroll without announcing your lineage. Even a false lineage is better than silence. The scrolls remember who opened them, and they will whisper your name to the Hollow.

### Regional Mood: The Weight of the Forgotten

Power here is measured in scrolls sealed, secrets kept, and the length of a silence. The Lethai-thora have no king, no army, no treasury. They have archives, and the archives are their fortress. The Emperor’s Censorate fears them because they cannot audit a secret that has no ink. The Mandate of Heaven is written in public; the Lethai-thora keep the unwritten ledger — the one that records why dynasties fall. They are not rebels; they are witnesses. And a witness who never speaks is the most dangerous kind.

### The Fledging of the Empire (Origin Story)

When the Valewood’s fey courts crumbled, a caravan of Lethai-thora refugees crossed the eastern passes. Their scrolls were water-stained, their children hungry, their memories already fraying. They found a patchwork of warring clans along the Sihon River — farmers who fought over silt, herders who stole each other’s sheep, chieftains who could not agree on a name for the season.

The Lethai-thora did not offer swords. They offered ink.

They taught the clans to write their disputes on clay, to seal them with witnesses, to let the record speak instead of the spear. A generation later, the first emperor rose — a man who had learned his letters from a Lethai-thora tutor. He did not forget. He built his capital around the Lethai-thora archive, and he decreed that no law could be written without a copy placed in their care.

The Lethai-thora have been part of Sihai ever since — embedded so deeply that they can no longer imagine leaving, even if they wanted to. They are the empire’s memory, but also its conscience, its secret-keeper, and its silent judge. Some among them resent this entanglement; they dream of returning to the Valewood, of hearing the old songs again. But the Valewood has changed. The fey courts do not answer. And the Lethai-thora have become something they never intended: the architects of a mortal empire.

## Prominent NPCs of the Lethai-thora

| <small>p0.2</small>           | <small>p0.25</small>            | <small>p0.3</small>                                           | <small>p0.15</small>                                                               |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Name                          | Role/Title                      | Motivation                                                    | Rumoured Quirk                                                                     |
| Keeper Lian                   | Master of the Seventh Gutter    | Preserve the true history of the emperor’s grandfather        | She has not spoken aloud in twenty years. She writes on water.                     |
| Scribe Wei                    | Scroll-binder                   | Tie a secret so tightly it can never be untied                | He has forgotten his own name. He signs his work with a thumbprint.                |
| Ink-Maker Hana                | Forger of context keys          | Create inks that reveal different truths in different seasons | She has a jar of ink made from crushed moonstones. It only writes during eclipses. |
| The Quiet Chancellor          | Imperial censor (secret ally)   | Find the scroll that proves the emperor’s claim is false      | He speaks in couplets; the second couplet is always a bribe.                       |
| The Ghost of the Ninth Scroll | A memory that was never written | A secret that killed its keeper before it could be recorded   | It appears as a blank scroll that weeps ink. The ink is the secret.                |

## Names of the Lethai-thora

Inspired by the central kingdom traditions: soft consonants, vowel endings, honorifics. Surnames denote an archive, a gutter, or a lineage.

| <small>p0.25</small> | <small>p0.25</small> | <small>p0.2</small> | <small>p0.2</small>    |
|----------------------|----------------------|---------------------|------------------------|
| First Names (Male)   | First Names (Female) | Clan/House          | Epithets               |
| Lian                 | Hana                 | Seventh Gutter      | <i>the Silent</i>      |
| Wei                  | Mira                 | Forbidden Archive   | <i>the Unwitnessed</i> |
| Chen                 | Nuan                 | Ink-Thread          | <i>Ninth Scroll</i>    |

Jin Yue Water-Pavilion *the Forgetful*

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Kael Sora Root-Memory *the Context-Keeper*

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**(Archive/Chamber/Shrine)** A hidden pavilion with scrolls stacked to the ceiling; a brass lamp that never goes out; a shrine to the forgotten gods, covered in dust.

## Spades — Places

2. **Hidden Pavilion (Waterfall)** — An archive behind a curtain of falling water. *The water muffles sound. Secrets spoken here cannot be overheard — but the water remembers.* ‘[SECRECY]’
3. **Chamber of the Ninth Scroll** — A locked room with a single blank scroll on a pedestal. *The scroll is not blank. It is written in disappearing ink. The reagent is moonlight.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
4. **Well of Forgotten Names** — A stone well where the Lethai-thora throw scrolls that are too dangerous to keep. *The well is bottomless. The scrolls burn as they fall. The smoke forms faces.* ‘[DEATH]’
5. **Ink-Maker’s Studio** — A cave with grinding stones and jars of pigment. *The ink is made from crushed beetles, iron ore, and tears. The tears are the ink-maker’s own.* ‘[CRAFT]’
6. **Silent Scriptorium** — A hall where scribes copy scrolls without speaking. *They write with their left hands. Their right hands are for swearing oaths.* ‘[LABOR]’
7. **Context Key Archive** — A vault of stones, each carved with a season and a place. *A scroll cannot be read without the correct context key. The keys are scattered across Sihai.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
8. **Emperor’s Censorate (Monitoring Station)** — A building near the archive, staffed by imperial spies. *They pretend not to know about the hidden pavilion. The Lethai-thora pretend not to notice them.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
9. **Bridge of Unspoken Names** — A stone arch where the Lethai-thora whisper secrets to the river. *The river carries the secrets to the sea. The sea does not tell.* ‘[RITUAL]’
10. **Shrine of the Silent Gods** — A ruined temple where the old fey beings were once worshipped. *The gods are not dead. They are waiting. The Lethai-thora leave offerings of ink.* ‘[LEGEND]’
- J **The Forgotten Ledger’s Vault** — A subterranean room with a single iron door. *The door has nine locks. The keys are held by nine different keepers. The ninth keeper is dead.* ‘[SECRECY]’

- Q Memory-Thread Chamber** — A room where Lethai-thora weave their hair into cords. *Each thread contains a memory. Cutting a thread releases the memory — and kills the keeper.* ‘[DEATH]’
- K The Emperor’s Secret Archive (Hidden)** — A duplicate archive built by a paranoid emperor. *It contains the same scrolls as the Lethai-thora’s, plus the emperor’s own confessions.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A The First Pavilion (Myth)** — Where the first Lethai-thora hid the first forbidden scroll. *It is said to be invisible. Only those who have forgotten nine names can see it.* ‘[LEGEND]’

**(Keeper/Scribe/Chancellor)** Keeper Lian with a brass lamp; Scribe Wei with ink-stained fingers; the Quiet Chancellor with a sealed letter.

## Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Keeper of the Seventh Gutter** — Old, silent, writing on water with a reed brush. *“The words vanish,” she says. “That is how I know they are true.”* ‘[JUSTICE]’
3. **Scroll-Binder (Wei)** — A man with no shadow. He lost it to a scroll that ate his reflection. *He ties silk cords around each scroll. The knots are the secrets.* ‘[CRAFT]’
4. **Ink-Maker (Hana)** — A woman with stained hands and a jar of moonstone ink. *“This ink only writes during an eclipse,” she says. “The next eclipse is in nine days.”* ‘[MAGIC]’
5. **Quiet Chancellor** — An imperial censor in grey robes. He speaks in couplets. *The first couplet is a greeting. The second is a threat. The third is a bribe.* ‘[POLITICS]’
6. **Memory-Weaver** — A woman with a loom made of human hair. She weaves memories into cloth. *The cloth is soft. It whispers the memory when you touch it.* ‘[ART]’
7. **Imperial Spy (Undercover)** — A young man posing as a scribe. He has a hidden seal. *He is looking for a scroll that names the emperor’s true father. He will pay.* ‘[DECEPTION]’
8. **Ghost of the Ninth Scroll** — A blank scroll that floats through the archive at midnight. *It weeps ink. The ink forms words. The words are a secret that killed its keeper.* ‘[DEATH]’
9. **Forbidden Scholar** — A monk who was excommunicated for reading a scroll he should not have. *His eyes are gone. He reads by touch. The scrolls burn his fingers.* ‘[TRAGEDY]’
10. **Silent Guard** — A warrior who took a vow of silence to protect the archive. *He communicates by writing on his own skin. His skin is full of scars.* ‘[COMBAT]’

- J The First Keeper (Ghost)** — A translucent figure in scholar’s robes, seen at the well. *She asks: “What secret do you wish to forget?” The answer becomes a scroll.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
- Q The Censorate’s Interrogator** — A man with a brass scale. He weighs truth and lies. *His scale is balanced. He has never found a truth heavy enough.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K The Emperor’s Dreamer** — A woman who dreams the emperor’s nightmares. She knows what he fears. *She is kept in a locked room. The Lethai-thora want to free her.* ‘[MAGIC]’
- A The Forgotten God’s Echo** — A voice from the ruined shrine. It speaks in a language no one understands. *The Lethai-thora say it is the last fey being. It is asking for a memory.* ‘[LEGEND]’

**(Scroll/Forgery/Witness)** A scroll is found to be a forgery — the party is blamed; a context key is missing — the scroll cannot be read; the Quiet Chancellor demands a witness to a secret.

## Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Forged Scroll** — A tax ledger is discovered to be a fake. The forgery is perfect. ‘[DECEPTION]’ *The forger is a Lethai-thora. The scroll is not a forgery — it is the original. The empire’s copy is wrong.*
3. **Missing Context Key** — A scroll cannot be read without a specific stone. The stone is lost. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The stone was stolen by the Censorate. They want to destroy the scroll.*
4. **Witness Demanded** — The Quiet Chancellor asks the party to witness a secret exchange. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *If they agree, they become bound by the Lethai-thora’s silence. If they refuse, they are exiled from the archive.*
5. **Archive Fire (Accident)** — A lamp falls. Scrolls burn. The smoke forms names. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The names are those of the keepers. One is yours.*
6. **Censorate Raid** — Imperial inspectors arrive with a warrant. They have a list of forbidden scrolls. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The list is accurate. Someone inside the archive is a spy.*
7. **Memory-Thread Cut** — A keeper’s memory-thread is severed. She forgets everything. ‘[DEATH]’ *The thread was cut by an assassin. The assassin wants a secret only she knew.*
8. **Silence Broken** — A keeper speaks aloud for the first time in decades. The Hollow hears. ‘[DEATH]’ *The Hollow sends a Oath-Keeper. The Oath-Keeper asks: “What did you say?”*

9. **Ink of Truth (Forced Confession)** — Someone poisons the ink well. Writing with it forces you to confess. '[MAGIC]' *The poison was placed by the Censorate. They want to know where the forbidden scroll is.*
10. **Emperor's Death (Succession Crisis)** — The emperor dies. The Mandate wavers. The archive is vulnerable. '[POLITICS]' *The new emperor will burn the scrolls. The Lethai-thora must hide them — or die.*
- J **Ghost of the Ninth Scroll Awakens** — The blank scroll fills with ink. The ink is a name. '[DEATH]' *The name is the next person to die. The name is yours.*
- Q **The First Pavilion Appears** — The mythic archive manifests. It is invisible to most. The party can see it. '[MYSTERY]' *They are now witnesses to a secret that has been hidden for a thousand years. The Hollow will want it.*
- K **Censorate's Interrogation** — The party is arrested and brought before the brass scale. '[AUTHORITY]' *The interrogator asks one question: "What did the Lethai-thora tell you?" The scale will know if you lie.*
- A **The Forgotten God Wakes** — The voice from the shrine becomes a scream. The ground shakes. '[LEGEND]' *The god wants its memory back. The memory is held in a scroll. The scroll is the Ninth Scroll.*

(**Scroll/Stone/Cord**) Forbidden scroll (one truth no one wants spoken); context key stone (unlocks one scroll's meaning); memory-thread (a cord containing a secret).

## Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Forbidden Scroll** — A scroll sealed with silk cord. It contains one truth no one wants spoken. '[TRUTH]' *Read it aloud, and the secret becomes known. The speaker will be hunted.*
3. **Context Key Stone** — A carved stone. Unlocks the meaning of one specific scroll. '[TRAVEL]' *The stone is warm. It glows when held near the correct scroll.*
4. **Memory-Thread (Silk Cord)** — A cord woven from a keeper's hair. Cut it to release a memory. '[MEMORY]' *The memory is a secret. The keeper will forget it. The cutter will remember it.*
5. **Ink-Stone (Moonstone)** — A jar of ink made from crushed moonstones. Writes only during eclipses. '[MAGIC]' *The ink reveals truths that cannot be spoken. Use it to write a secret that will last.*
6. **Silence Token (Brass)** — A small brass charm. Present it to demand a moment of silence in any court. '[SOCIAL]' *During the silence, no one can lie. The truth will echo.*

7. **Keeper's Lamp** — A brass lamp that never goes out. The flame flickers when a lie is spoken nearby. '[JUSTICE]' *The lamp also flickers when a secret is hidden in the room.*
  8. **Quiet Chancellor's Seal** — A jade seal. Press it to any document to grant it imperial immunity from censorship. '[AUTHORITY]' *The seal is a forgery. The Chancellor made it himself. It still works.*
  9. **Scroll of Forgotten Names** — A scroll that lists the names of everyone who has been erased from history. '[TRUTH]' *Speak a name, and that person's deeds become known. The Hollow will remember them too.*
  10. **Ink-Maker's Grinding Stone** — A stone bowl. Grind any pigment into ink that writes the truth. '[CRAFT]' *The truth cannot be erased. The ink will burn through lies.*
- J **Ghost's Tear (Vial)** — A vial of ink wept by the Ghost of the Ninth Scroll. '[DEATH]' *Write a name with it, and that person will forget one secret. The secret is your choice.*
- Q **First Pavilion's Key (Invisible)** — An invisible key that opens the mythic archive. '[LEGEND]' *You cannot see the key. You can feel it. It is cold.*
- K **Emperor's Nightmare (Scroll)** — A scroll containing the emperor's most feared secret. '[TRUTH]' *Read it aloud to make the emperor confess — or to drive him mad.*
- A **Forgotten God's Memory (Glass Shard)** — A piece of green glass that hums. It contains a fragment of a fey god's memory. '[LEGEND]' *Once, touch it to learn a secret of the old world. The secret will cost a memory of equal weight.*

## Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (scrolls, stones, threads) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **ink-omens**—scrolls that rustle in still air, a lamp that burns green, a forgotten name whispered from a shelf.

## Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Silence as Sanctuary:** Once per scene, when asked a direct question, a character may answer with a silence. That silence counts as a successful Deception roll against any attempt to extract the truth — but the GM gains 1 Story Beat (the silence has weight). In Lethai-thora halls, a silence is worth more than a thousand words.

- **Context Keys:** To read an old text or recall a forbidden history, you need three keys: place, season, and witness. Without all three, roll at disadvantage. A Lethai-thora may create a temporary Context Key by spending 1 Boon and describing a small ritual (lighting incense, touching a stone, speaking a name).
- **The Keeper's Toll:** When using a Lethai-thora Rite or consulting a hidden archive, mark 1 Fatigue. The knowledge costs something — a moment of warmth, a pleasant memory, the scent of rain. Some keepers have forgotten how to smile.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
  - **The Unwritten** — The Witness. \*A secret that never needs to be spoken.\*
  - **The Quiet Scale** — Mykkiel. \*The law that weighs silence as heavily as testimony.\*
  - **The Ink Father** — Maelstraeus. \*The debt written in disappearing ink; the interest that accrues in forgetting.\*
  - **The Echo of the First Pavilion** — The Traveler. \*The path that leads only inward.\*

### Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Ninth Scroll and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The Ninth Scroll is said to describe the creation of the amulet — and the demon sealed within. The Veiled Sisters have been searching for it for centuries. The Lethai-thora have hidden it in plain sight.
- **Silence Tokens and the Covenant (Mykkiel):** The Covenant recognises a Lethai-thora silence token as a valid request for a closed hearing. A silence token can pause any court proceeding for the duration of a single breath.
- **Context Keys and the Ukwe (Sekogo):** The Ukwe's roots are a natural context key — they remember the season, the place, and the witness. A Lethai-thora who consults the Ukwe does not need to spend a Boon.
- **Memory-Threads and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The Hollow feeds on forgotten memories. A Lethai-thora's memory-thread is a feast. The Oath-Keepers will cut a thread if given the chance.
- **The Fledging of the Empire (Sihai):** The Lethai-thora's oldest scrolls still bear the water stains of the Valewood crossing. A keeper who unrolls one of these scrolls may glimpse a memory of the old fey courts — but the glimpse costs a year of her life.

### Lethai-thora Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Archive:** Crumble a crust at the threshold. Ignore the first *Archive Fire* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'

- **Knot the Scroll:** Tie a single knot in a silk cord. Cancel *Forged Scroll* or take -1 die on your next forgery detection roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead keeper’s name into the well. Gain +1 Effect when recalling a forgotten fact this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Lethai-thora. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

## Thematic SB Spend Table

### Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Censorate spies or imperial guards**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **scribes or keepers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **memory-hunters or the Hollow**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or access to an archive**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

### Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local keeper or Censorate agent** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **flickering lamp or silent alarm**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **Censorate interrogator or a Oath-Keeper** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

### Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Censorate agents, imperial guards, or Hollow spirits** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**scroll burns/thread cut/pavilion appears**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

### Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: High Keeper, Quiet Chancellor, or Ghost of the Ninth Scroll** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**archive floods/well overflows/first pavilion materialises**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

### Region-Specific SB Options

- **Lethai-thora (Silence Law):** Lamps flicker without breeze, scrolls shuffle their own order, a whisper is heard from a sealed jar.
- **Lethai-thora (Memory Law):** A keeper forgets your face, a memory-thread glows, you recall a fact you never learned.
- **Lethai-thora (Context Law):** The season changes inexplicably, a stone context key warms, a witness appears who was not there.

### Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Silent Step*.
- **Cut the Memory (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a memory-thread is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Interrogation (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Censorate's Interrogation*, you pick who is questioned; on a miss, the GM does.

### Boss Seeds (Ink & Silence)

- **The Scroll-Eater (Nine Forgeries)** — *Phases:* Scrolls Burned → Orchestrated Erasure → Archive Coup. *Cracks:* recover a true scroll, expose a false context key, survive a night in the well.
- **The Forgotten God (Memory Eater)** — *Phases:* Voices from the Shrine → Procession of Blank Scrolls → Ink-Baptism of a Keeper. *Cracks:* relic memory-thread, survivor testimony, the first pavilion opening its doors.

## Patronage &amp; Power

Among the Lethai-thora, power flows through silence, ink, and the weight of a forgotten secret. A Keeper's authority rests on how many secrets she has buried and how many she has forgotten. The archive is the fortress; the silence is the shield. Yet they are also entangled with the empire they helped create — the Censorate watches them, the Emperor needs them, and the common people fear them. The Lethai-thora can no longer leave Sihai, even if they wished. Their fate is bound to the Mandate of Heaven.

**For the GM:** Power in Lethai-thora society is measured in scrolls sealed, context keys held, and the length of a pause. Patronage often takes the form of forbidden scrolls, context stones, or memory-threads — each tied to a specific secret, archive, or keeper. To emphasise the entangled relationship with Sihai:

- Use the **Silence as Sanctuary** mechanic to create tense social scenes where a pause is a weapon.
- Require **Context Keys** to unlock ancient lore — the party must gather place, season, and witness before a scroll can be read.
- Let the **Keeper's Toll** be a meaningful cost: fatigue, lost memories, or forgotten faces.
- Remind players that the Lethai-thora are not outsiders; they are the empire's conscience. A Lethai-thora NPC may hold a secret about a PC's family, or about the true cause of a war, or about a crime the emperor himself committed.

In Lethai-thora society, the ink forgets nothing — and the silence remembers everything.

# Appendix A

## The Seven Bell Court

*Form, Spirit, Intent – the three pillars of honourable contest.*

The Seven Bell Court is a neutral Ayokhan judiciary that evaluates duels, tournaments, ritual competitions, and even legal disputes. Its name comes from the seven bells rung before a contest – each bell representing a virtue. A panel of judges scores each exchange.

### Judges' Scorecard

|                                                                                                                          | l                 | c            | c                                  | c        |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|--------------|------------------------------------|----------|
|                                                                                                                          | Category          | 0 Points     | 1 Point                            | 2 Points |
| <b>Form</b>                                                                                                              | Sloppy, reckless  | Competent    | Exemplary technique, discipline    |          |
| <b>Spirit</b>                                                                                                            | Cruelty, dishonor | Restraint    | Mercy, respect, cultural resonance |          |
| <b>Intent</b>                                                                                                            | Selfish motive    | Neutral duty | Protection of others, justice      |          |
| A fighter may lose physically yet win socially. PCs may influence one category per scene via ritual, oath, or testimony. |                   |              |                                    |          |

### Earning Bells (Court Favour)

- Respectful testimony or proper ritual → +1 Bell
- Clear evidence with unbroken custody → +1 Bell
- Public act of mercy or restraint → +1 Bell

3 Bells allow a PC to overturn any one corrupt decision or expose a falsified verdict.

### Using the Seven Bell Court in Play

The GM may invoke the Court whenever a contest's outcome should reflect honour, not just harm. Typical uses:

- Tournaments and duels of honour.

- Trial by combat with legal stakes.
- Ritual poetry or dance competitions.
- Diplomatic exhibitions where face matters more than victory.

### Crowd Mood Track [6]

0–2: Curious admiration; cheers, ritual silence. 3–4: Partisan chants; thrown petals; accusations of bias. 5: Projectiles, panic, scuffles; Position –1 on all social checks in the ring. 6: Riot or stampede: duel halted, collateral harm.

*Influencing the Crowd:*

- Respectful bow, ritual, poetic challenge → Crowd –1
- Public mercy or restraint → Crowd –1
- Brutality, insults, cheating → Crowd +1

# Appendix B

## Equipment of the Eastern Realms

*Tools that carry meaning, not just metal.*

This appendix presents items suitable for contemplative, ritual, or morally weighted adventures. Each is defined by TAGS (keywords) that describe its narrative and mechanical effects.

### Bridge-Walker's Staff

*A walking staff carved from wood that grew on sacred ground.* **TAGS:** [WARD] [MEMORY] [STABILITY] **Effects:** +1d to Survival and Insight in spirit realms; [WARD] vs. Cap 2 spirits; once per scene ask one question about a location's history; +1 Position on precarious crossings.

### Truth-Teller's Mirror

*A polished bronze mirror that reflects intention, not appearance.* **TAGS:** [REVEAL] [PURIFY] [BIND] **Effects:** Roll vs. DV 3 to expose deception; remove minor [CURSE] or [CORRUPTION]; two willing parties may swear a truth-oath – breaking it costs Harm 1.

### Mercy-Bearer's Bowl

*A wooden bowl that never empties when compassion is sincere.* **TAGS:** [HEAL] [CLEANSE] [SHARE] **Effects:** Heal minor Harm or one Condition once per scene; remove one level of [FEAR] or [SHAME]; share any beneficial effect among multiple recipients.

### The Meteor Hammer of Remembrance

*A chain and weight forged from fallen stars; each link bears a name.* **TAGS:** [BIND] [FORCE] [MEMORY] [AREA] **Effects:** Sweep attack vs. multiple foes (Harm 1 each). May restrain a target (break DV 3, or 4 if the wielder invokes a named life). After 10 lives are consciously protected, the weapon gains +1 Effect. Breaking an unjust bond causes Harm 1 to the wielder.

## The Scholar's Quill of Truth

*Ink flows only for honest words.* **TAGS:** [SCRIBE] [REVEAL] [BIND] [WARD] **Effects:** Records gain [WARD] vs. alteration. Hidden clauses or lost text become visible when traced. Contracts written are magically enforceable if witnessed. Cannot write deliberate falsehoods – the nib locks.

## The Diplomat's Fan of Seasons

*What was, what is, and what might be.* **TAGS:** [VEIL] [REVEAL] [SANCTIFY] [COMMAND] **Effects:** Veils the wielder's intentions during negotiation. Shows one plausible outcome of the current debate. Creates neutral ground acceptable to all parties present. Once per scene, issue an order consistent with the revealed truth.

## Three-Culture Prayer Beads

*One strand in harmony: Sihai, Nihori, Ayokha.* **TAGS:** [WARD] [HEAL] [GUIDE] [SANCTIFY] **Effects:** Advantage vs. spiritual threats of the three cultures. Recover 1 Fatigue or minor Harm via meditation. +1d to cross-cultural understanding or etiquette. Creates neutral ground acceptable to all three traditions.

## Memory Keeper's Robe

*Threads woven with emotional weight.* **TAGS:** [WARD] [MEMORY] [VEIL] [PURIFY] **Effects:** Protects the wearer from [FEAR] or [DESPAIR]. Recall exact words or emotions from preserved moments. Conceals the wearer's present emotional state. Remove one level of [CORRUPTION] or [CURSE] by sacrificing a memory woven into the garment.

## Compass of Consequences

*Points toward choices of greatest moral weight.* **TAGS:** [GUIDE] [REVEAL] [COMMAND] [BIND] **Effects:** Always indicates the path with greatest consequence. Shows likely outcomes of following or ignoring guidance. Compels acknowledgement of moral implications. Ignoring the compass knowingly causes [CORRUPTION].

## TAG Legend

WARD – Protects, deflects, or resists hostile spiritual/mental forces.

MEMORY – Recalls, records, or reveals past intent/context.

STABILITY – Improves footing, balance, composure; grants Position.

REVEAL – Exposes truth, intent, or hidden states.

PURIFY – Removes taint, minor corruption, curses, or emotional toxins.

BIND – Creates oaths, restraints, empathic links, or enforceable contracts.

HEAL – Recovers minor Harm, Conditions, or Fatigue.

CLEANSE – Eases specific afflictions ([Fear], [Shame]).

SHARE – Distributes effects across willing targets.

FORCE – Direct physical impact; adds Harm.

AREA – Affects multiple targets or a zone.

VEIL – Obscures intent, aura, or presence.

SANCTIFY – Establishes neutral/sacred ground.

COMMAND – Issues binding directives aligned with ritual, truth, or mandate.

GUIDE – Points toward destinations, truths, or consequential choices.

SCRIBE – Writes immutable records or reveals textual truth.

# Epilogue: The Ninth Scroll

I have written eight scrolls for this book. The ninth is still blank.

The Censorate will ask why. I will tell them that the ninth scroll is reserved for a truth I have not yet witnessed. They will not believe me. They will audit my accounts, inspect my seals, and count the strokes of every character.

Let them.

The road is east. The ink is fresh. The Hollow is patient.

— *Chen Wei, at a weigh-house in the Sihai capital, under a lamp that has just flickered for the eighth time*

*“The ledger is a tool. The story is the truth. Do not confuse them.”*

— Dusana of the Raven Road (marginal note, found in a Pereshi fire-temple)

# Colophon

This book was written on paper that had been a cargo manifest, a love letter, and a bandage. The ink is lampblack cut with salt water and the ash of a burnt confession. The binding is grey cord tied with nine knots. The ninth knot is not cut.

Chen Wei composed the preface in a weigh-house while an auditor counted his brush-strokes. The almanacs were gathered from clerks, spirits, and the occasional honest scholar. The generator tables were tested in the field – meaning he ran them while a Censorate spy took notes.

If you find yourself in the Eastern Realms and a provincial censor offers you tea, accept it. If they offer you a quill, decline politely. Some commissions are not worth the seal.

The road is a ledger – but only if you forget the stories.